

**ACCOUNTS OF THE TRANSMISSION OF THE DHARMA
TREASURY**

BDK English Tripiṭaka Series

**ACCOUNTS OF THE TRANSMISSION
OF THE DHARMA TREASURY**

(Taishō Volume 50, Number 2058)

AI-Assisted Translation from the Chinese

by

Dan Zigmond

**Numata Center
for Buddhist Translation and Research**

2026

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A Message on the Publication of the English Tripiṭaka

The Buddhist canon is said to contain eighty-four thousand different teachings. I believe that this is because the Buddha's basic approach was to prescribe a different treatment for every spiritual ailment, much as a doctor prescribes a different medicine for every medical ailment. Thus his teachings were always appropriate for the particular suffering individual and for the time at which the teaching was given, and over the ages not one of his prescriptions has failed to relieve the suffering to which it was addressed.

Ever since the Buddha's Great Demise over twenty-five hundred years ago, his message of wisdom and compassion has spread throughout the world. Yet no one has ever attempted to translate the entire Buddhist canon into English throughout the history of Japan. It is my greatest wish to see this done and to make the translations available to the many English-speaking people who have never had the opportunity to learn about the Buddha's teachings.

Of course, it would be impossible to translate all of the Buddha's eighty-four thousand teachings in a few years. I have, therefore, had one hundred thirty-nine of the scriptural texts in the prodigious Taishō edition of the Chinese Buddhist canon selected for inclusion in the First Series of this translation project.

It is in the nature of this undertaking that the results are bound to be criticized. Nonetheless, I am convinced that unless someone takes it upon himself or herself to initiate this project, it will never be done. At the same time, I hope that an improved, revised edition will appear in the future.

It is most gratifying that, thanks to the efforts of more than a hundred Buddhist scholars from the East and the West, this monumental project has finally gotten off the ground. May the rays of the Wisdom of the Compassionate One reach each and every person in the world.

August 7, 1991

NUMATA Yehan
Founder of the English
Tripiṭaka Project

Editorial Foreword

In January 1982, Dr. NUMATA Yehan, the founder of the Bukkyō Dendō Kyōkai (Society for the Promotion of Buddhism), decided to begin the monumental task of translating the complete Taishō edition of the Chinese Tripiṭaka (Buddhist canon) into the English language. Under his leadership, a special preparatory committee was organized in April 1982. By July of the same year, the Translation Committee of the English Tripiṭaka was officially convened.

The initial Committee consisted of the following members: (late) HANAYAMA Shōyū (Chairperson), (late) BANDŌ Shōjun, ISHIGAMI Zennō, (late) KAMATA Shigeo, KANAOKA Shūyū, MAYEDA Sengaku, NARA Yasuaki, (late) SAYEKI Shinkō, (late) SHIOIRI Ryōtatsu, TAMARU Noriyoshi, (late) TAMURA Kwansei, URYŪZU Ryūshin, and YUYAMA Akira. Assistant members of the Committee were as follows: KANAZAWA Atsushi, WATANABE Shōgo, Rolf Giebel of New Zealand, and Rudy Smet of Belgium.

After holding planning meetings on a monthly basis, the Committee selected one hundred thirty-nine texts for the First Series of translations, an estimated one hundred printed volumes in all. The texts selected are not necessarily limited to those originally written in India but also include works written or composed in China and Japan. While the publication of the First Series proceeds, the texts for the Second Series will be selected from among the remaining works; this process will continue until all the texts, in Japanese as well as in Chinese, have been published.

Frankly speaking, it will take perhaps one hundred years or more to accomplish the English translation of the complete Chinese and Japanese texts, for they consist of thousands of works. Nevertheless, as Dr. NUMATA wished, it is the sincere hope of the Committee that this project will continue unto completion, even after all its present members have passed away.

It must be mentioned here that the final object of this project is not academic fulfillment but the transmission of the teaching of the Buddha to the whole world in order to create harmony and peace among humankind. To that end, the translators have been asked to minimize the use of explanatory notes of the kind that are indispensable in academic texts, so that the attention of general readers will not be unduly distracted from the primary text. Also, a glossary of selected terms is appended to aid in understanding the text.

MAYEDA Sengaku
Chairperson
Editorial Committee of
the BDK English Tripiṭaka

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Translator's Introduction

The Text and Its Significance

The *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* (付法藏因緣傳, “Accounts of the Transmission of the Dharma Treasury”) is a fifth-century Chinese narrative that traces the transmission of the Buddhist Dharma through a lineage of twenty-three Indian patriarchs, from Mahākāśyapa, the Buddha’s senior disciple, to Śiṃha Bhikṣu, whose martyrdom in Kashmir brought the Indian transmission to its dramatic close. Preserved in the Taishō Tripiṭaka as text number 2058 (volume 50), it has never before been translated into English.

The text occupies a unique position in the history of East Asian Buddhism. It is the earliest surviving Chinese account of a continuous patriarchal lineage extending from the Buddha himself, and as such it provided the conceptual foundation for the transmission narratives that would become central to the Chan (Zen) tradition. The *Jingde Chuandenglu* (景德傳燈錄, “Jingde Era Record of the Transmission of the Lamp”), the foundational lamp-transmission history of the Chan school compiled in the early eleventh century, drew on the *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* (among other sources) for its Indian patriarch narratives, expanding the lineage from twenty-three to twenty-eight figures to bridge the gap to Bodhidharma. When Keizan Jōkin later composed his *Denkōroku* (傳光錄, “Record of the Transmission of Light”) in the early fourteenth century, the Indian patriarch stories he recounted descended from this same tradition. In a sense, every Zen lineage chart hanging in every Zen center in the world traces back to the narrative first articulated in this text.

Yet the *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* is not a Zen text. It predates the emergence of Chan as a self-conscious school by some two centuries and belongs instead to the broader tradition of Indian Buddhist

historiography as received and elaborated in China. Its concerns are those of fifth-century Chinese Buddhism: the legitimacy of the monastic order, the proper transmission of the Dharma and Vinaya, the role of royal patronage in sustaining the Sangha, and the ever-present threat of persecution and decline. These themes resonated powerfully in the Northern Wei context in which the text was produced.

The Translators

The text was co-translated by two monks at the Northern Wei court in Pingcheng (modern Datong, Shanxi) around 472 CE.

Tanyao (曇曜) is the more prominent of the two. He served as head of the Buddhist administration (*shamen tong* 沙門統) under the Northern Wei for more than twenty years, and he is best known today as the visionary behind the great rock-cut Buddha images at the Yungang caves (caves 16 through 20), which he conceived as monuments to the first five Northern Wei rulers. Tanyao was instrumental in rebuilding Chinese Buddhism after the devastating persecution of 446, when Emperor Taiwu, under the influence of his chief minister Cui Hao, ordered the destruction of Buddhist monasteries, scriptures, and images throughout the realm. When Emperor Wencheng restored Buddhism in 452, Tanyao led the revival with extraordinary energy, establishing the “Sangha households” and “Buddha households” systems that provided economic support for the monastic order. His translation work, including the *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* and the *Samyuktaratnapitaka Sūtra* (雜寶藏經, T203), should be understood in this context: as part of a comprehensive effort to reestablish the authority and legitimacy of Buddhism in China after a period of near-destruction.

Jikiyaye (吉迦夜), whose Sanskrit name is reconstructed as Kimkara, was a monk from the “Western Regions” (Central Asia). Very little is known about him beyond his collaboration with Tanyao on these two translations. The Taishō edition describes him as a “Tripitaka Master from the Western Regions” (西域三藏), suggesting that he brought the Indian source text or texts to China and provided the oral rendering that Tanyao then put into literary Chinese.

Contents of the Text

The text is organized into six fascicles covering the lives and transmissions of twenty-three patriarchs.

Fascicle One opens with a sweeping account of the Buddha's path to enlightenment, his defeat of Māra, and his years of teaching. The narrative then focuses on the Buddha's deathbed entrustment of the Dharma to Mahākāśyapa, followed by a detailed biography of the first patriarch: his past-life origins as a goldsmith, his marriage to a woman of golden complexion, their mutual vow of celibacy, his encounter with the Buddha, and his role at the funeral and the First Council. The account of Ānanda, the second patriarch, follows with similar richness.

Fascicle Two continues with Ānanda's extraordinary parinirvāṇa (he divides his body among four parties by levitating over the Ganges) and introduces Śāṇakavāsa, the third patriarch, and the beginning of Upagupta's story.

Fascicles Three and Four are dominated by the legend cycle of King Aśoka, whose relationship with the fourth patriarch Upagupta forms one of the text's most vivid narrative sequences. Aśoka's conversion, his distribution of the Buddha's relics, and his construction of eighty-four thousand stūpas are recounted at length, along with his meeting with Upagupta at the sites of the Buddha's life. This material overlaps significantly with the *Aśokāvadāna* (T2042/T2043), though the *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* integrates it into the patriarchal transmission framework.

Fascicle Five moves more swiftly through patriarchs five through thirteen, including the great poet-philosopher Aśvaghōṣa (eleventh patriarch), whose musical composition *Rāṣṭrapāla* moved five hundred princes in Pāṭaliputra to seek ordination, and Nāgārjuna (thirteenth patriarch), the founder of the Mādhyamika school. Each patriarch receives a briefer treatment, but the narrative retains its characteristic blend of biography, miracle, and doctrinal teaching.

Fascicle Six covers the final ten patriarchs, from Āryadeva through Siṃha Bhikṣu. The text concludes with the martyrdom of Siṃha at the hands of a king the text names as Mihirakula, who beheads the twenty-third patriarch. From the wound flows not blood but milk, symbolizing the purity of the Dharma even in its final bearer. The

lineage ends here; the *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* does not extend the transmission to Bodhidharma or any other figure. The later Chan tradition would add five additional patriarchs to bridge this gap, but the present text knows nothing of them.

The Patriarchal Lineage Tradition

The concept of a linear patriarchal succession is not native to Indian Buddhism. The earliest Buddhist texts speak of the Dharma being preserved by the community (Sangha) as a whole, not entrusted to a single successor. The idea that the Buddha's teaching was transmitted through a chain of individual masters appears to have developed in the Sarvāstivāda school in northwestern India, probably in connection with the need to establish the authority of particular Abhidharma lineages. The *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* draws on these Sarvāstivāda sources, particularly the *Abhidharma-mahāvibhāṣā-śāstra* (T1545), which contains many of the same patriarch stories.

Stuart Young's study *Conceiving the Indian Buddhist Patriarchs in China* (2015) has shown how the Chinese reception of this lineage tradition was shaped by indigenous concerns, particularly the Confucian model of legitimate succession (*zhengtong* 正統) and the political need to establish Buddhism's credentials as a tradition with an unbroken line of authority comparable to the imperial succession. The *Fu fazang yinyuan zhuan* served these purposes admirably: it provided Chinese Buddhists with a narrative of institutional continuity stretching back to the Buddha himself.

A Note on the Translation

This translation aims for accuracy, readability, and consistency with BDK English Tripiṭaka conventions. Sanskrit names are given in standard IAST transliteration. Chinese terms are generally translated into English, with the Chinese provided in the glossary. Verse passages (*gāthās*) are rendered as poetry. The Taishō page and column references are provided in the margins for readers who wish to consult the Chinese text.

The translation was produced with the assistance of large language models and should be regarded as a preliminary rendering to support

study and research. It is offered in the hope that it will make this foundational text accessible to English-speaking students of Buddhism for the first time.

ACCOUNTS OF THE TRANSMISSION OF THE DHARMA
TREASURY

Translated from the Chinese

Fascicle One

Long ago, the Bhagavat, for the sake of sentient beings across immeasurable kalpas, sought the most supreme path. He accomplished all manner of difficult and arduous practices, relinquishing his beloved body: head, eyes, marrow, and brain; kingdoms, cities, wives, and children; palaces, ministers, and attendants. He cast himself from cliffs, threw himself into fires, and submitted to the severing of his body. At times, for the sake of a single four-line gāthā, he would flay his own skin for paper, break his bones for a pen, and use his blood as ink to transcribe and make offerings, consulting wise teachers and receiving instruction from all Buddhas. Grieving for the multitude of beings, he labored with humility and accumulated virtue. He cultivated ten thousand wholesome practices and made vast vows. As extensively described in the five hundred Jātaka tales, his foundational practices were complete and he was on the verge of attaining perfect enlightenment.

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Beneath the bodhi tree he sat cross-legged. The demon of the Sixth Heaven was deeply afflicted with anguish, thinking: “If he accomplishes the Way, he will surely surpass me.” Immediately he mustered his retinue of one billion eight hundred million and proceeded to the base of the king of trees, saying to the bodhisattva: “You should rise at once and return to your palace. If you do not, I shall seize your feet and hurl you beyond the great ocean.”

At that time the bodhisattva, like a lion king, felt no alarm or fear in his heart. He declared: “Pāpīyas, you once made offerings to a single pratyekabuddha and observed the eight precepts and fast. Through the merit of that deed you became king of heaven. Yet I have already, across incalculable kalpas, fully accomplished difficult and arduous practices. On this great earth there is not even a spot the size of a needle-point that

is not a place where I formerly practiced austerities. Even if the hosts of Māra were as numerous as the sands of the Ganges, they could not move a single hair of mine. How then do you now propose to hurl my body beyond the great ocean?”

Māra replied: “In the past I gave to a pratyekabuddha and became lord of heaven. This fact can be verified. But what you now claim, who will bear witness to it?”

Thereupon the bodhisattva extended his hand and pointed to the earth, saying: “This spirit knows me.”

At that moment the earth spirit burst forth from the adamant foundation, pressed her palms together, and said: “It is truly as the Honored One teaches. Ever since this earth has existed, I have been its spirit. There is not upon this earth even a spot the size of a needle-point that is not a place where the bodhisattva formerly practiced.”

When Māra heard these words, he toppled over and fell. Having defeated the armies of Māra, the bodhisattva attained the most perfect enlightenment. The three kinds of insight shone forth uniquely; the six supernormal powers were unobstructed. Endowed with great compassion and inexhaustible eloquence, all that he proclaimed, people received with faith. He proclaimed the subtle and wondrous Dharma to rescue sentient beings. Just as a diamond destroys whatever it strikes, so too the teaching gate of the Tathāgata can extinguish the afflictions and bonds of sentient beings. He traveled throughout lands, villages, and cities, using the pure Dharma to extract the poisonous thorns of the multitude. He subdued non-Buddhist teachings and raised the most victorious banner. He closed the gates of evil destinies and opened the path to nirvāṇa.

When his conditions for teaching were nearly exhausted and he was about to enter final extinction, he addressed his great disciple Mahākāśyapa: “You should know that across immeasurable incalculable kalpas, for the sake of sentient beings, I diligently practiced austerities, single-mindedly seeking the unsurpassed and supreme Dharma. The vows I made long ago are now fully fulfilled.

“Kāśyapa, you should know: just as dense clouds fill the entire world and release sweet rain that nourishes and grows the seedlings, so too the rain of the unsurpassed Dharma is just like this, enabling sentient beings to increase their roots of merit. For this reason all Buddhas constantly

guard, protect, revere, praise, bow to, and make offerings to it. Now, as I am about to enter parinirvāṇa, I entrust this profound Dharma to you. Hereafter you should respectfully follow my intent and broadly propagate and disseminate it, never allowing it to be cut off.”

Kāśyapa said: “Excellent! I accept this teaching. I shall uphold the true Dharma in this way, so that beings of future ages may equally receive its abundant benefit. I only pray that the World-Honored One not be troubled by this.”

Therefore, after the Tathāgata’s passing, Mahākāśyapa in turn proclaimed the true teaching, compiled the treasury of the Buddha’s Dharma, and transformed all sentient beings. Those he liberated never again regressed.

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Mahākāśyapa

That great Kāśyapa possessed wisdom vast as the deep. His fame was heard everywhere and his merits were complete. Now, following the proper sequence, his practices and vows shall be recounted.

Long ago, in the distant past, Vipāśyin Buddha, having transformed sentient beings, entered parinirvāṇa. The fourfold assembly of disciples all gave rise to grief and longing. They collected his relics and erected a stūpa of seven treasures, adorned with banners of surpassing beauty.

Within that stūpa there was an image of the Tathāgata whose golden complexion on the face was slightly damaged in places. At that time there was a poor woman who wandered about begging. She obtained a single gold bead, and her heart was filled with joy. She wished to have it beaten into foil to repair the face of the image. Kāśyapa at that time was a goldsmith. The woman went to him and asked him to fashion it. When the goldsmith heard that this was an act of merit, he joyfully worked on it, polishing and decorating it until it was finished, and used it to repair the face of the image. Together the two made a vow, saying: “May we two always be husband and wife, with bodies of true gold, forever receiving the finest bliss.”

Through this causal connection, for ninety-one kalpas their bodies were of true gold. Born among humans and gods, their happiness was without limit. In their final birth they were reborn in the Seventh Brahma Heaven.

At that time, in the kingdom of Magadha, there was a Brahmin named Nyagrodha. Through long cultivation of superior karma in past lives, he was a man of lofty talent and broad learning, with deep and far-reaching wisdom. He was abundantly wealthy beyond measure, possessing gold, silver, lapis lazuli, shells, jade, cattle, sheep, fields, houses, servants, and carriages. Compared to the king of Magadha, his wealth surpassed the king's a thousandfold. At that time King Bimbisāra possessed a thousand golden plows. That Brahmin, fearing that equaling the king's possessions would bring criminal charges upon him, reduced his by one, possessing only nine hundred ninety-nine. His household had fine cloth, the lowest grade of which was worth a hundred thousand gold pieces. If driven in with a nail to a depth of seven feet, the cloth would not tear and remained the same as before. Such was the wealth bestowed by the power of his merit.

Though rich in treasure, he had no sons or heirs. Thinking to himself that he was old and decrepit and the time of death was drawing near, he had no one to whom he could entrust his storehouses and possessions. Beside his dwelling there was a tree spirit in a grove. That Brahmin, seeking a son, went to offer prayers. Years passed with no sign or response whatsoever.

Then Nyagrodha grew greatly angry and said to the tree spirit: "I have served you for years, yet you have not deigned to grant me even one blessing in response. I shall now devote myself wholeheartedly to you for seven days. If there is still no result, I shall surely burn and cut you down."

When the tree spirit heard this, it became deeply anxious and afraid. It went to the Four Heavenly Kings and fully reported the matter. The Four Kings then went and informed Indra. Indra surveyed all of Jambudvīpa but could find no being of sufficient merit fit to become that man's son. He then went to Brahmā and reported the full matter.

At that time Brahmā observed with his divine eye and saw that there was a being in the Brahma Heaven whose life was about to end. He told that being: "If you are to descend for rebirth, you should be born in Jambudvīpa, in the family of that Brahmin."

The Brahma being replied: "The ways of Brahmins are full of evil and wrong views. I am unable to become his son."

Brahmā said again: “That Brahmin possesses great majesty and virtue. No one in Jambudvīpa is worthy to be born there. If you are surely to be born there, I shall protect you. I will absolutely not allow you to fall into wrong views.”

The Brahma being said: “Very well. I respectfully accept the sage’s instruction.”

Thereupon Indra went to the tree spirit and told it of these matters. The tree spirit was delighted and went at once to that household, saying to the Brahmin: “Do not harbor resentment against me any longer. In seven days your wish will be fulfilled.”

When the seven days had passed, the wife realized she was with child. After a full ten months she gave birth to a boy. His features were handsome and his body was of true gold. His radiance blazed brilliantly, illuminating one yojana.

A physiognomist examined him and declared: “This child possesses great merit from past lives and has immense majesty and virtue. His resolve and strength are pure and lofty; he has no attachment to worldly affairs. He will certainly leave home and attain the fruit of non-attachment.”

Though still a young child, his aspirations and thoughts were pure and clean. He practiced compassion and gave generously, was of few desires and knew contentment, and constantly contemplated how worldly pleasures are impermanent and fragile. He never once gave rise to thoughts of fondness or delight.

At that time his parents, seeing him like this, became deeply worried and distressed. They said to each other: “When this child was born, the physiognomist declared that he would certainly leave home. What plan can we now devise to extinguish this intention?” After thinking it over, they concluded: “The only worldly thing that can captivate a person is feminine beauty. We should select for him a beautiful and virtuous wife to change his mind.”

When he reached the age of fifteen, they wished to arrange a marriage for him. When Kāśyapa heard this, he became deeply troubled and said to his parents: “My aspirations are pure. I have no need for a wife.” He said this three times, but his parents would not consent.

Thereupon Kāśyapa, knowing the matter could not be avoided, devised a stratagem and said to his parents: “If you can find for me a woman with a body of golden color and beauty surpassing the world, only then will I open my heart and accept her. If you cannot find such a woman, I will never marry.”

At that time his parents, out of devoted concern for him, did not go against his words. They immediately summoned the Brahmins and dispatched them throughout the land: “If there is any woman with a body of true gold, beautiful and extraordinarily fine, bring her to be betrothed to our son.”

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The Brahmins devised a plan together. They cast a golden figure of surpassing beauty, and together they carried it through the villages, crying aloud: “If any woman, seeing this golden deity, pays homage and makes offerings to it, in the future she will surely obtain subtle wisdom and a body of true gold.”

When the women heard this, they all came out to pay their respects. At that time there was a woman of magnificent appearance and a body of violet-gold. Her nature was gentle and her wisdom was deep and far-reaching. She was none other than the woman of the golden bead from the past. Because of that excellent past connection she possessed this wondrous body. Firm in her resolve, she alone did not go out.

All the women asked her why she would not come out. She answered: “Sisters, my mind is at peace and I have no other wishes. That is why I do not go out.”

Then the women took her by force to see the golden deity. The radiance of this woman, her beauty and grace, outshone the golden figure so that it was no longer visible. The Brahmins arranged the betrothal at once, and the agreement was made with a date set for the wedding.

When the woman heard this, she too was greatly distressed, but unable to follow her own wishes, she proceeded with the marriage. The two sat facing each other, each with a mind settled in purity. Though they were husband and wife, they had no desire whatsoever. Together they established an agreement, saying: “We two should now sleep in separate rooms and not disturb or approach each other.”

When their parents learned of this, they ordered servants to clear out one room and made the couple share the same quarters, emptying the

room so that only a single bed remained. Thereupon Kāśyapa made a further agreement with his wife: “In this room there is only one bed. It is not reasonable for us two to sleep together. When I am resting, you shall walk in meditation. When you are sleeping, I shall walk in meditation.”

Later, during the middle of the night, when it was Kāśyapa’s turn to walk, his wife was sleeping with her hand hanging over the edge of the bed. A poisonous snake entered through the door, intending to bite her. Kāśyapa, out of compassion, gently came forward, wrapped his hand in his robe, and lifted her hand back onto the bed. His wife awoke with a start and rebuked him: “What kind of man are you, so lacking in resolve! We made a vow together never to touch each other. Why have you now secretly lifted my hand?”

Kāśyapa replied: “I had no desire when I came near you. A snake entered from outside, about to bite you. Fearing you would be harmed, I merely lifted your hand, that is all.” The poisonous snake was still there, and he showed it to her. His wife then understood.

From that time on, husband and wife felt deep revulsion toward all conditioned existence and took no pleasure in it, like a person who has been freshly bathed and has no fondness for dust and grime. They went to their parents and asked to leave home. Having received permission, they became śramaṇas, pure and simple in their keeping, free from all action and desire, dwelling in seclusion and diligently practicing austerities.

Then Kāśyapa made this vow: “Whoever in this world has attained arhatship, I take refuge in them all.”

Having spoken these words, his deportment as a renunciant and all the precepts were perfectly complete. Eventually, when the Tathāgata attained omniscience and was proclaiming the wondrous Dharma in the city of Rājagṛha, Kāśyapa, wearing his rag-robles, came to the Buddha’s presence, bowed his head in reverence, pressed his palms together, and stood before the Buddha. He said: “World-Honored One, I now take refuge in the unsurpassed, cool tranquility. I pray that you will compassionately accept me and permit me to take the last place among the assembly.”

The World-Honored One declared: “Welcome, Kāśyapa!” He then divided his seat in half and invited him to sit. Kāśyapa said to the

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Buddha: “I am merely one of the Tathāgata’s lowest-ranked disciples. Though you graciously bid me share your seat, I dare not comply.”

At that time the assembly all had doubts, thinking: “What extraordinary virtue does this old śramaṇa possess, that the Heavenly Honored One would share his seat and invite him?” They concluded: “This man’s excellence is something only the Buddha can know.”

Thereupon the Tathāgata, knowing the doubts in their minds and wishing to resolve them, proclaimed the vast and profound practices of Kāśyapa. The World-Honored One further said: “All the great compassion, the four dhyānas, the three samādhis, and the immeasurable merits with which I adorn myself, the bhikṣu Kāśyapa also possesses in the same way.

“Moreover, long ago in the distant past, there was a holy king named Vandaka whose lofty talent surpassed the world and whose wisdom had no equal. At that time the lord Indra, revering his virtue, dispatched a chariot of seven treasures to his gate to welcome the king. The king rode the celestial chariot and flew through the air. Indra came out to greet him and they sat together. After they had enjoyed each other’s company, Indra escorted the king back to his palace.”

The Buddha told the bhikṣus: “The lord Indra at that time is the present Kāśyapa. The King Vandaka was none other than myself. In the past, Kāśyapa offered me a seat of worldly life and invited me to sit with him. Therefore today, having accomplished the unsurpassed Way, I repay his original merit with the seat of the true Dharma.”

At that time the World-Honored One then taught the Dharma for Kāśyapa in the manner appropriate to him, instructing, demonstrating, benefiting, and gladdening him. Just as a fresh, clean white cloth easily takes dye, right there upon his seat Kāśyapa attained arhatship, with the three kinds of insight, the six supernormal powers, and the eight liberations fully accomplished. Of lofty talent and heroic vigor, his bearing was calm and dignified. He always sat with the Tathāgata and expounded the Dharma together, so that the gods and humans of that time thought him the World-Honored One’s teacher.

Thereupon Kāśyapa took leave of the Tathāgata and went to Ḡḍhrakūṭa Mountain and the Pippala Cave. That mountain had many flowing springs and bathing pools. The groves of trees were luxuriant

and the flowers and fruits flourished. Hundreds of beasts roamed about and auspicious birds soared and sang. Gold, silver, and lapis lazuli were spread upon the ground. There Kāśyapa walked in meditation and contemplation, proclaiming the wondrous Dharma and liberating sentient beings.

Later, when the World-Honored One was about to enter nirvāṇa, a supreme light was emitted and the great earth quaked. Kāśyapa then had this thought: “Could it be that the Tathāgata is about to enter nirvāṇa and manifests these signs?” He entered samādhi and observed with the divine eye, seeing that the World-Honored One, beside the Hiraṇyavati River, had relinquished his entire body and his life. Having observed this, he was stricken with sorrow and displeasure: “How swiftly the Tathāgata has entered nirvāṇa! The eye of the world is extinguished, and unwholesomeness increases.”

Immediately, with his retinue surrounding him before and behind, he set out toward the city of Kuśinagara to pay reverence to the World-Honored One. On the road ahead he encountered a non-Buddhist wanderer holding a mandārava flower in his right hand.

Kāśyapa asked: “Where have you come from? Do you know my teacher?”

He answered: “I do know him. He entered parinirvāṇa seven days ago. All humans and gods have made great offerings. I obtained this flower from there.”

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When the bhikṣus heard these words, they were all overcome with grief and threw their bodies upon the ground. They wailed and wept, choking with tears that fell like rain. Together they cried: “Alas, impermanence has tremendous power! It has destroyed such a treasury of meritorious jewels. It has dried up the ocean of Dharma and toppled the banner of Dharma. The world is plunged into darkness, forever bereft of the great light. All sentient beings have no one to look up to. The evil destinies increase while the gods and humans diminish.

“How strange is impermanence, how deeply should it be loathed! Like a flash of lightning, it cannot last long. The swiftness of impermanence is likewise impossible to hold back. It destroys the prime of life, vigor, and longevity. It annihilates all the world’s joys and loves. The foolish cling to it, but the wise do not.”

Thereupon Kāśyapa and the bhikṣus proceeded onward and arrived between the twin śāla trees. They circumambulated the coffin three times, bowed their heads in reverence, and Kāśyapa spoke this gāthā:

Supreme one who transcended the three realms,
Forever crossing over the stream of birth and death,
Serene and without form or desire,
Subtle and beyond all thought!
The sun of the Buddha shone with utmost purity,
Able to dispel the darkness of delusion.
Through accumulated kalpas of arduous practice,
He vowed to liberate all who suffer.
Why now, at this time,
Has he abandoned his great compassion?
His entire body rests in the golden coffin,
Serene, at peace, and unmoving.
We pray the Honored One of gods and humans
Will reveal his golden body,
So that all beings everywhere
May give rise to immeasurable vows.

At that time, the World-Honored One, from within the golden coffin, through a thousand layers of cloth, extended his golden feet. Their radiance shone like the blazing sun. The coffin and its cloth were undamaged, yet the feet appeared plainly. When the entire great assembly witnessed this, their grief and anguish redoubled, and they wailed and choked with sobs.

Then Kāśyapa bared his right shoulder and touched his forehead to the feet in reverence. He spoke a second gāthā:

The Tathāgata's ankles are rounded and full,
The thousand-spoked wheel marks clearly appear.
His toes are slender, long, and supple,
The webbing between them perfectly formed.
With great compassion he saved all beings,
Severing the bonds of doubt in the world.
Therefore today I bow my head
In homage to the most supreme feet.

I have realized the Four Noble Truths
And spoken of the Buddha's treasury of merit.
Having offered praise and reverence,
May the feet now withdraw and return within.

Then Kāśyapa ordered the strong men to wrap the Buddha's body again with a thousand layers of cloth, pour fragrant oil over it, and close the coffin lid. They piled up sandalwood fuel and cremated the Tathāgata.

Ānanda, seeing the fire, wept bitterly, choking with sobs and wailing in anguish. He spoke this gāthā:

How strange, impermanence! How deeply to be feared!
It can destroy such a treasury of meritorious jewels.
The World-Honored One's body, pure and immaculate,
Now lies in the golden coffin wrapped in a thousand cloths.
Fragrant oil is poured and poured,
And sandalwood fuel is set ablaze.
This subtle and supreme body,
Where has it gone?

Then Kāśyapa extinguished the fire with milk and spoke this gāthā of [299a] praise:

The body was wrapped in a thousand cloths
And cremated in the fire;
Yet by the Buddha's spiritual power,
One inner robe remained, and the outermost was not burned.
Only what lay between was entirely consumed.
This supreme spiritual power is inconceivable!

After Mahākāśyapa spoke this gāthā, he addressed the bhikṣus: "The Buddha has been cremated. The relics of the World-Honored One are not our concern. Why? Kings, elders, great ministers, and householders, seeking the most supreme merit, will make offerings themselves. We should compile the Dharma eye so that the torch of the Dharma will not swiftly be extinguished. For the sake of future ages we should create illumination, continuing and exalting the Three Treasures so that they are never cut off."

At that time Kāśyapa and the bhikṣus went to the Pippala Cave in the city of Rājagṛha. King Ajātaśatru had attained faith without basis, and after the Tathāgata's passing, his ministers consulted together and said: "The great king's faith is like a vast ocean, surpassing all humans, gods, and worlds. If he hears that the World-Honored One has entered nirvāṇa, boiling blood will surely pour from his face, his body will break apart, and his life will not last long. What plan can we devise to spare him this calamity?"

At that time there was a minister named Yuśa, whose wisdom was vast and deep and who was skilled in skillful means. He had a copper pool constructed, several fathoms in length and breadth, and filled it to the brim with pure fragrant oil. He had King Ajātaśatru sit in this pool, and then further had painted on fresh, clean white cloth images of the Tathāgata's life story:

How the bodhisattva, descending from Tuṣita Heaven, transformed into a white elephant and entered his mother's womb. His father was named Śuddhodana, his mother was called Māyā. He dwelt in the womb for a full ten months and was born. Before reaching the ground, Indra received him in his arms. The Nāga King Nanda and Upananda poured water to bathe him. The great yakṣa king Maṇibhadra held a jeweled canopy and attended upon him from behind. The earth spirit manifested flowers to cushion his feet. He walked seven steps in each of the four directions. Upon arriving at the temple, all the images of the deities rose to welcome him. The sage Asita held him and read his physiognomy. After doing so, he was overcome with great sorrow, lamenting that he himself would pass away and not live to see the Buddha's arising. Then the prince went to a teacher to study letters, arts, and prognostication. He dwelt in the inner palace with sixty thousand maidens, delighting in pleasures. He went out from the city to the Kapilavastu gardens. On the road he saw an old man and a śramaṇa. Returning to the palace, he looked upon the maidens and saw their forms and appearances as like dried bones. All the palaces seemed no different from tombs. Filled with disgust, he resolved to leave home. At midnight he crossed over the city walls. He went to the great sages Udraka and Ārāḍa. He heard the teaching of the Sphere of Neither Perception Nor Non-Perception. Having heard it, he examined it deeply and knew it to be impermanent,

suffering, impure, and without self. He abandoned them and went to the foot of a tree, where for six years he practiced austerities. Then he realized that this was merely suffering and could not lead to the Way.

Then he went to the Nairañjanā River and bathed within it. At that time there were two cowherd women who, wishing to make an offering to a deity, milked a thousand cows and fed the milk to five hundred cows. In this manner they continued, halving each time, until finally there was one cow. They took its milk and cooked it into porridge. The porridge rose nine feet high without spilling a single drop.

A Brahmin asked: “Sisters, for whom are you cooking this porridge?”

The women answered: “We are making it as an offering to the tree spirit.”

The Brahmin said: “What deity could receive such food? Only one who, upon eating it, attains omniscience can receive such an offering from you.”

Thereupon the women offered it to the bodhisattva. He accepted it and ate it. Then he proceeded to the bodhi tree. He defeated Māra Pāpīyas and attained the most perfect enlightenment. At Vārāṇasī he first turned the wheel of the Dharma for the five bhikṣus. And so forth, until he came to the city of Kuśinagara, to the land of the Mallas, and entered parinirvāṇa. All these scenes were painted in full.

[299b]

The king asked his ministers: “What have you made?”

They answered: “Great king, we have painted images of the Tathāgata’s meritorious deeds.”

Then they came to the scene of the World-Honored One’s passing and the transformation of his body. The king was startled and alarmed; every hair on his body stood on end. He gave rise to deep grief and longing for the Tathāgata. One-fifth of the oil in the pool suddenly flowed and entered the king’s body, like a dried brick placed in a great pool that naturally absorbs the water. It was just like that. Through this means his life was preserved.

Such was the depth of King Ajātaśatru’s faith and devotion, and such was his longing for the Tathāgata. When he heard that Kāśyapa was coming, he was overjoyed. He had the roads cleaned and prepared, with incense burned and flowers scattered. He himself mounted a white elephant and went out to welcome Kāśyapa. Previously, when the king

had seen the Buddha, he would throw himself from the elephant to bow in reverence. When he saw Kāśyapa, he did the same. Mahākāśyapa, with his spiritual power, caught him so that he was not harmed.

He then said to the king: “The power of the Buddha is supreme and differs from that of a śrāvaka. A śrāvaka must enter concentration before he can exercise supernatural powers. Henceforth, when you see me, do not throw yourself from the elephant.”

The king said: “I respectfully obey.” He then addressed Kāśyapa: “When the World-Honored One entered nirvāṇa, I did not get to see him. When you, Venerable One, enter final extinction, I pray you will certainly inform me.”

Kāśyapa replied: “Very well.” He then said to the king: “The Tathāgata, the World-Honored One, possessed wisdom deep and far-reaching. He was able to extinguish the blazing fire of the three poisons in sentient beings and to dry up the great tree of the twelve links of dependent origination. Gods and humans all received his abundant benefit. Now that he has entered nirvāṇa, the eye of the world is extinguished. Birth, old age, sickness, and death, grief, sorrow, decline, and affliction, all these sufferings blaze ever more fiercely. I wish to create the light of wisdom for their sake, and together with the bhikṣus, compile the treasury of the Buddha’s Dharma. Your Majesty should now prepare the provisions for offerings.”

The king said: “Excellent! I pray that the holy ones will always accept my offerings.”

Thereupon Kāśyapa asked Aniruddha: “Among the arhats, who has not come?”

Aniruddha said: “Gavāṃpati is in the Śīriṣa Palace and has not yet come.”

[299c]

Then Kāśyapa told Revata: “You may go to the Śīriṣa Palace and tell Gavāṃpati: ‘Mahākāśyapa and the others now have Sangha business and must see you.’”

Revata flew through the air and reported the above matters in full.

The venerable Gavāṃpati asked Revata: “Where is the World-Honored One, that you speak of Kāśyapa?”

Revata said: “The Buddha has entered nirvāṇa. The bridge of the Dharma is broken, the mountain of the Dharma has collapsed. The lamp of the Dharma is extinguished and the time of darkness has come.”

Gavāṃpati sighed: “How bitter! The world is empty and void. Māra Pāpīyas must surely be rejoicing now. Ordinary, deluded sentient beings, obscured by ignorance, revolving in birth and death, sinking in the net of Māra, were pulled out by the World-Honored One of the Ten Powers. Now he has entered nirvāṇa, and there is no more rescue or protection forever. Alas for sentient beings! How deeply they are to be pitied.”

He said to Revata: “Please bow your head for me to Kāśyapa and to the rest of the holy assembly. Convey my words as follows: ‘Gavāṃpati addresses Mahākāśyapa: Had the World-Honored One still been present, I would have gone there to bow in reverence and make offerings. Now he has entered nirvāṇa and the world is empty and void. Looking at Jambudvīpa, there is nothing in it to delight in. Just as when a great Nāga King has shed his body, the young nāgas will surely follow, so it is with me. I now wish to enter nirvāṇa.’”

Having spoken these words, he immediately entered final extinction. In this manner, all such people, upon hearing of the Buddha’s passing, entered nirvāṇa.

Kāśyapa proclaimed: “The Dharma treasury has not yet been compiled. Do not enter nirvāṇa!”

At that time the bhikṣus asked Mahākāśyapa: “Which teachings should be compiled first?”

Kāśyapa answered: “First the sūtras.”

They asked again: “Who should compile the sūtras?”

[300a]

Mahākāśyapa said: “The bhikṣu Ānanda is one of great learning and comprehensive retention, possessing great wisdom. He always attended the Tathāgata, and his pure conduct was immaculate. In the final period of the Dharma, he will benefit and bring peace to the Sangha. His knowledge and vision are complete, and the Buddha praised him. He should be appointed to compile the sūtras.”

At that time Kāśyapa then said to Ānanda: “You should now proclaim the Dharma eye.”

Ānanda replied: “Very well.” Observing the hearts of the assembly, he spoke this gāthā:

The bhikṣus, the retinue,
Parted from the Buddha, are without adornment,
Like the stars in the empty sky
When there is no moon.

Having spoken this gāthā, he bowed at the feet of the assembly of monks, ascended the Dharma seat, and spoke these words: “Thus have I heard. At one time the Buddha was dwelling at Vārāṇasī, in the Deer Park, the place where the ancient sages had dwelt. For the five bhikṣus he first turned the wheel of the Dharma, namely, the noble truth of suffering.” And so forth, as extensively taught.

When he had spoken these words, the five hundred arhats rose into the air and cried out in loud voices: “How strange, impermanence, so tremendously swift! Like the rapid current of a river, it flows away and never returns. In the past we beheld the World-Honored One with our own eyes. Now we can only speak of hearing him.” All wept in grief and spoke this gāthā:

Alas, the sufferings of all existence
Revolve and shift like the moon on water,
Insubstantial as the plantain,
Like illusions, shadows, and echoes!
The Tathāgata, the great hero,
Whose merit transcends the three realms,
Was still swept along by the wind of impermanence,
Carried away without abiding.

After the five hundred arhats spoke this gāthā, they returned to their original seats.

Then Kāśyapa asked the bhikṣus: “Was what Ānanda said free from error?” They all replied: “It is no different from what the World-Honored One taught.”

Thereupon Kāśyapa appointed Upāli to compile the Vinaya treasury. Kāśyapa himself compiled the Abhidharma treasury.

[300b]

When the compilation of the Dharma treasury was finished, Mahākāśyapa spoke this gāthā:

With this honored wheel of the Dharma,

May all classes of sentient beings be saved.
What the Honored One of the Ten Powers has taught,
All should diligently practice.
This Dharma is a bright lamp
That can shatter all darkness.
Worthy ones, you should uphold it.
Be careful never to give rise to negligence.

At that time Kāśyapa entered the samādhi of volitional knowledge and examined whether the compiled teachings had any omissions. When he had finished contemplating, he knew that everything was complete.

He then had this thought: “The great teacher, the Tathāgata, was my true good friend, benefiting and enriching me like a mother who loves her child. Now I benefit those who share this holy life through the Dharma, and I act with great compassion toward future ages, wishing to cause the great Dharma to flow and spread without ceasing. Only now do I begin to repay the Tathāgata’s kindness.

“I am aged and decrepit; my body is ruined by old age. This foul, rotting body is deeply loathsome. Impermanent and perilous, it cannot be relied upon. It is forever tormented by all manner of sufferings. What person of wisdom would take delight in this body? I should now enter parinirvāṇa.”

He reflected further: “I should now abide in great compassion. The Buddha, the Bhagavat, was a true, good friend, perfumed by immeasurable pure and wholesome merits. I should go to wherever his subtle and wondrous relics are enshrined, and bow in reverence, pay respect, and make offerings.”

He then flew through the air to the four stūpas, bowing in reverence and making offerings. Then he visited the eight stūpas, paying wholeheartedly devout respect. Like a king of geese flying to the great ocean, he went to the palace of Sāgara to pay reverence to the Buddha’s tooth relic. In the time it takes a strong man to flex and extend his arm, he arrived at the Trāyastriṃśa Heaven. Indra, together with the heavenly hosts, came out to welcome Kāśyapa, bowing in reverence and making offerings.

Mahākāśyapa said to Indra: “I wish to enter nirvāṇa. I have come here to pay reverence to the Tathāgata’s hair relic.”

When Indra heard these words, his heart was filled with sorrow, and he wept bitterly in anguish. He personally took the Buddha's hair relic and reverently presented it to Kāśyapa. Kāśyapa received it and paid wholehearted reverence. He made offerings of ox-head sandalwood.

When the offerings were completed, he said to the heavenly beings: "The five desires are impermanent and cannot be preserved for long. Like dew upon a flower, when it meets the sun it evaporates. Only the wholesome Dharma is truly worthy of aspiration. You should contemplate suffering and emptiness, and be careful never to be negligent."

[300c]

Having spoken these words, he vanished from that heaven and returned to the city of Rājagṛha. Ānanda followed him constantly and never left his side, fearing that he would enter nirvāṇa without being seen.

After some time, Mahākāśyapa said to Ānanda: "You go into the city alone. I too shall go."

Then Kāśyapa, having put on his robe and taken up his bowl, entered the city of Rājagṛha. He had this thought: "King Ajātaśatru previously made an agreement with me that when I was about to enter nirvāṇa, he must come to see me. I should now go and inform him."

He went to the palace gate and said to the gatekeeper: "Announce to the king for me that Mahākāśyapa is now at the gate and wishes to see him."

The gatekeeper said: "The king is now asleep. If I wake him, I fear I will be punished."

Kāśyapa said: "When the king awakes, please tell him for me: 'Mahākāśyapa was about to enter nirvāṇa. He came to take his leave of the king, but not seeing him, he departed.'"

Thereupon Kāśyapa went to Kukkuṭapāda Mountain. On a cushion of grass he sat cross-legged and made this vow: "Now, this body of mine, wearing the rag-robe bestowed by the Buddha, and holding my own bowl, shall remain incorrupt until the time of Maitreya, so that his disciples may all see my body and give rise to revulsion."

He further thought: "If King Ajātaśatru does not see me, boiling blood will surely pour from his face and his life will not be saved. If that

king comes together with Ānanda, the mountain should open and allow them to enter. When they depart, it should close again.”

He then relinquished the activities of life, retaining only a trace of vitality. At that moment the great earth quaked in six ways. Indra, together with the heavenly beings, made offerings of mandārava flowers and heavenly powdered incense before the relics, and gave rise to great sorrow. They said: “Since the Tathāgata’s passing, our grief has not yet subsided. Now Kāśyapa’s entry into nirvāṇa increases our sorrow. The Pippala Cave will now be empty and desolate. The destitute in the alleyways, the afflicted, the weak and wretched, the poor, the exposed, the orphaned, and the cold, he always had compassion for them. Now he has departed. Who will shelter and protect them?

“Just as on the fifteenth day of the month, when there are no clouds in the sky, the moon and stars appear clearly in the heavens, so too was the Tathāgata’s holy assembly while dwelling in the world, like the stars and moon. Yet the cloud of impermanent death has suddenly arisen and in an instant obscured the most supreme field of merit.”

The gods, in this manner, were overcome with grief. They wailed and wept, choking with sobs and anguish. Restraining one another, they returned to heaven.

King Ajātaśatru, in his sleep, dreamed that the ridgepole of his house had broken. He woke with a start, his heart filled with dread. The gatekeeper reported to the king: “Mahākāśyapa was about to enter nirvāṇa. He came to take his leave of the king, but it was during your sleep. He asked me to convey his regards, and then turned back.”

[301a]

When the king heard this, he fainted and collapsed to the ground. Cold water was splashed on his face before he could revive. He cried out loudly, tears filling his eyes: “How thin is my fortune! How deep are my karmic obstructions! When the saints enter nirvāṇa, I never see them even once.”

He immediately went to the Bamboo Grove and bowed at Ānanda’s feet. He asked: “Has Kāśyapa entered final extinction yet?”

Ānanda replied: “He has already entered nirvāṇa.”

“Where is he? I wish to make offerings.”

Thereupon Ānanda and King Ajātaśatru went together to Kukkuṭapāda Mountain. When the king arrived, the mountain opened of

its own accord. Kāśyapa was within, his entire body undecayed. Mandārava flowers covered him from above. When the king saw this, he cried aloud and threw himself to the ground. He piled up fragrant wood, intending to cremate the body.

Ānanda asked: “What do you intend to do?”

He replied: “I intend to cremate him.”

Ānanda said: “Mahākāśyapa abides in his body through the power of samādhi, awaiting Maitreya. He cannot be burned. When Maitreya appears in the world, he will bring his assembly of ninety-six hundred million to this mountain to see Kāśyapa. At that time Maitreya’s assembly will all think: ‘The disciples of the Tathāgata Śākyamuni had bodies as small and lowly as this. That Buddha too must have been no different from this.’

“Thereupon Kāśyapa will spring up into the air and perform the eighteen transformations. He will transform into a great form filling the entire world. Then the Buddha Maitreya will take the saṅghāṭī robe from Kāśyapa. At that time the great assembly, witnessing his spiritual power, will abandon their pride and all attain arhatship.”

After the king had made his offerings, he returned to his own kingdom. Then Kukkuṭapāda Mountain closed again as before.

Fascicle Two

When Mahākāśyapa was about to enter nirvāṇa, he entrusted the most supreme Dharma to Ānanda and spoke these words: “Elder, you should know that long ago the Bhagavat entrusted the Dharma to me. Now I am old and decrepit, and am about to enter nirvāṇa. The supreme eye of the world I now wish to entrust to you. You should diligently guard and protect this Dharma.”

[301b]

Ānanda replied, “Yes, I respectfully accept your teaching.”

Ānanda

Thereupon Ānanda expounded the wondrous Dharma and transformed sentient beings. In his past lives he had accumulated great merit. His wisdom was deep and vast, his learning broad and penetrating. The Buddha praised him as foremost in comprehensive retention. He was able to receive and hold the entire Dharma treasury of the Buddhas, like a great ocean receiving all rivers that flow into it. His renown was lofty and far-reaching, known to all. Such merit as his is inexhaustible. I shall now relate the causes and conditions in proper order.

Long ago, in a past age of incalculable kalpas, in the time of Dīpaṃkara Buddha, there was a śramaṇa who kept a novice. He constantly had the novice recite scriptures, admonishing him day and night without rest. If the novice fell even slightly short in his recitation, the master would scold him harshly. At that time, the novice would go to beg food for his master, and if he was even slightly delayed and could not fulfill his quota of recitation, his master would revile and humiliate him terribly. The novice became deeply distressed. While begging food for his master, he would recite as he walked. A certain householder, finding this strange, asked him about it.

The novice answered, “My master is strict and severe, requiring me to recite and study. If I am delayed while begging food, I cannot fulfill my quota. For this reason I always recite while walking.”

The householder replied, “Do not be troubled. From now on I shall always provide your food. You should devote yourself diligently to reciting and studying the scriptures.”

From then on, the novice no longer had to go begging and could concentrate entirely on recitation. Thereafter his scripture recitation was always fully accomplished.

The novice of that time was none other than the World-Honored One. The householder who provided food was Ānanda. Through this meritorious connection, the bhikṣu Ānanda attained profound and wondrous wisdom, powerful retention, and vast and boundless learning beyond measure.

When the Bhagavat accomplished the unsurpassed Way and expounded the wondrous Dharma to transform sentient beings, Ānanda reflected thus: “The prison of the world is not to be cherished. The five desires are like illusions, without any solidity. They are to be feared and loathed, more dangerous than poisonous snakes. The vigor and beauty of youth are all ravaged by old age and sickness. Impermanence rushes swiftly like a flooding river, swallowing and destroying all loving gatherings. The kings of ancient times, with all their majestic power and sovereign authority, were blown away and ruined by the wind of impermanence. Grief, decline, and affliction follow in succession. The rākṣasī of craving constantly deceives sentient beings. How can I escape this calamity?”

He further reflected: “The Tathāgata, the World-Honored One, with divine wisdom surpassing the world, originally left the Śākya clan to renounce the world and study the Way. I should now go to become his disciple.”

He then went to the Buddha and beseeched him, seeking to leave home. The Buddha said, “Welcome,” and he became a śramaṇa. The Tathāgata then taught him the Dharma, namely: the discourse on generosity, the discourse on morality, the discourse on rebirth in heaven, that desires are impure, and that renunciation is the highest good. His mind was immediately opened and he attained the fruit of stream-entry.

At a later time, the Buddha thought about needing an attendant. Kaundinya went to the Buddha and asked to serve as his attendant. The Buddha said, “Kaundinya, you are old and advanced in years; you yourself need someone to look after you. How could you serve as my attendant?” In this manner, five hundred great disciples all went to the Buddha asking to be his attendant, but none were permitted. They bowed to the Buddha and withdrew.

Then Mahāmaudgalyāyana, using his power of knowing others’ minds, perceived that the Tathāgata’s mind was set upon Ānanda, just as the sun when first rising casts its light upon the western wall. Together with the other bhikṣus, he told Ānanda, “The Buddha requires you as his attendant. You should go quickly to pay respects to the Supreme Awakened One.”

Ānanda said, “The Tathāgata’s awesome virtue is like that of a great dragon. I am defiled and weak; I dare not accept this charge.”

The bhikṣus said, “Ānanda, you should know that the World-Honored One’s mind is set exclusively upon you. You should go quickly to attend him and not delay any longer.”

Ānanda respectfully agreed, but first requested three conditions: “May the Tathāgata’s cast-off robes not be given to me. May any leftover food be given to others. May the times for audiences be determined at my discretion. If these three conditions are granted, I shall accept the charge.”

The bhikṣus went to the World-Honored One, prostrated, and fully reported these matters. The Tathāgata praised him, saying, “Excellent, Ānanda! He possesses great wisdom and knows well what is timely and appropriate. Not only today, but also in the distant past it was so. Listen well, all of you, and I shall explain.”

“Long ago in the past, in an incalculable kalpa, there was a king who ruled the world, dwelling in the city of Bhojā. In that city there was a Brahmin named Kugroda, brilliant and broadly learned, with extraordinary talents surpassing those of the world. The people and householders of the country all revered him. He possessed abundant wealth, numbering hundreds of thousands of millions, but had no son to carry on his line and was constantly troubled by this. He prayed to the gods for twelve years, and his chief wife then conceived. When the

months were fulfilled, she gave birth to a boy whose body was the color of purple gold, with handsome and upright features. The physiognomists examined him and declared, ‘This child has great merit.’ They gave him the name Mahādāna, ‘Great Giver.’”

“As he grew older, he asked his father for permission to go out on an excursion. His father ordered the roads to be prepared, incense burned, flowers scattered, and various music performed. Mahādāna then went out to see the sights. Along the road ahead he saw a beggar wearing tattered and ruined clothing, who humbly pleaded for help.”

“Mahādāna asked, ‘Why are you in such a state?’”

“The beggar answered, ‘I have always been orphaned and poor, and am oppressed by illness and suffering. My very life is at stake, and so I go about begging.’”

“Hearing this, Mahādāna sighed sorrowfully, ‘How pitiable are living beings! With ignorance obscuring their minds, they sink in the five desires. They are tormented by old age, sickness, and death, yet in the midst of it all they feel at ease and content. Failing to cultivate wholesome deeds, they receive these evil fruits. How strange, how perilous, how fearsome!’”

[302a] “He went a little farther and saw hunters spreading nets to capture birds, and farmers plowing fields and fishermen catching fish, causing great harm to many creatures.”

“Mahādāna asked, ‘Why do you do this?’”

“The people answered, ‘From the time of our fathers and grandfathers, we have always practiced this trade. We depend on it for our livelihood and also to fulfill our obligations to the king. If we were to abandon it, we would immediately fall into poverty.’”

“Hearing this, Mahādāna’s sorrow increased. He thought to himself, arousing great compassion: ‘Alas for sentient beings, foolish and without the eye of wisdom! Having long accumulated sinful karma, they are poor and feeble, dwelling in great darkness, which is truly fearsome. Now they create still more evil karma, killing sentient beings and cutting short their precious lives. Evil karma increases and unwholesomeness flourishes. Circling through the five destinies, how can they ever escape? I should now find skillful means to rescue and protect them, and provide cool relief from the burning afflictions of birth and death.’”

“Having thought thus, he entered the great ocean and went to the Nāga King’s palace to seek the wish-fulfilling jewel. He saw a golden city, brilliantly radiant. Poisonous serpents encircled it so that none could approach. He then entered the samādhi of loving-kindness and walked over them. The Nāga King came out to welcome him with bows and reverence. After exchanging greetings, they entered the palace together.”

“The Nāga King asked, ‘Benevolent one, why have you come here?’”

“Mahādāna answered, ‘The people of Jambudvīpa, being impoverished, cause great harm to one another. When they die, they will certainly be reborn in the three evil destinies. Out of compassion for them, I have traversed these dangers to come here, seeking the wish-fulfilling jewel to deliver them from their suffering. I humbly ask that you give it to me for the benefit of sentient beings.’”

“The Nāga King said, ‘Very well. I shall not refuse your request. But please stay a while and teach the Dharma for my sake.’”

“Mahādāna agreed. He stayed for four months, expounding the various teachings, their names, origins, and conclusions, explaining their phrases and meanings in proper order. The Nāga King listened attentively, pondered the teachings, and attended to all needs with great propriety, determining the appropriate times and occasions by his own discernment.”

“After four months, Mahādāna took his leave. The Nāga King unfastened the jewel from his topknot and gave it to him, then made this vow: ‘The great one’s compassion is exceedingly vast and broad. You will surely attain natural, perfect enlightenment. May I become your disciple of great learning.’”

“Thereupon Mahādāna used the wish-fulfilling jewel to rain down the seven treasures, and all the people of Jambudvīpa were brought to peace and happiness. They cultivated the ten wholesome deeds and, at the end of their lives, were reborn in heaven.”

“Bhikṣus, you should know: the Mahādāna of that time was none other than myself. The Nāga King of that time was Ānanda. Even in the Nāga King’s realm he knew what was timely and appropriate; how much more so now, as a human being, would he not be thoroughly versed in such matters!”

Thereupon Ānanda served as attendant to the Tathāgata, skillfully attending to his needs. What he heard and retained of the Dharma treasury was never lost.

When the World-Honored One was about to enter parinirvāṇa in the grove of twin śāla trees, he asked Kauṇḍinya, “Where is Ānanda?”

Kauṇḍinya answered, “He is now outside the śāla grove, being troubled and disturbed by hosts of Māra. He has fallen deeply into the net of delusion and is in great anguish. Apart from the Buddha, the Tathāgata, no one can rescue him.”

Mañjuśrī addressed the Buddha, saying, “World-Honored One, in this great assembly there are bodhisattvas who over immeasurable kalpas have generated the aspiration for enlightenment, who have long cultivated their vows and practices and attained non-retrogression. Beings such as these are well able to receive and hold the Dharma treasury of all Buddhas. Why do you inquire after Ānanda’s whereabouts?”

The Buddha told Mañjuśrī, “The bhikṣu Ānanda has served me for a long time without ever committing a single fault. His accomplishments are inconceivable. The Dharma he has heard, he is well able to receive and retain, like water poured from one vessel into another. He is revered and looked up to by all sentient beings. Therefore I ask where Ānanda is. He is now twelve yojanas from this assembly, being tormented by the hosts of Māra. Take my dhāraṇī and go there to release him.”

Mañjuśrī then went to where Māra was and recited the dhāraṇī. Upon hearing it, Māra released Ānanda. Together with Mañjuśrī, Ānanda came to the Buddha’s presence, prostrated in reverence, and sat to one side.

At that time, the World-Honored One, during the last watch of the night, entered parinirvāṇa. All the gods and humans made great offerings. They wrapped the body in white silk cloth and performed the cremation. When all these rites were completed, Mahākāśyapa and the arhats, in the city of Rājagṛha, wished to compile the eye of the world.

At that time, Ānanda was still on the stage of learning, for his defilements had not yet been exhausted, and he was not admitted to the assembly of noble ones. There was a bhikṣu named Vājīputra who awakened him with these verses:

How splendid, O man of great learning,

Sitting peacefully amid forest groves!
You should contemplate that all dharmas
Are false and without solidity.
Birth and death have many perils;
Nirvāṇa is the ultimate cool relief.
O son of Gautama, you should
Diligently cultivate the practice free of defilements.
In this way, before long,
You will surely receive the foremost bliss.

Upon hearing this, Ānanda spent the entire night in walking meditation. Though he exerted himself strenuously, he could not attain arhatship. His body and mind were exhausted and he wished to lie down and rest. Before his head reached the pillow, he attained the fruit of non-attachment. The three kinds of clear knowledge were unobstructed, and the six supernormal powers were perfectly lucid. He immediately flew to the Pippala Cave and, standing outside the door, spoke these verses:

Of great learning and eloquent speech,
Attendant of the Perfectly Awakened Gautama,
Ānanda now stands outside the door.

At that time, Kāśyapa replied in verse:

[302c]

If you have exhausted all suffering
And cast off the burden of afflictions,
You should manifest your supernormal powers
So that the assembly may all bear witness.

Thereupon Ānanda, using his supernormal powers, passed through the stone wall and entered. He paid respect at the feet of the assembled monks and took his seat in proper order. Receiving Kāśyapa's charge, he compiled the supreme eye of the world.

Later, when Kāśyapa was about to enter nirvāṇa, together with King Ajātaśatru they went to Mount Kukkuṭapāda, burning incense, scattering flowers, praising, and making offerings.

The king said, "Venerable one, when the Tathāgata Kāśyapa entered parinirvāṇa, it was my great misfortune not to have witnessed it. If you,

venerable one, are about to pass away, I humbly ask that you kindly inform me.”

Ānanda said, “Very well. I respectfully accept your request.”

Thereupon he traveled about, expounding the wondrous Dharma and transforming sentient beings, enabling them all to cross over to liberation.

At last he came to a certain bamboo grove and heard a bhikṣu reciting a verse from the Dharmapada:

If a person lives a hundred years
But never sees a water crane,
It is better to live a single day
And get to see one.

Hearing this, Ānanda sighed sorrowfully: “How swiftly the eye of the world has been extinguished! How quickly the evils of affliction arise! Going against the holy teaching and giving rise to false imaginings, without the light of wisdom, one forever dwells in the darkness of delusion and will be carried endlessly along in the great ocean of birth and death, tormented by old age, sickness, and death.”

He then said to the bhikṣu, “These are not the Buddha’s words and should not be practiced. You should know that there are two kinds of people who slander the Buddha: first, those who, despite extensive learning, give rise to wrong views; and second, those who, failing to understand the profound meaning, speak falsely and in an inverted manner. One who has these two faults injures himself and cannot lead others away from the three evil destinies. You should now listen as I recite the Buddha’s verse:

If a person lives a hundred years
But does not understand the dharma of arising and ceasing,
It is better to live a single day
And come to understand it.

[303a]

At that time, the bhikṣu went to his teacher and reported what Ānanda had said. The teacher told him, “Ānanda is old and decrepit. His wisdom has declined. His words are full of errors and cannot be trusted. You should simply continue reciting as before.”

Later, when Ānanda heard that bhikṣu still reciting the former verse under the bamboo grove, he asked the reason. The bhikṣu answered, “Venerable one, my teacher told me: ‘Ānanda is old and decrepit. His words are mostly false. You should simply continue reciting as before.’”

Ānanda reflected: “He disregards my words, perhaps following some other teaching.” He then entered samādhi and searched for a person of superior virtue who might change that man’s mind. Finding no one who could do so, he spoke these words:

“How strange is impermanence! How fierce and mighty its power to scatter and destroy immeasurable sages and saints, making the world entirely desolate! Forever dwelling in darkness and walking amid terrors, wrong views blaze forth and unwholesomeness increases. They slander the Tathāgata and sever the true teaching. They will forever sink in the great river of birth and death, opening the gates to evil destinies and closing the paths to human and heavenly realms. For immeasurable kalpas they will undergo all manner of suffering. Alas for the world! How deeply pitiable!”

“Now this bhikṣu, to whom I personally spoke, has instead accepted false words and rejected my teaching. To whom then can I speak of such matters? The many sufferings of the world are not to be wished for. This body is not solid but decaying, fragile, and perilous, like a mass of foam that changes and vanishes in an instant. The beauty of a handsome appearance, so lovely and alluring, where will it be when decline and old age arrive? Covered by thin skin that is taken for adornment, inside there flow pus and blood, foul discharges and impurities. Conditioned things are impermanent, passing with great swiftness. In the space of a single glance, there are four hundred births and deaths. It is like thunder resounding in empty space, clouds forming, a violent wind rising suddenly and then immediately dispersing and vanishing. The five desires are just as insubstantial. People share in mutual love, ease, and pleasure, yet when impermanence arrives, who among them remains?”

“The many sufferings of the world are truly hard to endure for long. Today I should enter nirvāṇa. Moreover, my great teacher and those who practiced the holy life with me have all passed into extinction. How could it be fitting for me to remain any longer?”

He further reflected: “I have a pledge with King Ajātaśatru. I should go and inform him.” He then went to the royal palace and told the gatekeeper, “Please inform the king on my behalf that Ānanda is outside. He is about to enter nirvāṇa and has come to see the king.”

The gatekeeper answered, “The king is now asleep. If I were to wake him, the punishment upon me would be no small matter.”

Ānanda said, “When the king awakens, please convey my message to him in full.”

King Ajātaśatru dreamed that the canopy’s stem was broken. He immediately awoke in alarm. The gatekeeper reported the matter in full. When the king heard this, he fainted and fell to the ground. Cold water was sprinkled on his face, and after a long while he revived. He cried out in anguish, his wailing shaking heaven and earth. Beating his chest and calling out, he was overcome with grief, and spoke these words:

“Alas! How strange! The eye of the world is extinguished! Who will deliver us from the sufferings of the three realms? In former days the World-Honored One, with deep compassion, served as a great refuge for all sentient beings. Since he entered nirvāṇa, the world has been orphaned and exposed. Mahākāśyapa, of great renown, succeeded the Tathāgata in expounding the Dharma and teaching. Yet he too has passed into extinction, and the Dharma has further declined. I looked up to Ānanda as one looks up to the sun and moon. Now that he is entering nirvāṇa, upon whom can I rely? The pure water of the Dharma washes away the dust of affliction. Who will proclaim it again to benefit all beings? Sentient beings are ever beset by thirst and craving. Who will pour the rain of Dharma to satisfy them? The beings of the three realms will forever transmigrate, undergoing all manner of suffering without end. Māra will rejoice greatly and gain many followers. The wholesome Dharma will gradually be exhausted, and all evils will blaze forth.”

[303b] He then asked the gatekeeper, “Where is Ānanda?”

The spirit of the park informed the king, “He has gone toward Vaiśālī.”

The king immediately mustered the four divisions of his army and proceeded to the banks of the Ganges. Ānanda was aboard a boat in the middle of the river. The king went forward directly, bowed his head, and

said, “The bright lamp of the three realms has already forsaken me. Now I look up to you in hope. I beg you not to enter nirvāṇa.”

Ānanda remained silent and did not assent.

At that moment the great earth shook in six ways. In the Himālayas, five hundred sages, seeing these signs, all thought, “What cause and conditions have produced these extraordinary portents?” Looking with insight, they saw that Ānanda was about to pass away. They immediately flew through the air to his presence, prostrated in reverence, and beseeched him, asking to leave the household life. Ānanda then transformed the Ganges, turning it into a ground of gold, and taught the Dharma to the sages as was fitting. Their hair and beards fell away of themselves, and they all became arhats. Together they all entered parinirvāṇa at the same time.

Ānanda then recalled: “The Buddha prophesied that in Kaśmīr there would be a bhikṣu named Madhyāntika who would spread the Dharma eye in that land.” He thereupon entrusted the Dharma to Madhyāntika.

Rising into the sky, he performed the eighteen transformations and entered the Wind Swift samādhi, dividing his body into four parts: one part he gave to Indra in the Trāyastriṃśa Heaven; one part to the great ocean Nāga King Sāgara; one part to the people of Vaiśālī; and one part he bestowed upon King Ajātaśatru. In each of these four places, jeweled stūpas were erected, and incense was burned, flowers scattered, and offerings made to the relics.

When Mahākāśyapa had been about to enter nirvāṇa, he had told Ānanda, “I now entrust the Dharma treasure to your care. Elder, when you are later about to enter nirvāṇa, know that in the great city of Rājagṛha there is a householder named Śāṇakavāsa, of outstanding talent, courageous spirit, and great wisdom, who has already deeply planted roots of merit in past lives. He resolved to go to sea to gather precious treasures. Upon his return, he will wish to hold a pañcavārṣika festival, construct a walking-meditation path for the Tathāgata, and also build a gate tower. When these works are completed, you may admit him to the monastic life and entrust him with the entire Dharma treasury of the Tathāgata.”

Therefore, when Ānanda was about to pass away, he told Śāṇakavāsa, “The Buddha entrusted the Dharma eye to great Kāśyapa. Kāśyapa

entrusted the Dharma to me. Now that the time of my nirvāṇa has arrived, I entrust the treasure of the Dharma to you. You should diligently guard and protect this Dharma, enabling all sentient beings to taste the flavor of sweet dew.”

Śāṇakavāsa answered, “I accept your teaching. I will protect and uphold this wondrous Dharma, serving as a great bright torch for all beings.”

Śāṇakavāsa

Thereupon Śāṇakavāsa proclaimed in turn the unsurpassed Dharma medicine, healing the sickness of afflictions and delivering sentient beings across to liberation. His virtue was lofty and far-reaching; he had long cultivated his vows and practices. His learning was vast, his retention comprehensive, and his eloquence inexhaustible. I shall now set forth that accumulation of merit.

Long ago in a past age of incalculable kalpas, Śāṇakavāsa was a merchant leader who, together with five hundred traders, wished to enter the great ocean to gather precious treasures. Along the road ahead they saw a pratyekabuddha who was gravely ill, his life force feeble and waning. The merchant and the traders immediately stopped, sought out medicine, and treated him. They attended to him wholeheartedly, providing everything he needed. His illness was cured, and his strength was restored.

[303c] This pratyekabuddha wore a garment of śāṇa cloth. At that time, the merchant bathed the pratyekabuddha with various fragrant waters and offered him fine white silk robes, saying, “Great sage, this śāṇa garment is extremely worn and shabby. I humbly wish that you would accept the robes I offer.”

The pratyekabuddha said, “Benefactor, you should know that I went forth and attained the Way wearing this garment, and I shall also wear it when I enter nirvāṇa.”

Hearing this, the merchant was deeply grieved and distressed. He said, “Great sage, I beg you not to pass into extinction. Please come with me into the ocean. I will provide for you for the rest of my life with robes, bedding, medicine when you are ill, and all necessities.”

The pratyekabuddha said, “I cannot go to sea. I now wish to enter parinirvāṇa. You should generate deep faith toward this field of merit. In the future you will surely obtain a great reward.”

He then rose into the air, performed the eighteen transformations, returned to his original seat, and entered parinirvāṇa. The merchant wept and sobbed with grief. He piled up fragrant wood and cremated the body. He collected the relics, erected a stūpa, and made offerings. He then made this vow: “May I in a future life encounter a holy teacher who surpasses even this one. May all the accumulations of merit I have gained, my deportment, my practices, and even my garments, be the same as this sage’s, without any difference.”

Through the mighty power of this vow, while in his mother’s womb he wore a garment of śāṇa cloth. Moreover, this garment grew together with his body. Whether leaving home, receiving the precepts, attaining the Way, or entering nirvāṇa, the śāṇa garment never left his body. For this reason he was called Śāṇakavāsa.

Long ago when the Tathāgata was traveling in the country of Mathurā, he saw a grove of green trees, flourishing and luxuriant. He told Ānanda, “Do you see this grove?”

Ānanda replied, “Indeed, I have seen it.”

The Buddha said, “This is Mount Urumūṇḍa. After my parinirvāṇa, there will be a bhikṣu named Śāṇakavāsa who will build a monastic dwelling on this mountain. He will teach the Dharma and provide great benefit to many.”

When Śāṇakavāsa returned from the sea, having obtained many precious treasures, he went to the Bamboo Grove and prostrated at Ānanda’s feet, saying, “Great sage, when I originally set out to sea, I vowed to return safely, to hold a great pañcavārṣika festival for the Buddha and the Sangha, and to provide great offerings. Where is the World-Honored One now?”

Ānanda answered, “He has already entered nirvāṇa.”

Upon hearing these words, Śāṇakavāsa fainted and fell to the ground. Water was sprinkled on his face before he could revive. He cried out in anguished wailing, his grief beyond endurance. He tore at his hair, covered his body with dust, beat his chest and cried aloud, his tears falling like rain. He spoke these words: “The great evil of impermanence

[304a]

has destroyed this treasury of jewels! The world is orphaned and exposed, with no refuge forevermore. How meager is my fortune, how deep and thick are my karmic obstructions, that the bright sun of the Buddha shone and yet I did not behold it! I will forever sink in the bitter sea of the three realms of existence.”

He then asked Ānanda, “Are Mahākāśyapa, Mahāmaudgalyāyana, Śāriputra, and the others still present?”

Ānanda answered, “They have all passed into extinction.”

Upon hearing this, his grief and sorrow doubled. He said, “Great sage, when I originally set out to sea, I vowed to return safely and hold a great pañcavārṣika festival for the Buddha and the Sangha. I now wish to prepare a modest offering for the noble assembly. I humbly beg that you take pity on me and permit this.”

Ānanda answered, “Excellent, householder! You are able to understand the insecurity and fragility of the world, and to establish firm karma in this supreme field of merit. Householder, you should know that all dharmas are impermanent, without self or anything belonging to self, like something borrowed that cannot be kept forever. If you wish to obtain the highest benefit, you should build earnest karma in this field of merit. The reward of such deeds cannot be destroyed.”

Śāṇakavāsa then made all the arrangements: he held the pañcavārṣika festival with every kind of provision, and he constructed a walking-meditation path as well as a gate tower. When all this was completed, Ānanda told him, “Your generosity of material gifts is most rare and extraordinary. Now you should also practice the giving of Dharma. This form of giving is subtle and wondrous, exceedingly vast and broad, surpassing the giving of material things by a hundred thousand million times.”

Śāṇakavāsa asked, “What is meant by the giving of Dharma?”

Ānanda answered, “Within the Buddha-Dharma, to leave the household life and study the Way, to teach the Dharma and transform beings, to benefit sentient beings: this is called the giving of Dharma.”

Śāṇakavāsa replied, “Excellent! This is exactly what I wish.”

Thereupon Ānanda ordained him, admitting him to the monastic life, and conferred upon him the full precepts. Śāṇakavāsa said, “Great

teacher, when I was born I was wearing a garment of śāṇa cloth. I wish to wear this garment for the rest of my life.”

Having spoken thus, he obtained the power of comprehensive retention. Whatever Dharma he heard, he never forgot. He became an arhat of great merit.

After Ānanda’s entry into nirvāṇa, Śāṇakavāsa proclaimed the wondrous Dharma and benefited sentient beings. The eighty-four thousand gateways to the Dharma treasury that Ānanda had held, Śāṇakavāsa was able to remember them all, like water poured from one vessel into another. He was likewise able to receive and retain them in just this way.

With the true and pure Dharma, he traveled about teaching and transforming. At last he came to the country of Mathurā and wished to establish a dwelling place on Mount Urumūṇḍa. At that time, in that mountain there were two young nāgas whose venomous power was fierce and blazing, so that none could approach. Śāṇakavāsa then used his supernormal power to shake the mountain. The nāgas became furiously angry and raised up evil wind and rain. Śāṇakavāsa entered the samādhi of loving-kindness, and through the power of his concentration, the nāgas’ venom was extinguished. Greatly startled and afraid, they gave rise to a mind of faith and reverence.

[304b]

They asked, “Venerable one, what instruction do you have?”

Śāṇakavāsa answered, “The Buddha prophesied that on this mountain there would be a monastic dwelling. Therefore I wish to build one here.”

The young nāgas said, “If the Buddha truly prophesied this, then very well, we consent.”

Śāṇakavāsa then constructed a dwelling place on that mountain, complete with meditation chambers and walking paths, all fully equipped. The interior and exterior were spacious and tranquil, free from all commotion.

Having built the dwelling, he thought, “The Buddha prophesied that Kaśmīr is peaceful and prosperous, that the land is tranquil and free from obstacles, cool and with little illness, most suitable for walking meditation. Should I now go there?”

He immediately flew through the air to the country of Kaśmīr. Entering samādhi with joy, he spoke these verses:

Always wearing the śāṇa garment,
Having accomplished the five branches of meditation,
Amid mountain cliffs and empty valleys,
I sit in meditation and contemplate absorption.
Wind, cold, and all manner of hardships
I am able to bear and endure.
My mind is well liberated;
Wisdom is my adornment.
Like a wild elephant in an open field,
I dwell at ease, free from worry and care.

At that time, Upagupta had five hundred disciples who were still caught in birth and death, unable to attain liberation. Their minds had given rise to pride and arrogance. Upagupta entered samādhi and observed that these people had no karmic connection with himself. Only his own teacher could transform and deliver them. He then single-mindedly called to mind Śāṇakavāsa.

Śāṇakavāsa then used his supernormal power and, like a great king of geese, flew through the air and arrived at Upagupta's dwelling place. At that time, Upagupta had gone elsewhere, and only his disciples were present when they saw Śāṇakavāsa. His robes were coarse and shabby, and his hair and nails were long and sharp. He went to Upagupta's room and sat upon his seat.

Upagupta's disciples all became angry: "What wretched person is this, sitting on our master's seat?" They tried to expel him and force him out, but he was like Mount Sumeru and could not be moved. They wished to utter harsh words, but their mouths sealed themselves shut. They then went together to Upagupta and said, "Great master, there is an old bhikṣu, haggard and worn in appearance, who has gone to your seat and is sitting there cross-legged."

[304c] Upagupta thought, "Unless it is my teacher, no one could sit there." He went to his room and saw Śāṇakavāsa. He prostrated, placing his head on the ground in reverence.

The disciples thought, "Even though our master has bowed to him, our master surpasses him in awesome virtue."

Śāṇakavāsa, knowing that the disciples' pride had not yet subsided, pointed his finger toward the sky, and fragrant milk descended from above, like a spring cascading from a high mountain peak.

He asked, "Upagupta, what kind of meditative sign is this?"

Upagupta immediately entered samādhi and examined it deeply, but could not comprehend it. He then asked his teacher, "What samādhi is this?"

Śāṇakavāsa answered, "This is called the Dragon Swift samādhi."

In this manner, five hundred types of samādhi were presented one after another, and when asked their names, Upagupta could not identify a single one. Śāṇakavāsa explained each one.

Upagupta said, "All that I have attained, I received from my teacher. Only these samādhis are beyond my capacity."

Śāṇakavāsa said, "Upagupta, you should know that the samādhis of the Tathāgata cannot even be named by the pratyekabuddhas. The samādhis of the pratyekabuddhas cannot be comprehended by any śrāvaka. The samādhis entered by Mahāmaudgalyāyana and Śāriputra cannot be fathomed by the other arhats. The samādhi characteristics of my teacher Ānanda are all unknown to me. Likewise, my samādhis are unknown to you. After my nirvāṇa, all these samādhis will be extinguished along with me. The seventy-seven thousand jātaka sūtras in their entirety, the ten thousand divisions of the Abhidharma treasury, and the eighty thousand sections of the pure Vinaya: all these teachings will likewise be extinguished along with me. Therefore, Upagupta, after the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa, as the sages and saints pass away, this Dharma treasury will gradually decline, until at last it will all be completely extinguished. You should now exert yourself diligently to guard and protect it."

At that time, the disciples were remorseful and reproached themselves: "We lacked wisdom and showed contempt toward a great saint. Now we realize that our master's attainment truly cannot compare with his."

Thereupon Śāṇakavāsa taught them the Dharma, and all five hundred disciples attained the way of the arhat.

Then the Venerable Śāṇakavāsa, having done all that was to be done for sentient beings, rose into the sky, performed the eighteen

transformations, returned to his original seat, and entered nirvāṇa. Upagupta and his retinue piled up fragrant wood, cremated the body with fire, collected the relics, and erected a stūpa to make offerings.

Fascicle Three

The Venerable Ānanda entrusted the Dharma to Śāṇakavāsa, telling him: [305a]
“Long ago, when the World-Honored One was traveling through the land of Mathurā, he turned to me and said: ‘In this country there shall be an elder named Gupta, whose son will be called Upagupta. In the practice of meditation, he shall be foremost. Though he will lack the major and minor marks, his ability to convert and liberate beings will be equal to mine. After my parinirvāṇa, he will bring about great benefit. The sentient beings he teaches and transforms will be immeasurable, and all shall attain liberation as arhats. You should, in due course, ordain him and allow him to leave home. When you are about to enter nirvāṇa, entrust the Dharma treasury to him.’”

When Śāṇakavāsa was on the verge of entering nirvāṇa, he told Gupta: “The Buddha entrusted the true Dharma to Mahākāśyapa. Kāśyapa in turn entrusted it to my teacher Ānanda. Ānanda entrusted the Dharma to me. Now, as I am about to pass away, I entrust it to you. You must be diligent and devoted in safeguarding the eye of the world.”

Upagupta replied: “Yes, I accept your instruction.”

Upagupta

Thereupon he expounded and spread the supreme, wondrous Dharma, broadly proclaimed the true teaching, and brought salvation to all sentient beings. His virtue was deep and vast, immeasurable and boundless. In past lives, over long ages, he had cultivated the supreme, excellent practice. Even when reborn among birds and beasts, he constantly converted sentient beings, vanquished non-Buddhist teachers, and erected the great banner of the Dharma. With clouds of compassion

he universally sheltered all. These merits and virtues shall now be briefly recounted.

Long ago, when the Bhagavat was dwelling at the Jetavana, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the land of Śrāvastī, Upagupta was at that time a Nirgrantha named Saccaka. His wisdom was profound and wondrous, and his skill in debate was without peer. Deeply proud and self-important, he strode unrivaled throughout the world. He bound copper plates around his belly and bore a vessel of fire upon his head, declaring: “My wisdom is so full that I fear it will overflow. For this reason, I bind myself with plates. The world is dark and blind, seeing nothing. I wish to illuminate its darkness with my light.”

Hearing that the World-Honored One, the Buddha, was dwelling in Śrāvastī, he wished to go there and challenge him to a contest of eloquence and argument. Someone said to him: “If you see the Buddha, your wisdom will be diminished and your light will be extinguished of its own accord.”

He went to the Buddha’s dwelling place and addressed him: “Gautama, I wish to leave the household life. If my wisdom proves equal to that of Śāriputra, I shall be content and glad. But if it falls short, I shall return to lay life.”

The World-Honored One told him: “Even if you were to pile up a hundred thousand myriad bodies, hoping to equal Śāriputra, such a thing could never come to pass.”

Hearing this, the brahmin took his leave and departed. Not long after he had gone, the Buddha told the assembly: “After my parinirvāṇa, when a full one hundred years have passed, this man will attain the path of the arhat. With the three clear knowledges and six supernormal powers, fully endowed with the eight liberations, the torch of his wisdom shining alone, he will broadly convert sentient beings. Those he liberates will be beyond counting.”

When the assembly heard this, they were filled with a sense of wonder.

Furthermore, in a past life countless kalpas ago, on Mount Urumūṇḍa there lived a pratyekabuddha together with five hundred others of his kind. Groups of sages also dwelt on the mountainside, and five hundred monkeys inhabited one area nearby.

At that time, the monkey king gave rise to great faith and deeply cultivated roots of merit. He constantly gathered flowers and fruits to offer to the pratyekabuddhas. On one occasion, the assembly of pratyekabuddhas sat upright in contemplation and entered samādhi. The monkey imitated them, assuming the cross-legged posture.

Later, all the pratyekabuddhas entered nirvāṇa together. The monkey offered flowers, but none among the pratyekabuddhas showed any sign of acceptance. He pulled at their robes and pushed them, but they did not stir. Realizing they had passed into nirvāṇa, the monkey was overcome with deep grief and anguish.

Going to another part of the mountain, he saw the sages practicing severe austerities: sleeping upon thorns, standing on one leg, hanging upside down, scorching their bodies with the five fires, casting themselves from cliffs, and kindling flames. The monkey immediately gathered up their ashes and thorns, cleared away the filth, pulled their feet down to straighten them, and then sat cross-legged before them. The sages, astonished at this behavior, proceeded to imitate the monkey, sitting upright and focusing their minds. Without any teacher, they awakened of themselves and became pratyekabuddhas. [305b]

They then reflected: “We have attained the Way thanks to this monkey.” And they made offerings to the monkey with incense and flowers.

The monkey king at that time was Upagupta. Even when in the form of an animal, he was able to bring about awakening in others. His determination was shrewd and wise, his intellect sharp and his eloquence brilliant.

When the time came for Śāṇakavāsa to transmit the Dharma to Upagupta, he first observed whether Gupta had yet had a son. Entering meditative concentration, he perceived that the child had not yet been born. So he went with his bhikṣus to visit Gupta’s house. Gradually he reduced his companions until he went alone.

Gupta asked: “Why do you come alone, without companions?”

He answered: “Elder, I have no stipend to give. Only those with faith who wish to renounce the world would follow me.”

Gupta replied: “I enjoy worldly life and cannot leave home. But if I later have a son, I shall offer him to you.”

Śāṇakavāsa replied: “Very good.”

Later a son was born, named Aśipagupta. As the boy gradually grew up, Śāṇakavāsa went to ask for him.

Gupta answered: “I have only one son. I cannot reasonably give him to you. But if another is born, I shall certainly offer him.”

Later a second son was born, named Nandagupta. Śāṇakavāsa again went to ask for him.

Gupta replied: “Venerable one, I now have two sons, and I depend on them for my livelihood. The younger one guards the home, while the elder gathers and manages the family affairs. In this way we can become prosperous. For this reason, I cannot give him to you. But if a third son is born, then I shall offer him.”

Śāṇakavāsa knew that these two sons had no karmic affinity with the Way, so he did not press the matter further.

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Later a third son was born, handsome and dignified in appearance. He was named Upagupta. He was gentle and good-natured, inclined toward compassion, intelligent and eloquent, and broad-minded. By the age of twelve, he was skilled in commerce. Whenever buyers came, he always gave them more than their due.

Śāṇakavāsa, observing whether the child had been born and knowing that Upagupta had long since come into the world, went to him and asked: “When you enter the marketplace, is your mind pure or impure?”

Upagupta replied: “What is meant by a pure mind and an impure mind?”

He answered: “If the mind is joined with greed and delusion, it is called impure. If it is not joined with them, then it is called pure.”

Gradually, through skillful means, he taught Upagupta to focus his attention. He instructed him: “When an unwholesome thought arises, set down a black stone. When a wholesome thought arises, set down a white stone.”

Upagupta followed these instructions, gathering his attention without distraction, and whenever wholesome or unwholesome thoughts arose, he would place a stone accordingly. At first the black stones were overwhelmingly many and the white ones few. Through gradual practice, the black and white became equal. After seven full days, his mind had

become entirely pure: the black stones were completely gone and only white ones remained.

Śāṇakavāsa reflected: “Now his wholesome mind has become fully mature. The time for the Way has arrived, and I can teach him the Dharma.” He then proclaimed the Four Noble Truths, and Upagupta immediately attained the fruit of stream-entry.

At that time, in the city of Mathurā there was a courtesan named Vāsudattā, exceedingly seductive, enchanting, and deceitful. She sent a servant to the market to buy fine flowers. The servant went to Upagupta’s stall, where he obtained a great quantity of beautiful flowers and brought them back to Vāsudattā. The woman was surprised at the abundance and asked the servant: “Did you not steal these flowers?”

The servant replied: “I did not steal them. I bought them at the market. There is a man named Upagupta who is benevolent, generous, and naturally fair-minded. For this reason, I obtained so many flowers. Moreover, this man is handsome and elegant in appearance. My lady, if you were to see him, you would have no regrets even in death.”

Vāsudattā then sent a messenger to invite Upagupta, but he firmly declined and would not consent. Despite repeated and earnest invitations, he would not waver.

Now a certain elder’s son had been staying the night with the courtesan. It happened that a merchant arrived from a distant land, bringing great quantities of precious jewels, seeking the woman’s company. The woman, coveting his treasures, killed the elder’s son and buried him within her house.

The family of the deceased searched everywhere. They came to the courtesan’s house, dug into the ground, and found the body. They reported the matter in full to the king. The king then had the courtesan seized, her hands and feet severed, her ears and nose cut off, and abandoned her among the charnel grounds.

Upagupta then reflected: “Previously, in the glory of her beauty, she invited me. For that reason I refrained and did not go. Now, for the sake of her liberation, it is fitting that I go and convert her.”

He took an attendant and went to where the courtesan lay. Vāsudattā said: “In the past, when I was beautiful and lovely in form and

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appearance, I invited you and you would not deign to come. Now that I am mutilated and ruined, what use is your coming?"

He answered: "Sister, I have come to observe your true nature, not out of desire. In the past, you used your beauty to delude sentient beings. Ordinary people, lacking wisdom, give rise to perverse imaginings. You should now carefully observe this body: impermanent, fragile, like gathered foam. It is covered with a thin layer of skin, outwardly displaying adornment. Sinews and bones are strung together; mucus and saliva are unclean. It is like a painted vessel filled with foul refuse. The foolish fail to perceive this and give rise to deep attachment and desire. The wise understand and never find pleasure in clinging to it. Though one may adorn it with incense and flowers, bathe it, and dress it in fine garments, it appears elegant on the outside but is truly impure within. The great ocean is vast, and one might count its drops, but the faults of this body are far more difficult to exhaust. For this reason, all the Buddhas constantly reproach it and never give rise, even for a single moment, to thoughts of desire for it."

At that time, the courtesan's mind gradually opened to understanding, and she gave rise to deep respect and faith in the Buddha-Dharma. She said: "Benevolent one, what you say is true and sincere. I beseech you to expound it for me in full."

Upagupta then proclaimed: "All conditioned existence is an accumulation of suffering, like a swelling, like a sore, like an arrow piercing the heart. Birth, old age, sickness, and death revolve without end. It is impermanent, decaying, unstable, and swiftly disintegrating. It is like a prisoner awaiting execution whose life will not last long. It is like a prison in which no one takes delight. It is like fruit on a roadside tree, pelted by all who pass. This body is loathsome and destined for destruction. Crows, magpies, foxes, and wolves compete to devour it. Wind blows upon it, the sun dries it; it turns blue, rots, and festers. Hair, teeth, and nails scatter upon the ground. How could such a body be worthy of attachment? One should diligently strive through skillful means to seek liberation."

The courtesan's understanding opened, and she attained the purification of the Dharma eye. When she died, she was reborn in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.

Through contemplating the nature of all phenomena as suffering, empty, and impermanent, Upagupta immediately attained the fruit of a non-returner.

Śāṇakavāsa then went to Gupta and told him: “You previously made a promise to give me your son. Now that he has grown, will you give him to me?”

Because Upagupta was by nature skilled in commerce, Gupta was reluctant and again refused.

The venerable one said: “The Buddha prophesied that this person, a hundred years from now, would greatly serve the Buddha’s work and benefit sentient beings. You should open your heart and give me this son.”

Hearing this, Gupta consented to his leaving home. Śāṇakavāsa brought him to the monastery, ordained him, and conferred the full precepts upon him. When the ordination ceremony was complete, Upagupta attained the path of the arhat, with the three clear knowledges, six supernormal powers, and the eight liberations fully accomplished. He was skillful in speech, and his expositions were inexhaustible.

He thought to himself: “I have now beheld the Dharma body, but I have never seen the Tathāgata’s physical body adorned with the major and minor marks.” Having reflected on this, he was filled with deep longing and sorrow.

At that time there was an old bhikṣuṇī, one hundred and twenty years of age, who had once seen the Tathāgata. Upagupta knew that she had seen the Buddha and wished to visit her. He first sent a messenger to inform the bhikṣuṇī: “The Venerable Upagupta wishes to come and see you.”

The bhikṣuṇī then filled a bowl to the brim with oil and placed it behind the door. When Upagupta arrived at her dwelling and entered the room, he spilled several drops of oil.

After exchanging greetings, they sat down together. He asked: “Elder sister, when the World-Honored One was in the world, how did the bhikṣus conduct themselves in their deportment and manner?” [306b]

The bhikṣuṇī replied: “In the past, when the Buddha was in the world, the group of six bhikṣus were the most coarse and unruly. Yet when they entered this room, they never spilled so much as a single drop

of water. Great Virtue, today you are praised for your lofty wisdom, and people in the world call you ‘the Buddha without marks.’ Yet upon entering my room, you spilled several drops of oil. From this I can tell that the people of the Buddha’s time were truly marvelous.”

When Upagupta heard these words, he was deeply remorseful and filled with shame. The bhikṣuṇī said: “Great Virtue, you should not feel ashamed or resentful. As the Buddha himself said: ‘After my parinirvāṇa, the people of the first day will be superior to those of the second, and the people of the third day will be still more inferior.’ In this way, merit and virtue progressively decline, and foolishness and dullness increase while wholesome qualities weaken and diminish. How much more so now, Great Virtue, when a hundred years have passed since the Buddha? Although you may commit breaches of deportment, it is only fitting for the times. Why should it be thought strange?”

Upagupta then asked: “Sister, when you saw the Tathāgata, what was it like?”

The bhikṣuṇī replied: “In the past, when the Buddha was in the world, I was twenty years old and was about to be married. I lost a gold hairpin, which fell into deep grass. I searched but could not find it. I then searched with a lamp, looking everywhere until I was exhausted, but could not find even a trace of it. Just then, the Tathāgata happened to pass by on his wandering. His golden radiance blazed like a hundred thousand suns. The darkest places all became brilliantly illuminated, and the most minute objects were clearly revealed. I immediately saw my hairpin and retrieved it. It was on this occasion that I saw the Buddha.”

When Upagupta heard this account, his longing and admiration doubled, and he exclaimed that it was something rare and unprecedented.

Śāṇakavāsa then told him: “The Buddha prophesied that you, one hundred years after his passing, would be foremost in sitting meditation and would greatly transform sentient beings. Now is precisely that time. You should bring benefit, causing all sentient beings to taste the flavor of the sweet dew of immortality.”

Upagupta replied: “Yes, I accept your instruction.”

In the land of Mathurā, he gathered a great assembly like clouds converging. He sat as during the half-month observance and taught the Dharma, expounding the doctrine of giving, the doctrine of morality, and

the doctrine of rebirth in heaven; that desire is impure, and that renunciation is the highest good.

Māra Pāpīyas became anxious and fearful, thinking: “Upagupta has gathered a great assembly. He will certainly teach them to escape from my realm. I must go and destroy their resolve.”

During the Dharma teaching, Māra rained down genuine gold and jewels, or rained down garlands of flowers of radiant and pure colors. He conjured a white elephant adorned with the seven treasures. He manifested as a woman of extraordinary beauty. The entire assembly gazed at these spectacles, and no one had any mind to listen to the Dharma.

For three days, Upagupta expounded the deep flavor of the Dharma, yet not a single person attained the Way. Māra was delighted and congratulated himself.

Upagupta then entered samādhi, contemplating and investigating who had done this. Māra again placed a garland of genuine pearls around his neck. The venerable one examined this and knew it was the work of Māra. He reflected: “The evil Māra, out of jealousy and malice, disrupts and corrupts the true Dharma. Why did the Tathāgata not subdue him?” He then contemplated the Buddha’s intention: the Buddha had left it for him to do.

He then took three corpses, a snake, a dog, and a human, and transformed them into garlands of flowers. He used these to lure Māra to come, and said to him: “You gave me garlands, a deeply considerate and generous gift. Now I offer these in return.”

Māra was greatly pleased and stretched out his neck to receive them. But once they were on his neck, they reverted to their true form as decaying corpses, with worms and maggots crawling out, reeking and foul beyond endurance. Seeing this, Māra was overcome with revulsion.

He said to Upagupta: “Why have you tied these corpses around my neck?”

The venerable one replied: “A bhikṣu should not be adorned with garlands of flowers. You, with evil intent, placed them on me. Now I place putrid corpses on you in return. It is only fitting. You should not be angry.”

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Māra used his supernatural power to try to remove the corpses, but they were like Mount Sumeru, immovable. He erupted in great fury, leapt into the sky, and went before the hosts of heaven, begging them to remove the corpses. All the devas replied: “This is the work of a great saint. We, who are merely ordinary, how could we remove it?”

He then went to Brahmā and begged to be freed from the corpse-bonds. Brahmā answered: “This is the supernatural power of a disciple of the One of Ten Powers. How could I, who am ordinary and humble, undo it? Even if the fires at the end of the kalpa were to blaze and the fierce winds of the whirlwind were to blow, they could not release these corpse-bonds. You might sooner hang Mount Sumeru with a lotus fiber than free yourself from these corpses. There is no such possibility. Just as one who has fallen because of the ground must rise again by relying on the ground, if you take refuge in Upagupta, these corpse-bonds may possibly be released.”

Thereupon Māra Pāpīyas, heeding Brahmā’s instruction, cast aside his arrogance and gave rise to deep faith and reverence. He went to the venerable one’s dwelling, prostrated himself with all five limbs touching the ground, and said: “Great Virtue, when the Buddha first attained enlightenment and sat beneath the King of Trees, I led my host of officers and soldiers to press in upon him. From then on, my harassments and disturbances were beyond counting, yet the Buddha never uttered a single harsh word or showed me contempt. His great compassion was as vast as Mount Sumeru. But you, an arhat, have little compassion and patient endurance. Before gods and humans, you have humiliated me.”

Upagupta replied: “Pāpīyas, you are greatly foolish and lack wisdom. You compare a śrāvaka to the Tathāgata. It is like trying to equate a mustard seed with Mount Sumeru, the light of a firefly with the radiance of the sun and moon, or the water in an ox’s hoofprint with the volume of the great ocean. The great compassion of the Tathāgata does not exist in the Two Vehicles. For this reason, the Buddha did not retaliate against you. I am narrow and inferior, with little compassion and patient endurance. For this reason, I have humiliated you. Furthermore, the Tathāgata intended that I, coming after him, should subdue you. Through this cause, you would give rise to reverence and faith in the Buddha. Through this wholesome thought, you would not fall into the three evil

destinies. It would wash away your defilements and shatter your evil karma.”

When Māra heard this, he was filled with great joy. The hair on his entire body stood on end, and he was filled with a sense of wonder. He said: “Benevolent one, it is through you that I have given rise to this mind of reverence and faith. You have brought me great benefit. Now I beg you to release me from these three corpses.”

The venerable one replied: “You must no longer disturb and harm the true Dharma. Only then will I release you.”

Māra said: “I accept your instruction.”

The venerable one then said: “I have never been able to see the Tathāgata’s physical form. You have seen him in the past. Please manifest his form for me.”

Māra replied: “Benevolent one, when I manifest the Buddha’s body, please do not bow to me.”

Upagupta answered: “I shall do as you say.”

He then released Māra from the three corpses.

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Māra entered a forest grove and transformed his appearance into that of the Buddha, complete with the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks. His form was extraordinary, like a mass of molten gold. His radiance was brilliant, and his bearing was serene and dignified. He manifested bhikṣus surrounding him before and behind. Like a king of geese in stately procession, he emerged from the forest.

When Upagupta saw this, he was filled with joy. Gazing single-mindedly, he spoke this verse:

Alas, impermanence, devoid of all compassion,
Can destroy even such a supremely wondrous body as this.

Upagupta gazed intently, his eyes never turning away for a moment. With surging joy within, he spoke these verses of praise:

How excellent, this pure karma,
That can produce such a wondrous fruit!
Not born from a sovereign deity,
Nor made without any cause.
His face is like purple gold,
His eyes are pure as blue lotuses.

His beauty surpasses the sun and moon,
His splendor excels a grove of flowers.
Serene as the great ocean,
Unmoving as Mount Sumeru.
His step is steady as a lion's,
His gaze is like a bull king's.
Through immeasurable hundreds of thousands of kalpas,
He purely cultivated body, speech, and mind.
Therefore he obtained
Such an extraordinarily wondrous body.
Even an enemy, seeing it, would rejoice;
How much more should I not be filled with gladness!

After Upagupta spoke these verses, his mind was so wholly absorbed in contemplating the Buddha that, without realizing it, he bowed in reverence. Māra said: "Benevolent one, why have you done this?"

He answered: "Pāpīyas, I know the World-Honored One passed into nirvāṇa long ago. Yet seeing this appearance, it is as if I were beholding the Buddha himself. Joy surged forth from within me, and so I bowed."

Māra resumed his original form and returned to heaven.

On the fourth day, Māra descended once more and proclaimed in a great voice to all: "All benevolent ones, if you wish to attain wealth and joy and be reborn among humans and devas, or if you seek nirvāṇa, the foremost peace and security, yet have not seen the Tathāgata teaching the Dharma with great compassion, you should all go to Upagupta. Listen and receive the wondrous Dharma, and cultivate it with your whole hearts."

When the men and women, great and small, of the city of Mathurā heard that the venerable one had subdued the evil Māra, hundreds of thousands of myriads of people gathered together like clouds. Upagupta ascended the lion's seat and, according to the capacities of each, taught various Dharma teachings. Hundreds of thousands of beings attained the fruit of stream-entry. Eighteen thousand persons attained arhatship. From this time onward, those he converted were beyond measure.

He brought great benefit to King Aśoka. That king's merit was deep, far-reaching, and surpassing. He had attained unshakable faith in the

Three Treasures. It was through wholesome causes that he obtained this supreme fruit.

Long ago, when the Buddha was dwelling in the Kalandaka Grove, the time for the daily meal arrived, and he led the bhikṣus into the city to beg for food. Along the way, he saw two boys. One was named Jaya, the other Vijaya. They had built a city, houses, and granaries out of earth, calling them by the names of rice, millet, hemp, and wheat, and had gathered these into the granaries. The Tathāgata's radiance illuminated everything, turning it all to the color of gold, utterly pure and clear.

Jaya, filled with joy, scooped up what he called parched grain and offered it to the Tathāgata. Being too small to reach, Vijaya knelt down so that Jaya could climb up and present the offering. The World-Honored One then gently smiled. [307b]

At that time, Ānanda promptly asked the Buddha: "For what reason does the Tathāgata display this smile?"

The Buddha told Ānanda: "Do you see these two boys?"

"Yes, I have seen them."

"This boy, one hundred years after my passing, shall become a king possessing one-quarter the power of a wheel-turning monarch, ruling with the true Dharma from the city of Pāṭaliputra. He shall distribute my relics far and wide and build eighty-four thousand jeweled stūpas."

The Buddha then gave this earth to Ānanda, who used it to plaster the southern wall of a room, and it was just enough to cover it entirely.

One hundred years later, the boy was indeed reborn as king. However, he was cruel and tyrannical, killing many. He constructed a prison-city called "Outwardly Delightful," and appointed a wicked man named Gīrika as its warden. He established great cauldrons of boiling water, iron balls, swords, and knives, and all such instruments were fully provided. Anyone who entered from outside was subjected to punishment.

A certain elder's son had left the household life to follow the Way. While wandering on his begging rounds, he entered the Delightful Prison and immediately tried to leave. Gīrika stopped him. The bhikṣu then raised his voice and wept bitterly.

The jailer asked: "Why do you weep?"

The bhikṣu replied: “I do not fear death for my own sake, but for the sake of wholesome benefit. I have only just left home and have not yet tasted the flavor of the Way. A human body is difficult to obtain, and the Buddha-Dharma is difficult to encounter. Now I have encountered both, only to die in vain. Reflecting on this, I weep with great sorrow.”

Gīrika replied: “The king has standing orders: whoever enters this prison is never permitted to leave.”

The bhikṣu said: “Since I am certainly going to die, I ask for a reprieve of seven days, after which I shall submit to execution.”

The jailer thereupon granted his request.

[307c] At that time, certain palace women of King Aśoka were found dallying with other men. The king was furious and had them sent to the prison for punishment. They were immediately crushed with iron pestles until they were reduced to dust. Their flesh and bones were scattered like gathered foam.

Observing this, the bhikṣu was filled with deep revulsion and exclaimed: “Truly what the Great Compassionate One said is sincere and true! He taught that form is impermanent, likening it to bubbles and mirages, unstable, swiftly disintegrating, and extremely difficult to preserve. These women were once fair and radiant of countenance. Now if one searched for that beauty, where would it be found? Human life is illusory and cannot be safeguarded. Whether noble or humble, foolish or wise, though people differ in their stations, all alike share this death. It is like a hundred rivers whose springs have different sources, yet not one stream fails to flow into the great ocean. Humans likewise all proceed toward the place of death. According to the length or brevity of their karma, their lives are long or short. Before much time has passed, they too shall come to an end. This body is foul, impure, and loathsome. Covered by a thin skin, one falsely gives rise to thoughts of love. One does not observe the various evils within. How strange is this cycle of birth and death, which only the deluded enjoy! It is not something in which the noble and wise would let their minds dwell with relish.”

Contemplating in this way from nightfall until dawn, the bhikṣu severed all fetters and attained the fruit of stream-entry. Redoubling his efforts, he then attained the path of the arhat.

When the seven days were complete, Gīrika said: “Your time has come. You shall now be executed.”

The bhikṣu replied: “My night has passed; my day has dawned. What needed to be done has been accomplished. Do with me as you will.”

Gīrika flew into a rage and placed him in a cauldron to be boiled. But though the flames blazed fiercely, the water grew ever cooler and more refreshing. Astonished at this, Gīrika went to look into the cauldron and saw that within it had grown a thousand-petaled lotus flower, upon which the bhikṣu sat cross-legged.

Gīrika immediately went to report to the king. The king came with his retinue to observe. The bhikṣu then leapt into the air and performed the eighteen transformations. Witnessing this, the king exclaimed that it was something rare and unprecedented.

He said: “We share the same human form, yet the difference in majestic virtue is this great! I do not yet understand. I beg you to explain.”

The bhikṣu, wishing to convert the king, spoke thus: “I have severed all fetters, gained liberation from the three realms of existence, departed from all disturbance, and dwell in serene peace and joy. Great King, you should know that the Buddha prophesied about you: one hundred years after his passing, you would rule in Pāṭaliputra, distribute his relics, and broadly erect jeweled stūpas. How then can you engage in such evil, harming sentient beings without a heart of compassion? The king should now fulfill the Buddha’s intent and bestow upon sentient beings the joy of fearlessness.”

Hearing this, the king was filled with deep remorse and self-reproach. He took refuge in the Three Treasures and gave rise to a mind of reverent faith. He collected the meritorious relics of the Tathāgata and built eighty-four thousand jeweled stūpas.

When the stūpas were completed, he went to the Kukkuṭārāma monastery, joined his palms, and asked the senior elder Yaśas: “In this Jambudvīpa, is there anyone who, like me, was prophesied by the Buddha?”

Yaśas answered: “The Buddha prophesied that the Venerable Upagupta, one hundred years after his passing, would bring about great benefit.”

The king asked again: “Has that pure person already appeared in the world?”

He answered: “Great King, he was born into the world long ago and has attained the path of the arhat. On Mount Urumūṇḍa, surrounded by his assembly, he teaches the Dharma.”

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The king immediately prepared his royal carriage to go and pay homage. He first sent a messenger to announce: “Great Saint, King Aśoka wishes to come and pay his respects.”

The venerable one reflected: “This place is narrow and cramped, and cannot accommodate many people. I should go to him in person.” He then made preparations and set out toward Pāṭaliputra.

When the king heard this, he was overjoyed. He had the streets swept and cleaned, incense burned, flowers scattered, and various music performed. He then went forth with his ministers to welcome the venerable one. Upon seeing him, he prostrated with all five limbs touching the ground, gazing up at him with his whole heart, his eyes never turning away for a moment.

He said: “Great Saint, I rule as king with freedom and happiness, yet it does not compare to the joy of this single meeting with you today.” With great joy in his heart, he spoke this verse:

Though the Buddha has entered the stillness of nirvāṇa,
The Venerable One has been born as his successor.
Now may you bestow your instructions upon me,
And I shall follow and learn accordingly.

Thereupon the venerable one placed his hand on the king’s head and answered with this verse:

Be careful, fearful, and never heedless;
Royal rank and riches are hard to hold.
All things must come to change and dissolution;
In this world nothing abides forever.
The Three Treasures are rare, yet you have met them now;
You should always make offerings, never ceasing.

King Aśoka then invited the venerable one into the palace, personally escorted him to a jeweled seat.

He said: “Great Saint, wherever the Buddha traveled, wherever he walked or stood, I wish to erect stūpas to increase the faith of the multitudes.”

The venerable one praised him: “Excellent! Excellent! I shall now accompany you and show you all the places.”

He then prepared the four divisions of the army, and together they set out. He showed the king the Lumbinī garden, the place of the Buddha’s birth, and so forth, until they arrived at the city of Kuśinagara, the place where the Buddha, having completed his work of conversion, entered parinirvāṇa.

When the king heard of this, he fainted and collapsed to the ground. Only when cold water was sprinkled on his face did he regain consciousness.

At all these places, the king erected stūpas and donated hundreds of thousands of gold coins before departing.

The venerable one then showed the king the merit-stūpas of Śāriputra, [308b] the five hundred arhats, and others. The king paid homage to each and offered gold in worship. Finally they came to the stūpa of Bakkula.

The king asked: “What merit is associated with this stūpa?”

He answered: “Great King, the Buddha declared that this person was free from all decline and illness. Long ago in the past, ninety-one kalpas ago, after the parinirvāṇa of Vipasyin Buddha, Bakkula was living in a certain monastery. He saw wealthy and noble people coming to make offerings to the assembled monks. At that time, Bakkula was drunk and lying in bed. He thought to himself: ‘I am poor and destitute; what can I offer? All I have is one myrobalan fruit. If any monk in the assembly has an illness, I can offer it to cure his affliction.’

He then sounded the bell and announced: ‘I offer medicine.’

At that time, there was a bhikṣu suffering from a severe headache. He went to the one who dispensed medicine and asked for a myrobalan fruit. The dispenser said: ‘Someone has offered medicine. You may take it.’ The bhikṣu went and obtained the medicine. After taking it, his illness was immediately cured.

Because of this cause, for ninety-one kalpas Bakkula was reborn among humans and devas and was never once afflicted with illness.

In his final birth, he was born into a Brahmin family. His mother died early, and his father took a second wife. When Bakkula was still a small child, he saw his stepmother making flatbread and asked her for some. The stepmother, jealous and malicious, harboring hatred in her heart, seized him and threw him into the bread oven. The flames blazed fiercely, and she placed a griddle on top. When his father returned from outside and searched everywhere for the child, he found his son inside the oven, unharmed.

On another occasion, the stepmother was boiling meat. The little boy again went and asked for some. The mother grew even more enraged and threw him into the pot. The broth was boiling furiously, yet it did not scald or injure him. When the father searched again but could not find him, he said: ‘Where is my son now?’ Bakkula called out from inside the pot. The father pulled him out, completely unharmed as before.

On a later occasion, the stepmother went to a riverbank. Bakkula clung to her garments and followed behind. The mother was filled with fury and exclaimed: ‘What kind of ghost or demon is this monstrous creature? Though I have tried burning and boiling, I cannot kill it!’ She then picked him up and threw him into the river. A great fish immediately swallowed him. Yet because of his merit, he still did not die.

A fisherman caught this fish with a hook and brought it to the market to sell. He asked a high price, and no one would buy it. From morning until evening, it was about to spoil. Bakkula’s father happened to be walking through the market. Seeing the great fish, he thought: ‘This fish has a great deal of flesh. It is about to go bad, so the price must be low. I should buy it and take it home.’

He gave the fisherman his money, took the fish home, and began to cut it open with a sharp knife. Bakkula, from inside the fish’s belly, called out in a loud voice: ‘Father, please be careful! Do not hurt me!’

The father opened the fish’s belly and drew him out, holding him in his arms. As Bakkula grew up, he left home under the Buddha and attained the path of the arhat, fully endowed with all virtues. He lived to the age of one hundred and sixty, and was never once ill, not even suffering so much as a fever or a headache. He was of few desires and easily contented, always delighting in quietude and seclusion. He never taught anyone even a single verse of four lines.”

When the king heard this, he ordered that a single coin be offered to the stūpa. The chief minister said to the king: “He too was an arhat. Why do you offer only a single coin?”

The king told his minister: “Because he only liberated himself and could not transform others.”

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The spirit of the stūpa refused to accept even that and returned the coin to the king.

The minister said: “He is truly one of few desires. He will not accept even a single coin; how much less would he accept more?”

In this way, each of the five hundred great arhats had his own past-life story, which is here abbreviated and not recounted in full.

When King Aśoka had finished making offerings to the stūpas of the Tathāgata and the śrāvakas, he joyfully joined his palms and spoke this verse:

Through hundreds of thousands of sacrifices one barely gains a
human birth;

Yet now I have not received this life in vain.

Meeting a fine field of merit, I have accomplished excellent
deeds.

With perishable, fragile wealth I have cultivated the enduring
Dharma.

The stūpas I have raised adorn Jambudvīpa,
Like white clouds adorning the sky.

After speaking this verse, he bowed in reverence and departed.

He went to the bodhi tree and declared: “I now wish to perform two kinds of meritorious deeds. First, I shall fill a thousand vessels with fragrant water to irrigate the bodhi tree. Second, I shall establish a pañcavārṣika assembly.”

He then bathed himself, put on new, clean garments, ascended a high tower, bowed to the four directions, and proclaimed: “May all the holy ones accept my invitation.”

No sooner had he spoken than arhats from the ten directions flew through the air and arrived. Holy ones of the three paths, numbering two hundred thousand in all, also gathered like clouds. Yet the place of honor for the senior elder remained empty; no one dared to sit there.

The king asked the assembly of monks: “Why is this seat left empty?”

Yaśas answered: “There is a great arhat named Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja, designated by the Tathāgata as one who can roar the lion’s roar, whose majestic virtue is lofty and supreme. He will come here presently.”

When the king heard this, the hair on his entire body stood on end, like an utpala lotus first beginning to bloom. He joined his palms and gazed upward in anticipation.

[309a] Then Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja, together with numerous arhats, descended from the sky like a king of geese in flight. The entire assembly rose in respect.

The king saw that the venerable one’s eyebrows and hair were elegantly white, and his body possessed marks of distinction like a pratyekabuddha. He bowed in reverence, prostrating with all five limbs touching the ground, and asked: “Great Saint, have you seen the Tathāgata?”

He answered: “I have seen him. His form was like a mass of gold, his face like the full moon. The thirty-two marks adorned his body. His Brahma-voice was deep and wondrous; he was a dwelling-place of great compassion.”

The king asked further: “Where did you see him?”

The venerable one answered: “In the city of Rājagṛha. During the summer retreat, I was among the assembly and beheld the supreme field of merit.” He continued: “When you, in a past life, offered earth to the Buddha, and the Buddha prophesied about you at that time, I was also present and witnessed it.”

Thereupon the king offered everything in his kingdom: his wives, children, retinue, gold, silver, lapis lazuli, cattle, sheep, fields, and dwellings, as well as his own person and palace women, all given to the assembly of monks. He requested that the pañcavārṣika assembly be held in his name and irrigated the bodhi tree. Afterward, he personally prepared and served food to the monks.

At that time, Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja poured ghee over his rice. The king said: “Great Saint, ghee is hard to digest. Will it not cause illness?”

The venerable one answered: “It will not. Why? Because water in the Buddha’s time was equal to ghee today. Therefore, eating it will not produce illness.”

The venerable one then wished to verify this claim. He extended his hand down into the earth, reaching a depth of forty-two thousand and more leagues, and brought up the rich essence of the earth to show the king.

“The king should know that because sentient beings’ merit is meager, the rich and fatty flavors have all seeped into the earth. This is why the blessings of the world continue to decline.”

Having completed the offerings, the king departed in joy.

The king had a younger brother named Śūdra, whose wrong views were fierce and who harbored hatred toward śramaṇas. The king, through skillful means, caused him to reform his wrong-minded views. Śūdra immediately left home and attained the path of the arhat. Later, he was killed by a member of the Qiang people.

The assembly had doubts and questioned Upagupta: “For what reason was Śūdra, born into such noble eminence, killed by a Qiang person?”

The venerable one answered: “Listen well, and I shall explain. Long ago in the distant past, during the time of Kāśyapa Buddha, Śūdra once made offerings to the assembly of monks. Because of this meritorious deed, in every life he was always born in a position of honor, wealth, and nobility. Yet in another past life, he was a hunter. He spread out his nets but caught no birds. Seeing a pratyekabuddha, he gave rise to hatred in his heart and immediately took a sharp sword and beheaded him. Because of this karma, he fell into the great hells. In every subsequent life, he was always killed by others. Although he had attained the fruit of the Way, he still suffered this bitter retribution.”

Fascicle Four

King Aśoka also had a son named Dharmavṛddhi, whose countenance was handsome and whose eyes were remarkably beautiful. At that time there was a bird called kuṇāla, whose eyes were bright and pure, resembling those of the boy. For this reason the prince was given the name Kuṇāla. When he came of age, a wife was chosen for him, named Suvarṇamālā. The king brought his son to the Kukkuṭārāma monastery. The elder Yaśas, knowing that the prince would lose his eyes, told him: “The eyes are impermanent; in time they will surely decay and cannot be relied upon. You should diligently strive and seek the supreme liberation.” Kuṇāla received this instruction and returned to the palace. He contemplated how these eyes were marked by suffering, emptiness, and deterioration.

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The king’s chief queen was named Tiṣyarakṣā. She conceived an intense infatuation for Kuṇāla. Burning with the fire of desire, she pressed him to lie with her. But the prince was by nature chaste and pure; his resolve was firm, and he would not comply. Tiṣyarakṣā became deeply enraged.

At that time, Kuṇāla was governing in the city of Taxila. The chief queen constantly watched for an opportunity. It happened that the king fell gravely ill, his condition extremely critical. The queen treated and cured him, and his illness was swiftly removed. She then requested seven days of authority to act in the king’s place. Having received his permission, she sought to carry out her revenge. She secretly composed a sealed letter ordering that Kuṇāla’s eyes be gouged out.

The prince obeyed the command and sought out a vile person, who removed his right eye and placed it in his palm for him to behold. He then recalled the admonition that the elder Yaśas had originally given

him, and spoke these words: “True indeed was the venerable one’s teaching, sincere and not false. He said the eyes are impermanent, like an illusion. In the past I considered these eyes rare and wondrous, but today, looking deeply, what is there to be attached to? I shall abandon this perilous and decaying dharma and devote myself to seeking the supreme, pure eye of wisdom.” While contemplating in this way, he attained the fruit of stream-entry. When the other eye was also removed, he again contemplated deeply. His revulsion reached its fullness, and he attained the fruit of once-returner.

His wife Suvarṇamālā, hearing that her husband’s eyes had been gouged out, wailed and wept tears like rain, rushing to him in alarm and grief. When she saw him, she fainted and collapsed, and only after a long while did she revive. Kuṇāla then spoke a verse to console her:

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In the past I committed unwholesome karma;
Today I myself receive its consequence.
All suffering in the world
Includes the parting of those bound by love.
You should reflect on this with care:
Why should you weep so bitterly?

The people of the city drove the husband and wife out, expelling them to a distant place. Wandering from place to place, they made their way toward Pāṭaliputra. Playing the lute and singing mournfully, they begged for alms to sustain their lives. They eventually reached the royal palace and found shelter in the elephant stable. There Kuṇāla played the lute and sang in a clear voice, recounting his own sufferings. The king, hearing the sound of the music, vaguely felt he recognized it. He sent someone to look, and it was indeed Kuṇāla. The king summoned him inside. When the king saw his son, he fainted and fell to the ground. He cried out in loud wailing, his body trembling. He asked Kuṇāla: “Who destroyed your eyes? Tell me at once! I shall punish them for their crime.”

Kuṇāla replied: “Has my father not heard? In the past, even the Tathāgata himself underwent the retribution of karma. Such retribution possesses great power. Whether one is a sage or a commoner, noble or humble, there is no means by which one can escape it. It was my own

past karma that brought this cruel calamity upon me. I beg the king not to grieve and let his heart be worn with sorrow.”

Although King Aśoka heard these words, the fire of anguish still burned in his heart. He spoke again to his son: “Who destroyed your eyes? I shall slaughter them and grind their bodies to dust.” Through successive questioning, he learned it was Tiṣyarakṣā. The king immediately summoned her and said: “How can the earth bear your weight without swallowing you up? You feigned closeness while secretly harboring enmity. For what reason did you destroy my son’s eyes? I shall now take the wheel of blades and the forest of swords to hack your body to fragments like dust. I shall cast your corpse in a place of filth and stench, and pour foul excrement and vile poison into your mouth.”

When Kuṇāla heard the king’s words, he gave rise to great compassion toward Tiṣyarakṣā. He addressed his father: “She committed this transgression out of ignorance. Because of this, she now suffers disgrace. The king is a wise man; how can he act the same way? If you now seek to retaliate against her, you will surely be bound together as enemies through many kalpas. If this continues in endless succession, when will it ever end? Great king, you should know this: just as an echo responds to a sound, so too does this body give rise to suffering. Moreover, this body is the root of all evils. For this reason, all Buddhas constantly teach us to relinquish it. If this body were truly a source of certain happiness, why would the wise always regard it with revulsion? Seen in this light, the body is the root of suffering, an accumulation of immeasurable evils. Great king, please listen further. Just as an infant in the world, not yet understanding propriety, will insult and show disrespect to its parents without any sense of humility, would such parents give rise to hatred toward their child? All sentient beings are the same. They are constantly obscured by afflictions; ignorant and without wisdom, they are like small children. How can one give rise to anger toward them?”

But the king’s rage was fierce, and he would not accept these words. He heaped up great piles of firewood and oil, and burned Tiṣyarakṣā to death.

At that time, the assembly raised their doubts and questioned Upagupta: “For what reason was this prince born into a noble family yet

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had his eyes gouged out?” The venerable one replied: “Listen well, and I shall explain. Long ago, in Vārāṇasī, there was a hunter who went to the snowy mountains. There happened to be a hailstorm, and five hundred deer took shelter together in a single cave. The hunter wished to kill them all, but then thought: ‘If I kill them all at once, they will all rot and decay. Better to gouge out their eyes and eat them gradually.’ He thereupon gouged out the eyes of all five hundred deer. Because of this deed, he receives retribution to this day.

“Furthermore, in the distant past, after the parinirvāṇa of Krakucchanda Buddha, there was a king in that country named Duanyan (Dignified Appearance). He collected the Buddha’s relics and built a stūpa of the seven treasures. Later, another king arose who had no reverent faith. He destroyed the stūpa and took the treasures, leaving only the earth and wood. The people of the entire country all wept in sorrow. A certain elder’s son came and asked why they wept. The people answered: ‘The jeweled stūpa of Krakucchanda Buddha has been destroyed. Because of this, we weep.’ When the elder’s son heard this, he immediately restored and repaired it, adorning it as splendidly as before. He crafted an image of that Buddha with marks of exceptional beauty. He then made a vow: ‘May I, in a future life, attain the supreme liberation like that World-Honored One.’ Because of this wholesome karma, he was born into a noble family and attained a pure and excellent fruit.”

The members of King Aśoka’s household were all like this: each relinquished the heavy burden and departed from birth and death. The king’s faith was profound and far-reaching, difficult to fathom. Whenever he saw śramaṇas, whether elder or young, he would always go forward to greet them, inquire after them, and bow to them with respect.

At that time there was a minister named Yaśas who lacked faith and reverence and was consumed by wrong views. He said: “King Aśoka is utterly lacking in wisdom. He demeans his own noble station by bowing to mere youths.” When the king heard this, he issued an order to all his ministers, commanding each to seek out the heads of various beasts. Only Yaśas was commanded to find a human head. They all received the king’s order and went searching. When they had obtained them, they all came to present them to the king. The king then commanded them to take them to the marketplace to sell. Before long, all the animal heads

were sold, but no one would buy Yaśas's human head. After several days, it was about to rot and stink. Yaśas reported: "Great king, this head is impossible to sell. No one even wants to look at it, let alone buy it."

The king asked Yaśas: "What thing is most precious?" He answered: "Great king, human beings are the most excellent." The king said: "If humans are the most excellent, why can this head not be sold?" Yaśas answered: "Though humans are precious while alive, once dead they become the most base." The king said: "Is my own head the same as this, or not?" Yaśas was frightened and, bowing low, replied: "The king's head is likewise base in the same way." The king said: "If my own head is base, then why do you find fault with me for paying reverence to the young? If you are truly my good spiritual friend, you should encourage me to exchange this fragile and perishable head for an indestructible one. Why do you instead try to stop me from doing good?" At this, the minister Yaśas repented and reproached himself. He turned from his wrong views and placed his faith in the Three Treasures.

On another occasion, the king asked Upagupta: "In the days when the Buddha was in the world, who gave the most?" The venerable one answered: "The elder Sudatta gave most generously. He covered the ground with gold amounting to ten billion coins in offering to the Tathāgata." The king thought to himself: "If he was able to give such an amount of treasure, how could I today fail to match him?" He then calculated all the gifts he had made previously, which came to nine billion, six hundred million gold coins. Then he fell gravely ill and knew his life was nearing its end. He wept and was overcome with great anguish.

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There was a minister named Rādhagupta, who was in fact the boy who in a former life had rejoiced along with Aśoka. Because of this merit, he had become a minister of state. His wisdom was vast and profound, and he was gifted in speech. Seeing the king's distress, he placed his palms together and said: "Just as the sun at its zenith is beheld by all, so too is the king's great virtue revered and respected by everyone. Now that the king has fallen ill, it is like the sun about to set; the people of the realm are all filled with sorrow and fear. May the great king hear what this minister has to say. The three realms are impermanent; all things flow and change, never remaining. Though youth, vigor, and old

age differ, they all eventually perish. It is like stone mountains closing in from all four directions; what wise person could escape? Sentient beings in the world are likewise: having received the body of the five aggregates, the mountain of death presses near. Even if one were to devise a hundred thousand skillful means, various mantras, hiding places, and means of escape, none has ever been seen who could be freed from this peril. Therefore you should know: all things in the world are impermanent, and all gatherings must end in parting. You should contemplate such principles deeply. Restrain yourself; why should you grieve?”

The king said to his minister: “I do not fear death, nor am I reluctant to part with my wealth and treasures. It is only that I must leave the company of the noble sages. I have given nine billion, six hundred million gold coins, but the full ten billion remains incomplete by four hundred million. It is for this reason that I grieve.”

Rādhagupta said: “The royal treasury still holds much. You may give until the amount is complete.” King Aśoka then gave the seven treasures to the Kukkuṭārāma monastery. He installed Kuṇāla’s son, Sampadin, as crown prince. A minister of wrong views told the prince: “King Aśoka is nearing the end of his life and is scattering the royal treasury. If you succeed to the throne, you will have nothing to draw upon. You should block this now and not comply with his wishes.”

Sampadin heeded the evil counsel. He sent the king’s food on a gold plate. The king immediately redirected the plate as an offering to the Kukkuṭārāma monastery. Afterward, food was sent to the king in an earthenware vessel with only half an āmalaka fruit. The king summoned his ministers and asked them: “In this Jambudvīpa, who is sovereign?” The ministers answered: “Only the king rules.” He replied: “That is not so. I have sovereignty over nothing more than this half āmalaka fruit.” Then he spoke: “Alas! Wealth and honor are truly despicable. Glory and rank are like illusions and will soon scatter and vanish. Though one dwells in the highest station, one ultimately falls. I was emperor of men, my majesty without equal. Yet at the end of my life I am destitute, possessing only half a fruit. Thus one should know that all things in the world are false and deceptive. Fools delight in them, but the wise and holy reprove them.” He then spoke a verse before his ministers:

True indeed is the Tathāgata’s teaching;

What he proclaimed is sincere and not false.
He broadly declared the perils of birth and death:
There is nothing therein worthy of delight.
I once occupied a position of honor,
My majesty and virtue scarcely matched.
Lesser kings and common people alike
Not one failed to look to me with reverence.
Today my merit is nearly exhausted;
Hunger and affliction bind and press me.
Like a torrent striking against a mountain,
Its force spent, it can flow no more.
In the past I relieved the destitute
And rescued those in suffering and distress.
How is it that today
I find myself in such a lowly state?
Now I truly know that noble rank
Is easily destroyed and not enduring.
The peace and joy of liberation
Is alone the supreme happiness.

Having spoken this verse, he commanded a minister: “Take this fruit to the Kukkuṭārāma monastery and convey my words thus: ‘King Aśoka bows at the feet of the assembled monks. I have sovereignty over nothing more than this half āmalaka fruit. Everything I once possessed has been entirely lost. Though this fruit is small, it is my final offering. I humbly pray that the assembled monks will take pity on my poverty and accept it.’” [310c]

The elder Yaśas addressed the assembled monks: “You should all observe this well. King Aśoka enjoyed blessings and pleasures and ruled over all under heaven. Now he has been seized and stripped of his power by his own ministers. He has sovereignty over nothing more than half a fruit. You should know that birth and death are truly worthy of revulsion. Wealth, honor, and the five desires soon decay. Authority and power vanish in an instant. Alas, the three realms of existence are difficult to dwell in for long.” He then instructed the refectory manager to grind this fruit and place it in the broth, so that all the monks might universally partake of his offering.

When King Aśoka was on the verge of death, he asked Rādhagupta: “In this Jambudvīpa, who holds sovereign authority?” Rādhagupta replied: “Only the king.” Upon hearing this, the king sat up and placed his palms together. He gazed in all four directions and said: “Excepting only the treasury, I now give the four seas and all the great earth to the Buddha and the Sangha. And all the merit I have accumulated from the past until now, I dedicate not to rebirth in saṃsāra as a wheel-turning king or as Indra, but pray that wherever I am reborn, I may swiftly realize the fruit of the path.” He placed the sealed document in the hands of Rādhagupta. Thereupon his breath ceased, and he passed away. He was buried with funeral rites befitting a wheel-turning king.

Thus the venerable Upagupta opened the king’s mind and caused his faith to grow. Through excellent skillful means he taught and transformed sentient beings.

On yet another occasion, in the city of Śūra, there was a merchant leader named Devagupta who was deeply devout. He wished to voyage across the great ocean to seek precious treasures, vowing that if he returned safely he would hold a pañcavārṣika assembly for the Sangha. He went to sea, gathered treasures, and returned safely. Having formed this intention, he prepared to hold the great offering assembly. There was a bhikṣuṇī who had attained arhatship. She examined the assembly to see who would be a field of merit, and further contemplated who was the head of the Sangha. She saw that the various arhats and learners had severed the impurities of affliction and were worthy of offerings. She then observed a certain bhikṣu named Aśāra, who had not yet attained liberation but occupied the highest seat in the Sangha.

[311a] The bhikṣuṇī went to him and said: “Venerable one, you should now adorn yourself.” The bhikṣu did not understand her meaning. He put on clean robes, shaved his head, and bathed.

Sometime later, the bhikṣuṇī again told Aśāra that he should adorn himself. Aśāra became extremely angry: “I followed your instructions and made myself thoroughly clean and proper. What fault do you find that you keep repeating this?” The bhikṣuṇī said: “Venerable one, you should know that this worldly adornment is not the adornment of the Buddhadharma. The adornment of the Buddhadharma is the attainment of the four fruits. How remarkable, venerable one, that you take this

matter so lightly! The elder Devagupta wishes to hold a great assembly. Those who receive his offerings will mostly be noble sages. You, as the head of the Sangha, have not yet escaped birth and death. With a mind still subject to defilements, you will be the first to receive offerings. For this reason I now wish to awaken you.”

When Aśāra heard this, his face fell in sorrow and he wept, thinking: “I am old and decrepit; how can I exhaust the defilements?” The bhikṣuṇī said: “The Buddhadharma knows no particular time; does it matter whether one is young, vigorous, or old? You should go and pay respects to Upagupta. He will surely enable you to be freed from all suffering.”

The bhikṣu went to Upagupta. He arrived just as the Sangha was bathing, and they all simultaneously manifested supernatural transformations. Aśāra was overjoyed and spoke this verse:

Assembled together in one place,
Cross-legged like coiling dragons,
All entering into tranquil absorption,
Silent and unmoving.
Each radiating a pure light
Like hundreds and thousands of suns,
Though they share the human form,
Their merit towers far above.

Upagupta, seeing that his faculties were mature and pliant, taught him the Dharma, and he became an arhat.

At that time there was also a lay devotee who told a Brahmin that there is no self. The Brahmin asked: “Who teaches this?” He answered: “Upagupta constantly proclaims no-self. ‘Self’ is merely a conventional expression based on the conjunction of conditions.” The Brahmin then went to the venerable one. Upagupta, knowing his thoughts, immediately proclaimed the doctrine of universal no-self: “It is like a voice echoing in an empty mountain. When you carefully examine and investigate, nothing whatsoever can be found. It is merely formed through the combination of the five aggregates. What wise person would regard it as truly real?” The Brahmin thereupon was enlightened and attained the fruit of stream-entry. He was then ordained as a monk and attained the path of arhatship.

[311b]

A young man of good family came to Upagupta to leave home and study the path. He was always fond of sleeping, lazy and indolent. Although the Dharma was taught to him, he gained nothing whatsoever. The venerable one instructed him to practice seated meditation beneath a tree. There beneath the tree he promptly fell asleep again. Upagupta conjured an illusion of a deep pit a thousand fathoms deep. When the bhikṣu saw it, he was seized with extreme terror. With single-pointed mind he called out to Upagupta. The venerable one then conjured a narrow path and enabled the bhikṣu to pass through it. He thought to himself: “My teacher saved me from this peril.” Upagupta then said to him: “This fear is trivial, hardly worth mentioning. Those who are born in the three realms suffer old age, sickness, and death. These constantly follow a person and never depart. The torments of hell come in hundreds of thousands of myriad forms. Such terrors far exceed this pit.” Thereupon the bhikṣu never slept again. Through diligent contemplation, he attained arhatship.

In a country to the east, there was a young man of good family who, having faith in and delight in the Buddhadharma, left home to study the path. He was skilled at managing affairs, and nothing he undertook failed to succeed. After a long time he grew weary and dejected. He went to the venerable Upagupta. The venerable one observed him and knew that because this bhikṣu’s store of merit was not yet complete, he had not attained the path. He therefore instructed him to go among the Sangha and travel about seeking alms.

Receiving this instruction, the bhikṣu entered the city and searched everywhere. A certain elder saw him and asked what he was doing. He answered: “Elder, the venerable Upagupta has sent me to seek offerings on behalf of the Sangha. In this city, who is truly devout?” The elder replied: “You need not go elsewhere. Whatever is needed, I shall provide.” He prepared the offerings. The bhikṣu received them and knelt before the senior monks, holding the food. All the assembled monks recited the words of blessing. When the blessing was completed, the bhikṣu attained arhatship.

There was a bhikṣu who was excessively fond of food and drink. Because of this greed, he could not attain the path. Upagupta invited him to his quarters. He gave him fragrant milk porridge and told him: “Wait

until it cools, then you may eat.” The bhikṣu blew on the porridge, and it quickly cooled. He told the venerable one: “The porridge has cooled.” The venerable one said: “Though this porridge has cooled, the fire of your desire is still hot. You should use the water of contemplation to extinguish the fire in your mind.” Then, taking an empty vessel, he made the bhikṣu spit out what he had eaten. After spitting it out, he told the bhikṣu to eat it again. The bhikṣu replied: “It is now mixed with saliva; how can it be eaten?” The venerable one said: “All food and drink is no different from this. Because you do not examine it carefully, you give rise to deluded attachment. You should now contemplate the perception of the impurity of food.” He then taught him the Dharma, and the bhikṣu attained the path of arhatship.

There was a bhikṣu who was deeply attached to and fond of his own body. Because of this attachment, he wished to return to lay life. He took leave of Upagupta and lodged for the night in a wayside temple. The venerable one conjured a yakṣa carrying a corpse on its back, who came to the temple. Then another ghost came from behind. The two ghosts quarreled over the corpse, arguing back and forth, unable to settle the matter. The first ghost said: “I have a witness,” and they both went to ask the bhikṣu: “Whose corpse is this?” The man was terrified and thought to himself: “Tonight I am certain to die regardless. Better to speak the truth and accept my destruction.” He told the first ghost: “This is your corpse.” The second ghost, enraged, tore off the man’s hands and feet. The first ghost then took the limbs of the dead body and attached them in their place. The man’s body was restored as before, no different from the original. The two ghosts then together ate the remaining flesh. When they had finished eating, they departed. The man’s attachment to his own body immediately ceased. He returned to the venerable one, left home, and practiced diligently. Before long he attained arhatship. [311c]

In southern India, there was a young man of good family who had left home to study the path. He was fond of his own body, bathing it and anointing it with fragrant oils, eating fine food, so that his body was fat and robust. He could not attain the path. He went to the venerable one and sought to receive the supreme Dharma. Upagupta observed this person and saw that because of his attachment to the body, he had not been able to exhaust the defilements.

He said: “Bhikṣu, if you can follow my instructions, I will teach you the Dharma.” He conjured a great tree and told the man to climb it. On all four sides he transformed the ground into pits a thousand fathoms deep. He told him to release his right hand, and then to release all his other limbs as well. At that moment the man completely surrendered his body and life. Having released his hands and feet entirely, he immediately reached the ground. He saw neither deep pits nor the great tree. The venerable one then taught him the essentials of the Dharma, and he attained the path of arhatship.

There was a bhikṣu whose mind was extremely miserly and greedy. Because of this, he could not attain the path. Upagupta instructed him to practice giving. He answered: “I am poor; what do I have to give?” Upagupta sent two of his disciples to sit on either side of the bhikṣu, and their bodies radiated light. The bhikṣu was delighted and, reducing his own portion, gave a small amount of food as an offering. Later, when he received fine food, he was filled with joy and thought: “With only a small gift I received so great a reward. If I gave more, the reward would be immeasurable.” His miserly heart was thereby shattered. The venerable one then taught him the profound Dharma, and he immediately attained the fruit of arhatship.

A young man of good family left home to study the path. Upagupta taught him the essentials of the Dharma, and he promptly saw the truth and attained the fruit of stream-entry. He then thought: “I have cut off the three fetters; what more need I strive for? I shall roam freely at my ease; at most it will take seven rebirths.” The venerable one said: “The dharma of birth and death is truly vile and despicable. It is like excrement: whether a lot or a little, it all stinks.” He then took the bhikṣu to a caṇḍāla village, where they saw a small child whose body was covered with foul sores, with worms and blood oozing out, in great suffering.

The venerable one asked: “Bhikṣu, do you see this child?” He continued: “This little child is a stream-enterer. When the Buddha was in the world, there was an arhat who had a small sore on his body. When he scratched it, it made a sound. The duty-distributor angrily said: ‘Does your body have festering worm-sores? You should go out to the caṇḍāla village!’ The arhat said: ‘You have now incurred an offense; do not speak such words.’ The duty-distributor immediately repented. Through

diligent practice he attained the fruit of stream-entry. But afterward he grew lax and did not strive for further advancement. Therefore he was reborn in this family and suffers this affliction.”

They went a little further and saw a person being burned by fire, his body charred and blistered, the agony unbearable. Going still further, they saw another person who had violated the king’s law and was impaled on a great wooden stake, crying out in anguish, in extreme suffering.

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The venerable one then asked the bhikṣu: “Have you seen these two people?” The bhikṣu replied: “Yes, I have seen them.” The venerable one said: “The first person is a once-returner. The one you saw afterward is a non-returner. Both were lazy and did not strive for further advancement. Therefore they were reborn in the human realm and suffer these torments. For this reason, you should now diligently exert yourself and seek liberation without delay.” Hearing this, the bhikṣu practiced day and night, and before long he attained the path of arhatship.

The venerable one then taught the essentials of the Dharma to a caṇḍāla’s son, who became a non-returner. At death he was reborn in the Pure Abodes heaven.

In the country of Mathurā, there was an elder who fathered a son. When the child reached the age of one, he died. In this manner, through six successive elders, each son died at the age of one. Finally, a son was born to a seventh elder’s family. When this child reached the age of seven, he was carried off by bandits.

Upagupta observed that this child was destined to attain the path in this very life. He conjured the appearance of the four divisions of an army, as if to capture the bandits. The bandits, seeing this, were terrified and begged for mercy, prostrating themselves. The venerable one taught them the essentials of the Dharma, and they attained the fruit of stream-entry. They presented the child to Upagupta. The venerable one then ordained this boy, along with the band of bandits, and they all left home. He taught them the wondrous Dharma, and they attained the path of arhatship.

He said to the child: “You should now observe your relatives and teach and convert them.” The child immediately perceived his parents from seven successive lives, all grieving and weeping, longing for their son. He went to the first family and said: “Elder, I am your son. Do not

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grieve so deeply.” He taught them the essentials of the Dharma, and they attained the first fruit of the path. In the same manner, through all six families, it was likewise.

A young man of good family, having faith in the Buddha, left home and, practicing seated meditation, attained the four worldly dhyānas. He believed he had reached the ultimate and had attained the fruit of arhatship. Upagupta, through his skillful means, sent this bhikṣu to another village. On the road, he conjured the appearance of traveling merchants, then manifested a band of five hundred brigands who, forming a gang, came to rob the merchants. They killed and hacked and stabbed, and bodies were scattered across the ground. The bhikṣu was seized with great terror and immediately knew he was not an arhat. He then thought: “If I am not an arhat, perhaps I am a non-returner.”

After the merchants had been destroyed and scattered, an elder’s daughter said to the bhikṣu: “I pray that the venerable one will go with me.” The bhikṣu replied: “The Buddha does not permit me to travel with a woman.” The elder’s daughter said: “I shall walk behind the venerable one at a distance.” Out of compassion, the bhikṣu walked ahead, looking back to check on her. The venerable one then conjured a great river. The woman said: “Venerable one, let us cross together.” The bhikṣu waded in below while the woman was upstream. The woman then slipped, sank, and fell into the river, crying out: “Venerable one, save me from this danger!” The bhikṣu pulled her out. At her touch, a sensation of smooth and delicate contact arose, and he gave rise to thoughts of desire. He then immediately knew he was not a non-returner. Intensely attracted to this woman, he desired to lie with her and led her to a secluded place. Only then did he see that it was Upagupta. He was overcome with deep shame and stood with his head bowed. The venerable one said: “You formerly declared yourself an arhat. How is it that you were about to commit such an evil act?” He took the bhikṣu to the monastery and instructed him to repent. He taught him the essentials of the Dharma, and the bhikṣu attained the path of arhatship.

There was a bhikṣu who practiced the contemplation of impurity. When his afflictions temporarily ceased to arise, he believed he had attained the holy path. Upagupta told him: “Bhikṣu, you should go to the country of Gandhāra.” The bhikṣu received the instruction and traveled

to that land. In that country there was an elder named Karahava who had fathered a daughter of exceptional beauty. The bhikṣu went to his house to beg for food. The daughter came out carrying food and smiled, baring her teeth. When the bhikṣu saw this, thoughts of desire arose. But because of his former practice of the contemplation of impurity, he took the image of the woman's teeth and contemplated them all as white bones. Through this contemplation he attained the path of arhatship. He reproached his former mind and spoke this verse:

Outwardly he appeared virtuous and good,
But inwardly he was stained with many attachments.
Upon seeing the true nature of things,
His mind was immediately liberated.

In the country of Mathurā, there was an elder's son who had newly taken a wife. A thought arose in his mind: "I wish to leave home and enter the Buddhadharma." He took leave of his parents. His parents replied: "We have only one son. Even in death we would not let you go; how much less while you are alive?" The son said: "If you will not let me go, I shall refuse to eat." Thereupon he fasted, from the first day until the seventh day was complete. His parents, fearing he would die, said: "We shall grant your wish. But after you have left home, come to see us." The son was overjoyed and took his leave. He went to Upagupta and humbly requested ordination. The venerable one immediately ordained him and allowed him to enter the path.

The young bhikṣu then thought to himself: "In the past I made a promise to my parents." He took leave of the venerable one and went to his family home. He saw his parents and his former wife. His wife said to him: "If you do not come back, I shall end my life." The bhikṣu's heart was filled with regret, and he wished to discard his precepts. He went to his teacher and said he wanted to return home. Upagupta said: "Just wait until tomorrow." The bhikṣu accepted his teacher's instruction and stayed the night at the monastery.

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During the night, the venerable one caused a dream to appear to the bhikṣu, in which he saw himself returning to his home. On that very day, his wife had suddenly died. His parents and relatives were preparing the funeral, sending her body to the charnel ground. In an instant the corpse

began to rot, and maggots and worms emerged. The flesh separated from the bones, and foxes and wolves fought over the remains. He awoke in shock and went to report to his teacher. The teacher said: “You should go and see whether it is truly as in your dream.” Borne by his teacher’s supernatural power, he instantly arrived at his home. His wife had indeed died, exactly as he had seen in the dream. Contemplating and examining this, he gave rise to deep revulsion. He thereupon attained the path of arhatship.

On Mount Urumūṇḍa there was an old tigress who had given birth to two cubs. Driven by starvation and exhaustion, she died. The two cubs, having lost their mother, were in dire distress. Upagupta went to them, gave them food, and spoke this verse:

All conditioned things are impermanent;
They are dharmas of arising and ceasing.
When arising and ceasing are themselves extinguished,
Tranquil extinction is bliss.

Day after day he brought them food and recited this verse. Before long the two tiger cubs died. They were reborn in the country of Mathurā, in a Brahmin family.

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Upagupta went to visit that household, coming alone without any attendant. The Brahmin said: “Why do you walk alone?” He answered: “Patron, I am a renunciant and have few servants.” The Brahmin said: “My wife is with child. If she bears sons, I shall offer them to you.” Later she gave birth to two sons of handsome countenance. Upagupta came to ask for them. The Brahmin said: “The children are still very young. When they have grown, I shall certainly give them to you.”

When they reached the age of eight, the venerable one came again to ask. The Brahmin gave him the elder son. The younger one also spoke up: “Let me go too!” They competed and argued, each wanting to leave home. Upagupta said: “Both of these children are destined to attain the path.” The Brahmin then entrusted both sons to the venerable one. He ordained them, and both attained arhatship.

He then told them to go and pick campaka flowers. They replied: “Great teacher, this tree is tall and lofty; we cannot reach it.” The venerable one said: “You are heavenly beings; do you not possess

supernatural powers?” The two novices then rose into the air, picked the flowers, and presented them as offerings. The venerable one stood with his other disciples and, witnessing their supernatural abilities, praised them as having never been seen before. Upagupta said: “These two novices were formerly the starving tiger cubs. You formerly criticized me for giving food to those tigers. Today you should behold their supernatural transformations.” The disciples, hearing this, were filled with a sense of wonder.

In the country of southern India, there was a man who had committed adultery with another man’s wife. His mother sternly rebuked him: “You should know that the nature of sexual desire is fraught with many transgressions. Moreover, because of this, there is no evil one will not commit. In the future you will certainly be born in a place of extreme suffering.” The son, enraged, killed his mother. He went to the other family seeking the woman but could not find her. His heart was filled with regret. He left home and entered the Buddhadharmā to practice the path. Before long he memorized and mastered the Tripiṭaka, became eloquent in speech, and gathered many followers. Together with his assembly, he went to the venerable one’s dwelling.

Upagupta observed this person and saw that he had personally committed the heinous crime of matricide and had no share in the fruit of the path. He simply remained silent and would not speak with him. The Tripiṭaka-bhikṣu, knowing the gravity of his offense, and seeing that the venerable one would not engage him, returned to his own dwelling.

There was a bhikṣu who, practicing seated meditation and contemplation, attained the worldly concentrations. He thereupon declared that he had attained the realization of the four paths. Later, while sitting under a tree, Upagupta conjured the appearance of a bhikṣu who came to his place. They exchanged greetings, and the conjured bhikṣu sat down to one side. The conjured one asked: “Under whom did you leave home?” He answered: “My teacher is named Upagupta.” The conjured one praised him: “Venerable one, excellent! Your teacher is the ‘Buddha without marks.’” He then asked: “Bhikṣu, what sūtras do you recite?” He answered: “I recite the scriptures of the Tripiṭaka.” The conjured one asked again: “What path have you realized?” He answered: “I have attained the fruit of arhatship.” “By what means did you realize

the fruit?” He answered: “Through worldly concentration.” The conjured bhikṣu said: “If one claims to realize the path through worldly concentration, that is false.” Hearing this, the bhikṣu was filled with deep remorse. With single-pointed diligence he attained arhatship.

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In the country of Kaśmīr, there was a bhikṣu named Sudarśana who had attained worldly concentration and possessed the five supernatural powers. When there was no rain, he could cause it to fall. He developed overweening pride, believing he had realized the holy path. Upagupta then conjured a drought lasting twelve years. The people were terrified and begged the venerable one for help. The venerable one said: “I cannot do this. In the country of Kaśmīr there is the bhikṣu Sudarśana, whose supernatural powers are supreme and who excels at summoning rain.” The people all went to beseech him. The bhikṣu then, using his supernatural power, flew through the air and arrived. He prayed for sweet rain, and it fell at once. The people rejoiced greatly and made lavish offerings to him.

Having received these offerings, Sudarśana gave rise to arrogance. But then he reflected: “An arhat has no conceited mind.” He went to the venerable one, humbly repented, and sought forgiveness. The venerable one taught him the essentials of the Dharma, and he attained the path of arhatship.

In southern India there was a bhikṣu of few desires who was content with little. He preferred coarse and worn clothing. His body was weak and emaciated, and he could not attain the path. Upagupta observed this person and saw that he should be able to attain the path in this life, but his body was too feeble. He provided him with clothing, fragrant oil, and foot ointments. Thereupon the bhikṣu immediately attained the fruit of arhatship.

In this way, Upagupta taught and transformed immeasurable sentient beings, and all of them attained the fruit of arhatship. For each person who attained the path, one tally stick was placed, each four inches in length, filling a stone chamber. The chamber was six zhang high, and its length and breadth were likewise. Thus his fame filled all of Jambudvīpa, and all the world called him “the Buddha without marks.”

When the conditions for his teaching were complete, Upagupta reflected: “I have now finished making the offering of the Dharma to the

Buddha. I have brought benefit, peace, and happiness to my fellow practitioners of the holy life. I have enabled the fourfold assembly to obtain great benefit. I have continued and upheld the true Dharma so that it would not be cut off. The time for nirvāṇa has arrived; I should now enter final extinction.”

He announced to the great assembly: “Seven days from now, I shall enter nirvāṇa.” At that time he gathered the arhats from the ten directions, along with learners and those who purely upheld the precepts, in numbers beyond reckoning, as well as immeasurable hundreds of thousands of lay devotees. The venerable one then rose into the air and manifested the eighteen transformations, causing the fourfold assembly to give rise to great faith. He then entered nirvāṇa without remainder and passed into final extinction. The tally sticks from the chamber were used as fuel for his cremation. The arhats of the ten directions also entered nirvāṇa. Humans and devas wept in sorrow, crying out in grief. They all gathered the relics and built stūpas to make offerings.

Fascicle Five

When Śāṇakavāsa was approaching nirvāṇa, he entrusted the Dharma to Upagupta, speaking these words: “Long ago, the Bhagavat entrusted the supreme Dharma to the Venerable Mahākāśyapa, desiring that sentient beings might grasp the great torch of illumination, forever leave behind all suffering, and attain the bliss of nirvāṇa. Kāśyapa in turn entrusted it to my master Ānanda. Ānanda then entrusted it to me. Now, as I am about to enter final extinction, I commit it to you. When you yourself later approach nirvāṇa, there will be a good man in the country of Mathurā who will appear in the world. His name will be Dhṛtaka. He has long cultivated vows and practice, and his eloquence is inexhaustible. You should later ordain him as a renunciant and entrust to him the complete Dharma eye.” Upagupta replied, “I respectfully receive your instruction.”

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Dhṛtaka

When the time came that the Venerable Upagupta’s conditions for teaching were nearly exhausted and he wished to enter nirvāṇa, he contemplated whether Dhṛtaka had yet appeared in the world. Reflecting upon this, he knew that he had not yet been born. At that time, the Venerable Upagupta, leading an assembly of bhikṣus, went to the household of that family. Gradually the assembly diminished, fewer and fewer, until at last Upagupta went alone. The boy’s father, the elder, asked, “Great Sage, do you have no attendants? Why do you travel alone?” Upagupta answered, “Elder, I am a renunciant and have no one to attend me. If there were someone available, I would gratefully accept such kindness.” The elder replied, “I am content with household life and

am unable to pursue the Way. But if a son is born to me hereafter, I will certainly offer him to serve you.” Upagupta said, “Excellent! That is a fine intention. Hold to this resolve and do not let it change or be regretted.”

But this elder’s sons, one after another, all died young while still in childhood. His last-born son was named Dhṛtaka. His countenance was remarkable and striking; he was bright, keen, and wise. He was skilled at studying the various treatises, scriptures, and records. Through cultivation in past lives, he had deeply planted roots of merit. Upagupta came to request the boy, and the elder joyfully handed him over with his own hands. He brought the boy to the monastery and ordained him as a renunciant. When he reached twenty years of age, he received the full precepts. At the time of the first announcement, he severed the fetters of the truth of seeing and attained the fruit of stream-entry. At the first proclamation of the ordination ceremony, he thinned the passions of lust, anger, and delusion, and attained the fruit of once-returning. At the second proclamation, the fetters of the desire realm were exhausted, and he attained the fruit of non-returning. At the third proclamation, he immediately severed the afflictions of all three realms, established the pure conduct, and became an arhat. The three kinds of clear knowledge shone far and wide; the six supernormal powers were fully perfected. He moved freely, appearing and vanishing, unobstructed and at ease.

Upagupta then addressed him, saying: “The Sun of Wisdom, the World-Honored One, in his universal compassion, wished to deliver sentient beings from the great suffering of birth and death. The Dharma he had gathered over immeasurable kalpas he entrusted to the Venerable Mahākāśyapa, to serve as a great lamp of illumination shining upon all the darkness of delusion, enabling all beings universally to study and practice, to sever the net of craving and emerge from the mire of desire. Kāśyapa in turn entrusted it to the bhikṣu Ānanda. After Ānanda’s passing, he entrusted it to my master Śāṇakavāsa. Śāṇakavāsa then entrusted it to me. Thus in unbroken succession the wheel of the Dharma has continually turned, sprinkling the flavor of sweet dew to cure the thirst of affliction. But now my task is accomplished, the time of nirvāṇa has arrived, and final extinction is not far off. I take this jewel of Dharma and entrust it to you. You should hereafter receive it, uphold it, and bear

it upon your head. Guard it diligently and protect it; do not let it be lost or diminished. Let the light of the Dharma illuminate the darkness of ignorance.

“Furthermore, Dhṛtaka, since the Tathāgata’s nirvāṇa, the sages and saints have been passing from the world. All the profound sūtras and treasured repositories of scripture shall gradually decline, falling to the ground. The world will grow dark, and beings will drift through birth and death. Why is this so? In the past, after my master Śāṇakavāsa entered final extinction, of the seventy-seven thousand sūtras of past-life stories, the full ten thousand sections of the Abhidharma treasury, and the eighty thousand sections of the pure Vinaya, all such teachings gradually diminished with him. When one person enters nirvāṇa, many teachings decline. How much more so when numerous sages and saints all enter final extinction together! The pure, wondrous, and supreme Dharma will be gone without remainder. Therefore I now earnestly entrust it to you. You should with utmost sincerity reverently accord with my intention. Toward all sentient beings, give rise to the thought of great compassion. Receive, uphold, and disseminate the Dharma; do not let it be cut off.”

Dhṛtaka said, “I respectfully receive the Venerable One’s instruction. I shall protect and guard this true Dharma, and for the sake of future generations I shall be an uninvited friend.”

Thereupon he proclaimed in succession the supreme flavor of the Dharma. Those he taught and liberated were exceedingly numerous and vast. When his conditions were exhausted, he entered nirvāṇa, and humans and devas alike were moved to grief. His relics were collected, and a stūpa of seven treasures was erected. Incense was burned, flowers were scattered, and offerings of every kind were made.

Micchaka

Long ago, when Dhṛtaka was approaching final extinction, he entrusted the Dharma to his foremost disciple, named Micchaka. This disciple was broadly learned and profoundly accomplished, possessing great eloquence. Dhṛtaka told him, “The Buddha entrusted the true Dharma to the great Kāśyapa. Thus in succession it was transmitted down to me. As I am about to enter nirvāṇa, I entrust it to you. You should hereafter

disseminate the eye of the world.” Micchaka replied, “Excellent! I receive your instruction.”

Thereupon he proclaimed and circulated the precious treasury of the true Dharma, causing sentient beings to open the path to nirvāṇa. When his conditions for teaching were exhausted and he was about to enter final extinction, he in turn entrusted the true Dharma to the Venerable Buddhanandin, commanding him to disseminate the supreme flavor of sweet dew.

Buddhanandin

Buddhanandin afterward broadly proclaimed and expounded the Dharma, turned the great wheel of the Dharma, and crushed the foes of Māra. He then entrusted it to Buddhamitra.

Buddhamitra

That person’s virtuous power was profoundly immeasurable. Through skillful means he taught sentient beings, causing them to leave wrong views behind and proceed toward the supreme path. He adorned himself with great wisdom, proclaimed the pure flavor of the Dharma, and crushed the heterodox schools. Such merits as these are inexhaustible. I shall now follow the account and relate a small portion of them.

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There was a great king who ruled the entire realm. He was brilliantly talented, courageous and fierce, broadly learned and profoundly accomplished. He revered the heterodox teachings and adhered to wrong views. Toward the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha, he constantly harbored contempt and slander.

Buddhamitra thought to himself, “My master Buddhanandin entrusted the Dharma to me. How shall I expound the supreme eye so that sentient beings may universally receive benefit?” He further reflected, “This king holds exceedingly wrong views. I should first go and subdue him. It is like felling a tree: if the trunk is toppled, how can the branches, leaves, flowers, and stems long endure?”

Having thought thus, for twelve years he personally carried a red banner and walked before the king. After a long time had passed, the

king took no notice whatsoever. Only after this period did the king suddenly inquire, “Who is this person walking before me?” He then summoned him and asked his purpose. Buddhamitra answered, “Great King, I am a man of wisdom, skilled in discourse. I wish to seek a test of skill before the king.”

The great king then issued a proclamation throughout the land that all the Brahmins, elders, householders, and those of sharp intelligence and broad learning who were skilled in speech should assemble at the Hall of True Victory to engage in debate with a certain śramaṇa. Thereupon all the heterodox teachers of wrong views, those of profound eloquence and extensive wisdom, who had mastered astronomy, geography, and every discipline, gathered in angry throngs like massing clouds.

The great king, upon the hall’s main platform, arranged provisions and spread cushions and mats. He burned incense, scattered flowers, and adorned the hall with splendor and purity. Buddhamitra ascended the Dharma seat and engaged the heterodox teachers in unrestricted debate. Those of shallow wisdom were refuted with a single statement. Those of greater cleverness were exhausted after two exchanges. When the king saw that every one of them had been thoroughly defeated, he personally engaged Buddhamitra in debate. The moment the king began his argument, he too was immediately overcome.

Buddhamitra then thought, “In debating with the king, I should not display my victory openly.” He said to the king, “Whether this argument is profound or shallow, the king can judge for himself.”

The king thereupon recognized his own defeat. He turned from his wrong views, changed his mind, and came to revere and have faith in the true Dharma. He took the threefold refuge and became a disciple of the Buddha, broadly proclaiming the Way and its teachings within his own kingdom.

At that time, in this country there was a Nirgrantha practitioner whose wrong views were blazing fiercely, who slandered the true Dharma, and who was keenly intelligent and accomplished in the art of calculation. Desiring to convert him, Buddhamitra went to him and became his student, receiving instruction in this art. In a short time, he completely mastered it all.

The Nirgrantha then raised his voice in vile abuse against the Buddha. Buddhamitra said to him, “Do not speak such words, lest you bring guilt upon yourself. The retribution for this will surely be to fall into the great hells.”

The Nirgrantha said, “How could you know such a thing?”

Buddhamitra replied, “If you do not believe me, you may calculate it for yourself. Once you have calculated, you will verify it yourself.”

The Nirgrantha then performed his own calculations and immediately saw that his body would surely fall into hell. Greatly terrified, he was struck with deep anxiety and remorse. He prostrated himself with his five limbs touching the ground before Buddhamitra and said, “Benevolent One, what can I do to be freed from this calamity?”

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Buddhamitra told him, “Nirgrantha, just as one who falls to the ground uses the ground to rise again, if you take refuge in the Buddha, this sin can be extinguished.”

The Nirgrantha then gave rise to great faith. With five hundred verses he praised the Tathāgata, repented his former sins, and deeply reproached himself. Buddhamitra then told him, “Because of this wholesome mental disposition and the conditions of this good karma, when your life ends you will certainly be reborn in heaven.”

The Nirgrantha further asked, “How do you know that I will be reborn in heaven?”

Buddhamitra said, “If you do not believe, calculate it yourself and seek the truth.”

The Nirgrantha then performed his calculations and saw for himself that his sins had been extinguished and that he would be reborn in heaven. Overjoyed, he humbly beseeched permission to leave home and become a renunciant.

Buddhamitra replied, “Today you should first inform your household and dependents. Afterward I shall ordain you.”

The Nirgrantha’s disciples numbered five hundred persons. He went to them and said, “I have encountered a superior truth and feel great joy and delight. I wish to leave home within the Buddhadharma and pursue the Way. You may now follow your own wishes. Seek out a brilliant teacher and receive the supreme Dharma from them.”

All his disciples addressed their master, saying, “We have always looked up to you as one sheltered beneath a great canopy of clouds. If the master enters the supreme Way, our hearts rejoice to follow.”

Thereupon the Nirgrantha, together with five hundred persons, went to the Venerable One’s abode and all left home together.

Thus the Venerable Buddhmitra’s noble reputation spread throughout all of Jambudvīpa. Those he taught and converted were sentient beings beyond measure. When his conditions were exhausted and he departed this life, his disciples were deeply moved with grief. They collected his relics and erected a stūpa, making offerings to it.

Pārśva

Long ago, when the Venerable Buddhmitra’s conditions for teaching were exhausted and he was about to relinquish his life, he addressed one of his disciples, the bhikṣu named Pārśva, saying, “You should hereafter broadly disseminate the sacred teachings and teach sentient beings, enabling them to attain liberation.” Pārśva said, “Great Master, I respectfully receive the Venerable One’s instruction. I shall with utmost sincerity guard and protect the true Dharma.”

This Pārśva Bhikṣu, due to past karma, had remained in his mother’s womb for more than sixty years. When at last he was born, his beard and hair were already white. He felt disgust toward the five desires and took no pleasure in household life. He went to the Venerable Buddhmitra, bowed his head to his feet, and sought to enter the Way. Buddhmitra ordained him as a renunciant and expounded the essentials of the Dharma for him. Just as a fresh, clean piece of white cloth readily takes dye, right there upon his seat he attained the path of an arhat. The three kinds of clear knowledge illuminated all things; the six supernormal powers were unobstructed. He diligently practiced austerities with vigor and courage. Never once did he allow his ribs to touch the ground in sleep. People therefore called him “Pārśva Bhikṣu,” the Rib Monk. He skillfully taught the essentials of the Dharma and converted sentient beings. When his work was accomplished, he entered nirvāṇa. His relics were collected and a stūpa was erected, with offerings made to it.

[314c]

Puṇyayaśas

When Pārśva Bhikṣu was about to enter final extinction, he addressed a bhikṣu named Puṇyayaśas: “Elder, you should know that the Buddhadharma is subtle and wondrous, possessing great merit. Therefore the sages bear it upon their heads and reverently uphold it. I received the entrustment to guard and protect this Dharma. Now, as I am about to enter nirvāṇa, I commit it to you. You should with utmost sincerity embrace and uphold it.”

Puṇyayaśas answered, “So it shall be.”

Thereupon he proclaimed and expounded the subtle and wondrous supreme Dharma. Those he taught and liberated were sentient beings beyond measure. Once, while seated beneath a tree in a secluded forest, in cross-legged posture, silently absorbed in contemplation, a great man named Aśvaghōṣa appeared. His wisdom was fathomless, his insight surpassing, and his understanding without equal. Whatever challenges or questions were posed to him, there was nothing he could not crush and overcome. He was like a fierce wind uprooting rotten trees. He gave rise to great arrogance, treating all beings as no more than blades of grass. He held that the self truly exists and was exceedingly proud and self-important.

Hearing that there was a Venerable One named Puṇyayaśas, whose wisdom was deep and vast, who was broadly learned and profoundly accomplished, and who taught that all dharmas are empty, with no self and no person, Aśvaghōṣa went to him with a heart full of contempt and disdain, and spoke these words: “All the doctrines in the world, I can destroy, as hail crushes grass. If these words are false and not truthful, I shall cut out my own tongue to atone for the disgrace of defeat.”

Puṇyayaśas said, “Within the Buddhadharma there are two truths. According to conventional truth, there is a provisional designation called ‘self.’ According to ultimate truth, all is empty and still. If one investigates in this way, where can a self be found?”

At that time Aśvaghōṣa’s mind was not yet subdued. Relying on his quick wit, he still believed himself superior. Puṇyayaśas said, “Think carefully and do not speak falsely. Let you and I determine definitively who is the victor.”

Thereupon Aśvaghoṣa reflected: “Conventional truth uses provisional names, which are certainly not real. The nature of ultimate truth is also empty and still. Both these truths are unobtainable. Since nothing exists, how can anything be destroyed? I am certainly no match for him.”

He was about to cut out his tongue to atone for his defeat. Puṇyayaśas said, “My Dharma is one of benevolence and compassion; I will not cut out your tongue. You should shave your head and become my disciple.”

The Venerable One thereupon ordained him. But Aśvaghoṣa’s heart still harbored shame and resentment, and he wished to take his own life. At that time, Puṇyayaśas, having attained the arhat path, entered meditative absorption and observed his thoughts.

The Venerable One had a sūtra that was kept in a dark room. He immediately sent Aśvaghoṣa to go and retrieve it. Aśvaghoṣa said, “Great Master, this room is shrouded in darkness; how can I go there?”

Puṇyayaśas said, “Just go. I shall cause you to see.”

The Venerable One then, by his supernormal power, extended his right hand from afar, reaching through into the room. Light radiated from all five fingers, shining brilliantly, so that everything within the room was clearly revealed. [315a]

Aśvaghoṣa at first suspected it was an illusion. For the nature of illusion is such that when recognized, it ceases. Yet this light grew ever more blazing and intense. He exhausted all his arts trying to extinguish this light. Utterly wearied by his efforts, he found no sign of anything illusory. Knowing that his master had accomplished this, he immediately submitted. He diligently practiced austerities and never again regressed.

Thus the Venerable One, through skillful means, liberated sentient beings. When his work was accomplished, he entered nirvāṇa. The four assemblies, moved by longing, erected a stūpa and made offerings.

Aśvaghoṣa

Long ago, when Puṇyayaśas was approaching nirvāṇa, he entrusted the Dharma to his disciple Aśvaghoṣa, telling him: “It is like lighting a great lamp in a dark room: all the objects within are fully illuminated. The bright lamp of the Dharma is just like this. Circulating through the world, it can extinguish the darkness of delusion. Therefore the Tathāgata

proclaimed this true Dharma, universally enabling all beings to practice it. The sages and saints have always guarded and protected it, entrusting it to one another in succession, down to me. I now take this supreme eye and entrust it to you. You should hereafter receive and uphold it with utmost sincerity, so that future generations may universally receive its benefit.”

Aśvaghōṣa reverently assented, saying he would receive the Venerable One’s instruction. Thereupon he proclaimed the profound and wondrous Dharma treasury, erected the great Dharma banner, and crushed wrong views.

In the city of Pāṭaliputra, he traveled about teaching and transforming. Desiring to deliver the sentient beings of that city, he composed a musical work called Rāṣṭrapāla. Its tones were pure and elegant, plaintive and melodious, harmonious and flowing. It expounded the Dharma of suffering, emptiness, and no-self, teaching that all conditioned things are like illusions, like magical transformations; that the three realms are a prison of bondage without a single thing worthy of enjoyment; that royal rank, however exalted, and power, however sovereign, when impermanence arrives, who can endure? Like clouds in the sky, they scatter and vanish in an instant. This body is false and deceptive, like a plantain tree. It is an enemy, a thief, not to be drawn near. It is like a basket of venomous snakes: who would cherish it? Therefore the Buddhas constantly denounce this body. Thus he broadly expounded the meaning of emptiness and no-self.

He commanded the musicians to perform these sounds. But the musicians could not comprehend the meaning; the melodies and rhythms were all wrong and discordant.

Thereupon Aśvaghōṣa donned white robes, entered among the musicians, and himself struck the bells and drums and tuned the lutes and zithers. The melodies were mournful and elegant, and the musical composition was perfected. It proclaimed the Dharma of the suffering, emptiness, and no-self of all phenomena.

At that time, five hundred princes of the city simultaneously attained insight. They felt disgust toward the five desires and left home to pursue the Way. The king of Pāṭaliputra feared that if his people heard this music they would abandon the household way, the land would become

empty and desolate, and the royal enterprise would be ruined. He thereupon issued a decree to the people of his realm: “From this day forward, this music shall not be performed again.”

The city of Pāṭaliputra had a total population of nine hundred million. The king of the Yuezhi people was of blazing prestige and virtue. His name was King Kaniṣka. His spirit was heroic and fierce, his bravery and strength surpassing the world. Wherever he campaigned, nothing could withstand him. He assembled his four divisions of troops and marched upon this kingdom. After battle had been joined, the kingdom submitted. He then demanded nine hundred million gold coins.

The king of that country offered Aśvaghoṣa, the Buddha’s begging bowl, and a compassionate rooster, each valued at three hundred million, and presented them to King Kaniṣka. The Bodhisattva Aśvaghoṣa possessed surpassing wisdom. The Buddha’s begging bowl was an article of merit that the Tathāgata himself had carried. The rooster possessed a compassionate heart and would not drink water containing insects. Together these could extinguish all enmity and hostility. For this reason they were worth nine hundred million coins. The king was greatly delighted and accepted them. He then withdrew his troops and returned to his own country.

King Kaniṣka possessed great merit. He donned the armor of his vast vows, and his aspirations were firm and resolute. He had once placed a lump of clay upon a stūpa and made this vow: “If in a future life, among the thousand Buddhas, I attain true enlightenment, may this lump of clay transform into a Buddha image.” As soon as he made this vow, it was immediately fulfilled. The image’s appearance was extraordinary and remarkable, as though it had been painted. His heart was filled with great joy and boundless elation. [315b]

On a later occasion, the king was traveling along a road and saw a heterodox stūpa adorned with the seven treasures. Greatly delighted, he took it to be a stūpa of the Tathāgata. He prostrated himself before it, bowed his head in reverence, burned incense and scattered flowers with utmost sincerity, and spoke this verse of praise:

Endowed with omniscient wisdom,
Having severed the obstacles of desire and affliction,
Supreme among all sages,

His renown pervades the three realms.
Liberated and free from all forms of existence,
He shows compassion for all living beings.
His words are true and spoken in sincerity,
Able to topple the banners of heterodox doctrines.
Therefore I now bow my head
In homage to the one worthy of offerings.

When he had spoken this verse, the jeweled stūpa immediately shattered and collapsed. Seeing this, the king was alarmed and frightened, and said, “Have my merits now been exhausted? Am I about to lose my throne? Why did this jeweled stūpa crumble the moment I paid it homage?”

Someone said to the king, “What the king worshipped was a heterodox stūpa. Because its power and virtue are meager and slight, it could not withstand the homage of a king of such merit and blessings. That is why it happened.”

They then opened the base of the stūpa and found the corpse of a Nirgrantha. The people exclaimed in wonder, “How marvelous! The great king’s virtuous power is so deep and vast that his worship of this heterodox stūpa caused its destruction. The king’s merit is comparable to that of Brahmā.”

On another occasion, King Kaniṣka once summoned his barber and had him shave his beard. The barber, standing before the king, said, “My son is handsome and of rare wisdom. I humbly beg the great king to show compassion and mercy by giving him your daughter in marriage.”

The king was greatly enraged and said to him, “You are a person of lowly birth and base lineage. How could I give my daughter to your son?” He immediately drove the barber away to another place. The barber fell silent and dared not speak again. Later, the king summoned him again, and the barber repeated his request as before. This happened three times.

The king reflected, “There must be a hidden treasure beneath this very spot, which emboldens this man to dare make such a request.” He then ordered people to dig at that spot, and they immediately unearthed a great store of various treasures. Such was the king’s wisdom in this matter.

On yet another occasion, King Kaṇiṣka inquired of his ministers, “In the various lands, is there perchance a wise man whom I might consult and pay respects to?”

At that time there was a bhikṣu named Dharmamitra, whose wisdom was profound and far-reaching, whose merits were fully perfected, and who excelled in penetrating the characteristics of samādhi. In the kingdom of southern India, there were two bhikṣus whose minds were gentle and harmonious and who deeply delighted in the wholesome Dharma. Having long heard that the Venerable One was foremost in seated meditation, they traveled together to visit him.

At his dwelling place there were three tiers of caves. The two men reached the lowest cave and saw a bhikṣu wearing tattered, worn-out robes, with a rough and haggard appearance, sitting straight before the kitchen hearth, tending the fire for the Sangha. The two bhikṣus asked, “Elder, where is Dharmamitra?” He answered, “He is in the uppermost cave. You should go up quickly to see him.”

The two men proceeded to the uppermost cave and found the same bhikṣu already seated within. One of the bhikṣus said to his companion, “How is it that this old bhikṣu looks just like the one we saw below?” His companion, who was of quick and perceptive intelligence, said, “If this Venerable One is capable of such things, spreading his fame far and wide, would he not be capable of reaching this place to sit here?” He then went forward, paid his respects, bowed his head, and asked, “Great Worthy One, your noble reputation is rare in the world. Why do you humble yourself to tend the fire for the Sangha?”

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Dharmamitra said to the bhikṣus, “You should listen now. I reflect upon birth and death: the suffering endured has been long and far-reaching. If it were possible to set aflame my head and hands, I would burn them for the Sangha’s sake. How much less is the rest of my body, or the labor of tending the fire, any cause for difficulty? I recall that in past lives, for five hundred lifetimes, I constantly received the body of a dog. Starving and emaciated, I was fully satiated only twice.

“Once, long ago, there was a person who, having drunk wine until he was utterly intoxicated, vomited upon the ground. At that time I ate the vomit and was satisfied.

“Another time, long ago, there was a husband and wife who cooked gruel in a pot. When it was done, they went outside. Seeing no one about, I entered their house and thrust my head into the pot to eat the gruel, and was satisfied. But when I tried to withdraw my head, I could not get it out. The husband and wife came back inside and, seeing that I had eaten their gruel, were filled with rage. They took a sharp knife and cut off my head.

“Throughout five hundred lifetimes of receiving a dog’s body, though I was satisfied twice, I lost my life both times. Reflecting upon this, birth and death is long and vast; one wanders through all five destinies, suffering immeasurably. Therefore I now do not shrink from toil and labor but personally tend the fire for the Sangha.”

When the two bhikṣus heard these words, they deeply contemplated the immeasurable calamities of birth and death. At that very moment they attained the fruit of stream-entry.

Thus the Venerable Dharmamitra’s knowledge and vision were lofty and far-reaching, and his fame spread abroad. The king’s ministers had long heard his name. They all addressed the king, saying, “Great King, you should know that in the mountains of Kaśmīr there is a bhikṣu named Dharmamitra. His talent and wisdom are unequaled, and his merit is deep and vast. The king should go there to pay respects and make offerings.”

King Kaniṣka thereupon prepared his royal carriage and, with his entourage before and behind him, proceeded to the mountains of Kaśmīr. When he was still more than five hundred li from the dwelling place, the king thought to himself, “If this bhikṣu’s merit is truly deep and vast, he will be able to receive my reverent homage. But a person of meager blessings would never be fit for it.”

Dharmamitra was by nature of plain and simple disposition. He wore tattered, worn-out robes, and his complexion was haggard. The Venerable One’s disciples all said, “King Kaniṣka’s prestige and fame are lofty and far-reaching. He has condescended to come here to pay respects to the Great Master. You should adorn yourself and put on fresh, clean robes, lest he look down upon you with contempt.”

Dharmamitra told his disciples, “The Tathāgata in former times gave no instruction that one should adorn oneself upon seeing the powerful and noble. Moreover, for a renunciant, coarse and worn-out garments are the norm. Since this is fitting, what is there to change?”

The king then advanced and bowed his head in reverence, inquiring after the Venerable One's well-being. Dharmamitra, knowing the king's thoughts, promptly coughed up phlegm and spat, directing the king to receive it. King Kaniṣka knelt with palms joined, received the spittle, and then cast it aside. Dharmamitra asked, "Am I now worthy of the king's offerings or not?"

The king was immediately humbled, and his faith and reverence doubled. The Venerable One told him, "The king once came by the path of the supreme Way. You may now return by that same original road."

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Having heard these words, the king received the instruction and returned to his country.

At that time, the ministers were all displeased and resentful: "How is it that the great king, having originally gone to seek a superior person, met him yet did not consult or inquire about anything?"

The king told his ministers, "How could you understand such a matter? In past lives I accumulated meritorious practices over long ages. Now I have become king, with talent and wisdom surpassing the world. The Venerable One instructed me to return to my original undertaking. Having already received his instruction, what more was there to ask?"

On a later occasion, the king was journeying to a stūpa named Kaniṣka. Along the road ahead he encountered five hundred beggars who cried out together, pleading for alms, saying, "Give to us as you would give to yourself!"

When the king heard this, he made lavish gifts to the beggars: gold, silver, lapis lazuli, elephants, horses, fields, and residences. Upon returning, he organized many kinds of charitable assemblies. He relieved the poor and destitute and comforted orphans and the elderly. He governed with the true Dharma and benevolently nurtured all under heaven.

There was a minister named Heavenly Law who thought, "Why did the great king, upon seeing those beggars, establish such meritorious and excellent works?" He then asked the king, "What caused the king, upon seeing those beggars, to perform such extensive acts of merit?"

The great king told Heavenly Law, "The beggars were of deep benefit to me. Through their physical appearance and their words, they wished to enlighten me. In the past, I was a king who did not cultivate

the causes of merit. Therefore now I suffer hunger, cold, and destitution. My body is haggard, and I endure all manner of suffering. If a king does not give to beggars and the poor, in future lives he will surely be like me: hungry, cold, and wretched.” Such was the matter of the beggars. “I understood this truth, and therefore I perform meritorious deeds.”

Heavenly Law said, “The king today not only holds a position supreme over the realm but possesses wisdom sufficient to govern ten thousand kingdoms.”

At that time, the King of Parthia was by nature exceedingly stubborn and violent. He marshaled his four divisions of troops and attacked King Kaniṣka. King Kaniṣka likewise prepared his defenses. The two armies clashed in battle; swords and blades flew unceasingly. King Kaniṣka swiftly gained the victory, slaying nine hundred million of the Parthian soldiers.

He asked his ministers, “Can the sin I have committed today be extinguished or not?”

The ministers replied, “The great king has slaughtered nine hundred million people. The sin is exceedingly grave. How could it be extinguished?”

[316b]

King Kaniṣka then had a great cauldron set up. For seven days he heated water to a boil, churning and surging with violent, blazing heat. He placed a golden ring inside the boiling water and asked his ministers, “Who, by clever means, can retrieve this ring?”

One minister came forward to answer the king’s challenge. He poured in cold water and, following it in, retrieved the ring. His hands were unharmed and unscalded, and he promptly obtained the golden ring.

The king told his ministers, “The sin I have committed is like that boiling water. Repentance can surely extinguish it, just as the cold water did. Although I killed nine hundred million people, among them the gravest sins concern only two and a half persons. When I was killing, there were two devout believers who, at the moment of execution, called out, ‘Homage to the Buddha!’ Yet I killed them. This sin is exceedingly grave. The remaining one was a person who spoke the words ‘Homage to . . .’ but did not know whether it was the Buddha or Pūraṇa. I killed him as well. Therefore he counts as half a person.”

At that time, a certain arhat bhikṣu, seeing that King Kaniṣka had committed these evil deeds, wished to cause the king to feel terror and repent his transgressions. By his supernormal power, he revealed to the king the hells: the hacking and piercing, the spinning sword-wheels, the dismemberment of bodies, the piteous wailing and cries of anguish, the suffering and pain beyond endurance. When the king saw this, he was seized with the utmost terror and dread. He thought to himself, “How utterly foolish and deluded I have been to commit such evil deeds! In the future, I will surely suffer torments like these. Had I known beforehand of such terrible retribution, even if my own body were torn limb from limb, I would never have given rise to the thought of harming an enemy. How much less could I harbor even a single evil thought toward a good person!”

Thereupon Aśvaghoṣa said to the king, “If the king can listen to my teaching of the Dharma with utmost sincerity, follow my instruction, and reverently uphold it, I can ensure that this sin of yours will not lead to hell.”

King Kaniṣka said, “Excellent! I receive your instruction.”

Thereupon Aśvaghoṣa broadly expounded the pure Dharma for the king, causing his grave sins to gradually become lighter.

There was also a physician named Caraka, who was skilled in prescriptions and medicines, quick-witted, broadly learned, sharp in understanding, eloquent, compassionate, and benevolent. King Kaniṣka had long heard his name and had always sought him out. It happened that Caraka came of his own accord to the king’s palace.

When the king heard of the physician’s arrival, he said, “I am already well able to regulate my own body. I sleep on my right side, and I moderate my food and drink. Being such as I am, what need have I of a physician?”

Caraka said, “If the king is capable of this, he ought to leave home and become a renunciant. For a king to indulge his passions to the extreme, giving free rein to body and speech, and yet the king is still able to restrain and guard himself: why cling to this throne and linger long in the world?”

Hearing this, the king knew he was logically bested. He then summoned Caraka inside, and they exchanged courtesies. The physician

said, “Great King, if you can believe and accept my instruction, following it without resistance, I shall cause your body to be full of vigor and strength, your food to digest well, and you to be forever free of illness.”

[316c] The king said, “Excellent! I respectfully receive your instruction.”

Not long afterward, the king’s beloved consort discovered she was with child. After the full ten months, she bore a son, but the child had already died and was delivered feet-first from the womb. The mother’s suffering was excruciating, and her life hung by a thread. Thenceforth, each successive birth was like this.

Caraka then reached his hand into the womb and unwrapped the child’s garment, after which the child was delivered. The mother was then safe and fully recovered.

The physician said, “Great King, from this day forward, do not again visit this woman intimately. If you go near her, the result will surely be as before.”

But King Kaṇiṣka’s fire of lust was fierce. Unable to restrain himself, he again visited the woman. She bore another child, suffering cruelly as before.

Thereupon the physician Caraka began to realize that the five desires are the root source of calamity. He thought to himself, “I personally instructed King Kaṇiṣka, yet he did not heed my words, and this brought about such manifold suffering. One should know that sensual desire is truly not a source of happiness. The ruin of virtue and the loss of life all come from this. It destroys good reputation and pollutes pure conduct. Ordinary people, lost in delusion, cannot abandon it. The wise, understanding it clearly, view it as an enemy and a thief. I should now renounce these unwholesome ways, retire to the forests, and dwell in quiet places to practice meditation.”

He then took leave of the king and left home to study the Way. His talent was lofty and transcendent, his understanding deep and all-encompassing. He expounded discourses and treatises and traveled about teaching throughout the world.

There was also a minister named Māṭharī, whose wisdom was extraordinary and whose talents were rare in the world. He addressed King Kaṇiṣka, saying, “Great King, if you will follow my counsel, I can surely cause the king’s might to subdue all within the four seas. All will

pay homage, and the eight directions will submit to your virtue. But keep my words secret and do not let them be known.”

The king said, “Very well. It shall be as you say.”

The great minister then assembled a force of valiant generals and marshaled the four divisions of troops. Wherever they went, all submitted, as hail crushes grass. The peoples of three of the seas all came and declared their allegiance.

The horse that King Kaniṣka rode, while traveling along the road, suddenly stumbled and its legs gave way. The king said to the horse, “I have conquered three of the seas, and all have submitted. Only the northern sea has not yet surrendered. If I obtain it, I shall ride you no more. My task is not yet accomplished; why do you behave this way?”

When the ministers heard the king’s words, they deliberated among themselves: “King Kaniṣka is greedy, cruel, and without the Way. He constantly wages campaigns and exhausts the people in labor. Knowing no satisfaction, he desires to rule the four seas. Garrisons on distant frontiers separate families. When will such suffering ever cease? We should unite our hearts and depose him. Only then shall we find peace and happiness.”

When the king fell ill with a fever, they pressed heavy coverings upon him. A man sat upon him, and in a moment his breath ceased.

[317a]

Because he had listened to Aśvaghoṣa’s teaching of the Dharma, he was reborn in the great ocean as a fish with a thousand heads. A spinning sword-wheel revolved ceaselessly, severing his heads. They grew back at once, and were severed again in succession. This continued without end, to immeasurable repetitions. In the space of a single moment, the severed heads filled the great ocean.

At that time there was an arhat who served as the monastery’s timekeeper. The king then said, “When this sword-wheel hears the sound of the monastery bell, it stops for a time. During that interval, my suffering eases slightly. I humbly beg the Great Worthy One to show compassion and mercy. When you strike the bell, please let the sound extend and last longer.”

The arhat, moved by compassion, struck the bell for a longer duration. After seven days had passed, the king’s suffering came to an end.

Because of that king, in that monastery the tradition was established and handed down, generation after generation, of striking the bell for an extended time. To this very day, it remains as it was originally.

Thus Ásvaghoṣa, through his great practice and vows, proclaimed the flavor of sweet dew and brought immense benefit to King Kaniṣka. Those he liberated numbered hundreds of millions. When his work was accomplished, he relinquished his life and departed. His relics were gathered and a stūpa was erected, with offerings made to it.

Vīra

When the Bodhisattva Ásvaghoṣa was about to relinquish his life, he addressed a bhikṣu named Vīra: “Elder, you should know that the Buddhadharma is pure and able to cleanse the defilements of affliction. You should hereafter disseminate and make offerings to it.”

Vīra replied, “Excellent! I receive your instruction.”

From that time onward, he broadly proclaimed the true Dharma, adorning himself with subtle and wondrous merits. He was skilled in speech, and his wisdom was deep and far-reaching. There was no heterodox doctrine he could not crush and overcome. In southern India, he brought immense benefit. He composed the Treatise on No-Self, exactly one hundred verses. Wherever this treatise reached, nothing could withstand it, just as all things shatter before a diamond.

When the time of his passing drew near, he entrusted the Dharma treasury to a great man named Nāgārjuna. Then he relinquished his life.

Nāgārjuna

Nāgārjuna afterward broadly disseminated the supreme eye for the benefit of sentient beings, adorning himself with wondrous merits. His heavenly intelligence was extraordinary; he grasped things upon hearing them once, never needing to be told twice. He erected the banner of the Dharma and subdued heterodox teachings. Such merits as these are beyond description. I shall now follow the account and reveal his causes and conditions.

He was born in the kingdom of southern India, into a family of great wealth and nobility of the Brahmin caste. Because he was born beneath a tree and attained the Way through the aid of nāgas, he was called Nāgārjuna.

From earliest childhood he was brilliantly intelligent, with learning and talent surpassing the world. While still a nursing infant in swaddling clothes, he heard the Brahmins reciting the four Vedas. Those scriptures are vast and profound, containing forty thousand verses, each verse consisting of a full thirty-two syllables. He immediately comprehended them all and understood their phrases and meanings.

Before he had reached the age of twenty, his fame had spread, and he walked unchallenged throughout all the kingdoms. Astronomy, geography, astral calculations, prognosticatory charts, and all other arts and techniques: there was nothing he had not thoroughly mastered.

He had three friends, each of outstanding natural talent. They deliberated together, saying, “All the principles and doctrines in the world, those that illuminate the spirit and unfold hidden meanings to increase wisdom: such matters we have entirely mastered. With what further pursuit shall we amuse ourselves?”

They further said, “In this world, pursuing beautiful forms, indulging one’s passions to the utmost: this is the supreme and wondrous pleasure of a single lifetime. Yet the way of the Brahmins does not grant us such freedom. Without some extraordinary stratagem, this pleasure will be hard to obtain. We should seek together the art of making ourselves invisible. If this endeavor succeeds, our wish will surely be fulfilled.”

They all said, “Excellent! These words are most satisfying!”

They went at once to a master of arts and sought the method of invisibility. The art master thought, “These four Brahmins are of lofty talent and far-reaching wisdom, yet they are greatly arrogant, treating all beings as mere blades of grass. Now, because of my art, they have humbled themselves and come to me. Yet these men, who investigate and penetrate all things, know nothing of this one lowly art. If I teach them the formula, they will forever cast me aside. I should give them the finished medicine but not let them know the ingredients. When the medicine runs out, they will have to return, and I can retain them as students for a long time.”

He then gave each of the four a single pill of green medicine and told them, “Take this medicine and grind it with water. Apply it to your eyelids, and your form will become invisible.”

Following their master’s instructions, each began to grind his medicine. The moment Nāgārjuna smelled the fragrance, he identified every ingredient. He determined the quantities and proportions without the slightest error. He returned to the master and described the matter in full. There were a total of seventy ingredients in the medicine; he knew the names and amounts of each, all exactly matching the formula.

The master was astonished and amazed, and asked how he had done it. Nāgārjuna replied, “Great Master, you should know that all medicines have their own distinctive properties. I discerned them by this. What is there to find remarkable?”

When the master heard his words, he sighed in wonder at what he had never before encountered and thought, “A person such as this is hard even to hear of, let alone to meet in person. How could I begrudge him this art?” He then taught the full method to all four men.

The four prepared the medicine according to the formula, made themselves invisible, and went about freely. They then went together into the royal harem. The beautiful women of the inner palace were all violated. After more than a hundred days, many of them were found to be pregnant. They went and reported to the king, hoping to be absolved of blame.

[317c] When the king heard this, he was deeply displeased. “What inauspicious omen is this? What manner of abomination!” He summoned his wise ministers to deliberate on the matter.

One minister addressed the king, saying, “Generally, there are two possible explanations for such occurrences. The first is ghosts and spirits. The second is magical arts. You may spread fine earth at all the doorways and post guards to observe all who come and go. If it is magical arts, their footprints will be visible. If it is ghosts and spirits, they will leave no tracks when they enter. People can be dealt with by force of arms; ghosts should be eliminated by incantations.”

The king followed this plan and prepared accordingly. They found four sets of footprints entering through the gate. The guards immediately reported this to the king.

The king took several hundred brave warriors and had them slash their swords through the air. Three of the men were beheaded. But within seven feet of the king, the swords could not reach. Nāgārjuna had pressed himself close to the king and stood beside him.

At this moment, he first realized that desire is the root of suffering. It ruins virtue, endangers life, and pollutes pure conduct. He made a vow: “If I escape this peril, I shall go to the śramaṇas and receive the ordination of leaving home.”

Having escaped, he went into the mountains, arrived at a Buddhist stūpa, and renounced desire to leave home and pursue the Way. In ninety days, he read and fully mastered all the sūtras and treatises of Jambudvīpa. He sought further texts elsewhere but found none.

He then traveled toward the Himalayas, where he met a bhikṣu who bestowed upon him the Mahāyāna scriptures. He read and recited them with joy, and reverently made offerings to them. Although he comprehended the true meaning, he had not yet attained realization of the Way. His eloquence was inexhaustible, and he was supremely skilled in discourse. Heterodox teachers, śramaṇas, and scholars of every school were all defeated by him and requested to become his students. He then regarded himself as an omniscient person. His mind gave rise to arrogance and the utmost pride.

He then wished to enter through the gate of Gautama’s teaching. The gate spirit addressed Nāgārjuna, saying, “Your wisdom is no more than that of a mosquito or gnat. Compared to the Tathāgata, words cannot describe the difference. It is no different from a firefly trying to match the brilliance of the sun and moon, or from comparing Mount Sumeru to a mustard seed. As I see you, Benevolent One, you are not omniscient. How do you presume to enter through this gate?”

Hearing these words, he flushed with shame.

At that time a disciple addressed Nāgārjuna, saying, “The master has always called himself omniscient. Yet now he comes here in humiliation to become a disciple of the Buddha. The way of a disciple is to inquire of and defer to the master. If one’s inquiries fall short, one is not omniscient.”

Thereupon Nāgārjuna, his arguments exhausted and his pride crushed, thought to himself, “Among the dharmas of the world, there are

countless paths and approaches. Though the Buddhist scriptures are wondrous, their phrases and meanings are not yet exhaustive. I should now further expound and elaborate upon them, to enlighten later students and benefit sentient beings.”

[318a]

Having thought thus, he was about to do so, establishing a master’s rules, devising new garments. He wished his teaching to accord with the Buddhadharma but differ slightly, in order to dispel people’s attachment and show that he was not merely receiving another’s instruction. He chose an auspicious day and was about to inaugurate his system, dwelling alone in a quiet chamber, a crystal room.

The Great Nāga Bodhisattva, taking pity upon him, used his supernormal power to transport him into the great ocean, bringing him to the Nāga palace. There the Nāga King opened seven jeweled caskets and bestowed upon him the vaipulya and profoundly esoteric scriptures, the immeasurable and wondrous Dharma, and gave them all to Nāgārjuna. In ninety days, he penetrated and understood a great many of them. His mind entered deeply, and he attained the true benefit.

The Nāga King, knowing his thoughts, asked him, “Have you now finished reading the sūtras or not?”

Nāgārjuna answered, “Your sūtras are immeasurable and cannot be exhausted. What I have read is already fully ten times more than what exists in all of Jambudvīpa.”

The Nāga King said, “In the Trāyastriṃśa Heaven above, the scriptures possessed by Indra surpass what is in this palace by a hundred thousand, ten thousand times over. The collections in other places are similarly beyond counting.”

Having obtained these scriptures, Nāgārjuna’s understanding became thoroughly penetrating. He clearly comprehended the one characteristic. He deeply entered the birthlessness of all dharmas; the two kinds of patient acceptance were fully perfected. The Nāga King, knowing he had realized the Way, escorted him out of the palace.

At that time, the king of southern India held exceedingly wrong views. He served the heterodox teachings and slandered the true Dharma. Desiring to convert him, the Bodhisattva Nāgārjuna personally carried a red banner and walked before the king. After seven years had passed, the king at last took notice and asked, “Who are you, walking before me?”

He answered, “I am an omniscient person.”

The king was greatly astonished and asked, “An omniscient person is exceedingly rare. You claim to be one; how shall it be verified?”

Nāgārjuna answered, “If the king wishes to know, he should put a question to me. After I have answered, the proof will be evident.”

Hearing these words, the king thought, “I am known as a master of wisdom and a great debater. If I question him and defeat him, that is nothing remarkable. But should I prove inferior to him, the loss would be great. Yet to remain silent and say nothing is also unreasonable.” He deliberated back and forth for a long time, unable to decide. At last, pressed by the circumstances, he reluctantly put a question: “What are the devas doing at this very moment?”

He answered, “Great King, at this moment the devas are engaged in battle with the asuras.”

When the king heard this, it was as though a morsel were stuck in his throat: he could neither swallow it nor spit it out. If the claim were false, there would be no proof. But to accept the assertion as true seemed equally impossible to verify. [318b]

Nāgārjuna then said, “This is no idle claim. If the king will wait a moment, verification will come shortly.”

No sooner had he finished speaking than swords and halberds came falling down from the sky. Long spears and short weapons descended one after another.

The king said, “Weapons of war, spears and halberds, are indeed instruments of battle. But how does this prove it is the devas and asuras?”

Nāgārjuna answered, “Though my words may seem empty, let them be verified by fact.” Having said this, the ears and noses of asuras came falling from the sky.

The king at last was struck with awe and reverence. He bowed his head in homage and reverently received Nāgārjuna’s instruction in the Way.

At that time, the ten thousand Brahmins upon the palace platform, witnessing his spiritual power and virtue, sighed in wonder at what they had never before seen. They shaved off their beards and hair and left home to become renunciants.

When the various heterodox teachers heard of this, they all gathered like massing clouds, seething with anger and jealousy, seeking to contend in debate. Thereupon Nāgārjuna, with his great wisdom and skillful words, engaged the heterodox teachers in extensive debate. Those of dull intellect were defeated with a single statement. Those of modest cleverness lasted at most two days. Their arguments and reasoning entirely exhausted, they were all vanquished. They shaved their beards and hair and joined his order. Those of heterodox paths thus converted were beyond count.

The royal household regularly sent ten cart-loads of robes and bowls. By the end of each month, all were completely distributed. This continued on and on, to a countless extent.

He broadly elucidated and expounded the meaning of the Mahāyāna. He composed the Upadeśa in one hundred thousand verses. He also composed such treatises as the Adornment of the Buddha Path and the Great Compassion through Skillful Means, each five thousand verses, causing the Mahāyāna to shine forth and be proclaimed throughout the world. He composed the Treatise of Fearlessness in a full one hundred thousand verses. The Middle Treatise emerged from within the Fearlessness section, totaling five hundred verses. The meaning and import of what he expounded was profoundly deep, crushing the victory banners of all heterodox teachers.

At that time, in the land of India, there was a Brahmin of fiercely blazing wrong views who was skilled in incantatory arts. Wishing to pit his abilities against Nāgārjuna for the sake of reputation, he addressed the king, saying, “I humbly beg the great king to graciously permit me to contend with this śramaṇa in a contest of spiritual power. If he defeats me, I shall belong to him. If I defeat him, he shall belong to me.”

[318c]

The king said, “Great Worthy One, you are exceedingly foolish. This Bodhisattva’s brilliance equals the sun and moon, and his wisdom matches that of the sages. You, in your mediocrity, how can you compare? It would be like trying to suspend Mount Sumeru with a lotus fiber, or to equate the water in a hoofprint with the great ocean. As I see you, Benevolent One, it is just the same. Think well upon this, and do not diminish your noble standing.”

The Brahmin said, “The king is a wise man whom all look up to, like the sun and moon observed by all. Whether my words are empty or true should be tested by reason. Why does the great king presume to slight and insult me beforehand?”

The king, seeing his earnest determination, prepared his carriage and went to respectfully invite the Bodhisattva Nāgārjuna. Early the next morning, both assembled upon the Hall of True Virtue.

The Brahmin, using the power of his incantations, conjured a great pool, broad, long, and limpid. From within the pool arose a thousand-petaled lotus flower. He seated himself upon it and addressed Nāgārjuna, saying, “You sit upon the ground like an animal. I sit upon a flower, pure in wisdom. How dare you presume to contend with me in debate?”

Thereupon Nāgārjuna, also using the power of incantations, conjured a white elephant. The elephant had six tusks, adorned with ornaments of gold and silver. It walked slowly toward the pool and approached the lotus seat. With its trunk, it wrapped around the flower, plucked it from the water, and flung it, together with the Brahmin, to the ground.

The Brahmin, his back injured and helpless in his distress, immediately submitted and threw himself upon Nāgārjuna’s mercy: “I was exceedingly stubborn and foolish, and I offended the Great Master. I humbly beg your compassion and mercy; permit me to repent my transgression.”

Nāgārjuna, with compassion, ordained him and allowed him to leave home.

At that time, there was a certain Hīnayāna Dharma master who, seeing Nāgārjuna’s lofty brilliance, constantly harbored resentment and jealousy.

The Bodhisattva Nāgārjuna, his work accomplished, was about to depart from this world. He asked the Dharma master, “Do you wish me to remain long in the world or not?”

The Dharma master answered, “Benevolent One, in truth I do not wish it.”

Nāgārjuna then entered a quiet chamber and for an entire day did not appear. His disciples, growing alarmed, broke open the door and looked

in. They found that their master had shed his body like a cicada casting off its shell and had departed.

In all the kingdoms of India, temples were erected in his honor. They made offerings of every kind and revered him as they would a Buddha.

Fascicle Six

Āryadeva

When the bodhisattva Nāgārjuna was about to leave this world, he told his great disciple Āryadeva: “Good man, listen well. The Buddha, out of great compassion, took pity on sentient beings and expounded the sweet-dew flavor of the Dharma for the benefit of future generations. It has been transmitted in succession down to me. Now I am about to leave this world and entrust it to you. You must propagate it and receive and uphold it with your whole heart.”

[319a]

Āryadeva reverently assented, saying he would receive and carry out the venerable one’s teaching. Thereupon he proclaimed the true treasury of the Dharma, and with the power of wisdom he vanquished non-Buddhist teachers. Broadly learned and profoundly erudite, his eloquence and dialectical skill were transcendent. His fame was unrivaled throughout the world, and he walked alone among the nations without peer.

He was originally born in the land of South India, of the Brahmin caste, in a family of honor and great eminence. Because he had offered his divine eye, he was left with only one eye. For this reason he was called Āryadeva. His wisdom was deep and far-reaching, and his brilliance arose from within. When he examined himself, he found nothing to be ashamed of in his heart. Yet because people would not accept his words on faith, his teaching of the Way did not spread, and he worried about this night and day.

In that country there was a heavenly deity whose form had been cast in gold, standing six zhang high. Everyone called it the Great Lord,

Maheśvara. Those who sought blessings were said to receive immediate rewards. Āryadeva went to the temple and requested entry to pay his respects. The temple guardian said: “The divine image is supremely numinous. Those who see it dare not look directly at it. Moreover, anyone who approaches too closely loses his soul for a hundred days. You should simply go to the gate and make your petition. What more could you seek by wanting to see it?”

Āryadeva replied: “If the deity is truly as you say, then I wish all the more to see it. If it is not so, then it is not what I seek.” When the people heard this, they all marveled at his intent. Those who followed him into the temple numbered tens of thousands.

When Āryadeva arrived, he bowed his head in reverence. The deity moved its eyes and glared at him wrathfully. Āryadeva said: “The deity is indeed numinous. However, upon examination, it appears exceedingly base and inferior. A true deity should subdue all beings through its spiritual power. Yet here it relies on gold and crystal as adornments to dazzle and deceive the common people. How petty this is!”

He then climbed a tall ladder and gouged out the eye of the statue. All the onlookers harbored doubts: “The Great Lord Maheśvara possesses majestic virtue of the highest order. How could he be humiliated by this young Brahmin? Perhaps this deity’s reputation exceeds its reality.”

At that time Āryadeva addressed the crowd: “The divine spirit is vast and far-reaching. He has tested me through this immediate matter. Because I deeply comprehend what is in his heart, I ascended the golden mound and removed the crystal gem, so that everyone might clearly understand that the pure spiritual essence does not depend on material form. Since I am not acting from arrogance, how could the deity be insulted?”

Having spoken thus, he left the temple. That very night he procured all the offerings and preparations, and at dawn the next morning he reverently made offerings to the heavenly deity.

Āryadeva’s name and virtue were already well established, and his wisdom communed with the divine. Whatever he uttered never failed to receive a response. Within that single night, all the offerings were prepared. The Great Lord Maheśvara then manifested a body of flesh, approximately four zhang in height, with the left eye withered and

drained. He walked slowly and with stately composure, and came to take his seat. He surveyed the delicacies spread before him and sighed that this was unprecedented. He praised Āryadeva's virtue and power for having accomplished all this, and said to him: "Excellent, great one! You have deeply understood my mind and made your offering through wisdom and insight. You are truly one who reveres and believes in me. The people of this world are foolish and deluded; they only obtain my outward form. They make food offerings out of fear and thereby slander me. Now your offerings are complete, with every fine flavor provided. My left eye should rightly be bestowed upon you. If you can offer it to me, that would be a supreme act of giving."

Āryadeva replied: "Excellent! I accept your instruction." With his left hand he removed his eye and gave it to the deity. Through the deity's power, as soon as one eye was removed, another grew in its place. He kept asking for more, and Āryadeva removed eyes numbering in the tens of thousands.

The heavenly deity praised him: "Excellent, young man! This is truly supreme giving. What wish do you desire? I will surely fulfill your intention."

At that time Āryadeva addressed the heavenly deity: "I seek clarity and understanding, not anything external. My only regret is that people do not accept my teaching on faith. My sole wish is that my words will henceforth be widely disseminated."

[319b]

The deity said: "Very well." Then he rose and departed.

Thereupon Āryadeva went to Nāgārjuna's abode, shaved his beard and hair, and received the precepts of ordination. He traveled everywhere proclaiming the teaching and broadly saving sentient beings.

The king of South India, who ruled over all the surrounding kingdoms, harbored a proud and haughty heart and believed in heterodox ways. He would not receive a single śramaṇa or disciple of the Buddha. The people of the kingdom, both near and far, all followed his influence.

Āryadeva reflected: "If one does not fell the base of a tree, the branches and leaves are difficult to bring down. If the ruler is not converted, how can the Way be spread?"

The laws of that kingdom were such that the royal house paid people to serve as guards. At that time Āryadeva answered the call and served as

a captain, bearing a halberd and marching at the front. He disciplined his troops with authority and virtue, with kindness and benevolence, so that all were content under his governance. The king appreciated his spirit and asked: “Who is this man?”

An attendant replied: “This man answered the call for recruits. He neither draws rations nor takes wages. In his duties he is respectful and diligent, and by nature he delights in quiet contemplation. We have not yet fathomed his mind, nor do we know what he seeks or desires.”

The king summoned him and inquired fully about his intentions. Āryadeva answered: “Great King, I am a man of wisdom, skilled in debate. I wish to demonstrate this before Your Majesty.”

The king at once granted permission and had a debating platform built.

At that time Āryadeva established three propositions: “Among all the holy ones, the Buddha is the most supreme. Among all teachings, the Buddha-Dharma is without compare. As a field of merit for saving the world, the community of monks is foremost. If any debater from the eight quarters can refute these statements, I shall have my head cut off in acknowledgment of defeat. Why? Because to establish a thesis without clarity is the mark of stupidity, and such a head is not one I would regret losing.”

Debaters from the eight quarters all assembled like clouds. Each likewise declared: “If I am defeated, I shall have my head cut off in acknowledgment. A stupid head is not something I cherish.”

Āryadeva said: “The teaching I practice preserves the lives of the myriad creatures with benevolence. I require that the defeated shall have their hair shaved and become my disciples; I will not cut off their heads.”

Having established this condition, they proceeded to debate. Among the non-Buddhist teachers, those of shallow intellect were refuted at the very first statement and immediately fell silent. Those of superior wisdom held out as long as two days before their arguments and reasoning were both exhausted. All had their hair shaved and were ordained as monks.

[319c] At that time there was one disciple of a non-Buddhist teacher who was fierce, obstinate, and without wisdom. He was ashamed that his master had been defeated. Though he outwardly followed the assembly,

in his heart he harbored resentful anger. His pent-up malice burned fiercely, and he bit upon a knife and swore an oath: “His mouth has defeated my master; my knife shall subdue him.”

Having spoken thus, he kept a sharp knife concealed on his person, and day and night he watched for an opportunity.

At that time Āryadeva had gone out to a secluded grove to compose the *Hundred Verses Treatise* in order to refute wrong views. His disciples had dispersed, and he was contemplating beneath a tree. The bodhisattva Āryadeva rose from his meditation and began walking. The non-Buddhist’s disciple came to him, brandished the knife, and cornered him, saying: “In the past you used your intellect to subjugate my teacher. Now I use my knife to split open your belly!” He then slashed him, and Āryadeva’s organs spilled out.

Though his life had not yet ended, Āryadeva pitied the man’s mad foolishness and told him: “I have robes and a begging bowl at my seat. You may take them and quickly flee up the mountain. Among my disciples, those who have not yet attained the Way, should they happen to encounter you, will certainly seize you, and if they hand you over to the king, your suffering will be no small matter. Name and body are the root of manifold calamities. You are now deluded, with heavy attachments and clinging. Therefore you should take good care to protect yourself.”

When some of his disciples arrived first and saw their teacher, they cried out in grief. Then all the disciples gathered together, startled and horrified, wailing and throwing themselves to the ground. Some among them ran about wildly. Together they organized search parties and set up blockades on the roads.

At that time Āryadeva addressed the assembly: “All dharmas are fundamentally empty. There is no self and nothing belonging to a self. There is no one who harms and no one who is harmed. Who is friend? Who is foe? Who causes affliction? You are now shrouded by ignorance, generating false views where none exist, planting unwholesome roots. What that man has harmed is the karmic retribution of my past deeds. He has not killed me.”

Thereupon he released his body, shed it like a cicada casting off its shell, and departed.

Before Āryadeva relinquished his body, he told the venerable Rāhulata: “The Buddha, the Bhagavat, in order to save sentient beings, expounded the wondrous Dharma and benefited future generations. It has been entrusted in succession down to me. After my passing, it should be transmitted to you. You should protect and uphold the treasure of the profound sūtras and enable all sentient beings to universally receive their benefit.”

Rāhulata said: “Excellent! I accept your teaching.”

Rāhulata

Afterward he expounded the profound sūtras and the wondrous Dharma. With the power of wisdom he destroyed heterodox ways. After hearing the Dharma taught three times, he could receive and retain it all.

Nāgārjuna, Āryadeva, and this great one were all renowned for their virtue, and their fine reputations were known everywhere. At that time there was a Brahmin of remarkable intelligence and wisdom, skilled in discourse, who composed a book called the “Record of Spirits,” which was extremely difficult to understand. Its chapters and verses were vast and extensive, numbering one hundred thousand gāthās. He recited it as a tribute before the three great ones. Nāgārjuna, upon a single hearing, immediately understood and awakened to its meaning, and was able to remember and retain it as if he had long been studying it. Āryadeva, not yet understanding it, had it explained to him again. After hearing it a second time, he too fully comprehended it. The bodhisattva Āryadeva then further analyzed and expounded its chapters and verses for Rāhulata. When Rāhulata heard it, his understanding opened up in a flash.

The Brahmin was greatly astonished: “These śramaṇas possess such extraordinary talent and wisdom! They have read my book and in no time mastered it thoroughly, distinguishing its contents as if they had long studied it.” He thereupon submitted in faith and abandoned his wrong views.

[320a]

Such was Rāhulata’s intelligence and wisdom. Through skillful means he taught and transformed sentient beings. Afterward he entrusted the Dharma to the venerable Sanghanandi, commanding him to disseminate it for the benefit of sentient beings.

Sanghanandi

Sanghanandi possessed great merit. His wisdom was deep and far-reaching, and he practiced the bodhisattva path. He adorned himself with firm vows, transcending the realms of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Once there was an arhat who had cast off the heavy burden and was complete in all meritorious qualities. Sanghanandi, wishing to test him, proclaimed a gāthā and posed a question:

Born among the lineage of wheel-turning kings,
Neither a Buddha nor an arhat,
Not subject to future existence,
Nor yet a pratyekabuddha.

“Elder of great virtue, you should carefully observe and consider: what is the thing described in the verse above?”

The arhat then entered samādhi and contemplated deeply but was unable to comprehend it. Through his supernormal powers he divided his body, flew to Tuṣita Heaven, and went before Maitreya. He fully described the matter and asked him to resolve the doubt.

At that time Maitreya told the arhat: “People in the world take a lump of clay and place it upon a wheel, shaping and firing it into a tile. Is such a tile like one of the holy ones who continues to a future existence?”

The arhat immediately understood. He returned to Jambudvīpa and proclaimed this matter. Sanghanandi said: “Elder of great virtue, it must have been the bodhisattva Maitreya who explained this to you, and only then did you understand.”

Such were his wisdom, supernormal powers, and transformations; the beings he saved were beyond measure.

When he had completed all that he needed to do and was about to relinquish his body, he went beneath a certain tree, grasped a branch with his hand, and then immediately gave up his life, his body remaining supported by the tree. The arhats wished to move his remains to a level place and pile up firewood for the cremation. But his body was like Mount Sumeru, utterly immovable. Though they exhausted their supernormal powers, there was no change. They then employed great white elephants, combining their strength to push, but they could not

move it even the distance of a mustard seed. Thereupon they heaped fragrant wood around the spot and cremated him where he was. The fire blazed fiercely and burned the body completely, yet the tree grew even more luxuriant, with not the slightest withering or damage.

The assembly all witnessed this and exclaimed that it was unprecedented. They collected the relics and built a stūpa for offerings.

Sanghayaśas

After Sanghanandi had relinquished his body, there was an arhat named Sanghayaśas who next received the entrustment and disseminated the Dharma eye, broadly transforming sentient beings and relieving them of all suffering and distress. He possessed great wisdom, and his speech was pure and eloquent.

In former times, although he had left the household life, he had not yet realized the marks of the Path. He traveled along the shore of the great ocean and saw a palace adorned with the seven treasures, radiant and magnificent.

[320b] Sanghayaśas, seeing that the time had come, went to that palace and spoke a gāthā to beg for food:

Hunger is the foremost disease;
The conditioned is the foremost suffering.
One who thus knows the Dharma
May attain the path of nirvāṇa.

At that time the master of the house came out to welcome him, spread out cushions and mats, and invited him in to take his seat.

Sanghayaśas saw within the household two hungry ghosts, naked, black, and emaciated, famished and weak. Their bodies and heads were bound in chains, and each was fastened to a bed. There was also a bowl filled with fragrant rice and a pitcher of water placed beside them.

The master of the house then took this food and offered it to the bhikṣu, saying: “Elder of great virtue, be sure not to give any food to these hungry ghosts.”

At that time, the bhikṣu, seeing their hunger and distress, gave them a little rice. When the ghosts obtained the food, they immediately vomited pus and blood that flowed all over the ground, defiling the palace.

The bhikṣu, astonished, asked: “What cause brought about such karmic retribution for these ghosts?”

The master of the house replied: “In their previous lives, one was my son and the other was my son’s wife. In the past I practiced giving and performed various meritorious deeds, but that husband and wife constantly harbored resentment and stinginess. I repeatedly instructed them, but they would not accept my counsel. I then made a vow, saying: ‘Such sinful karma will certainly bring evil retribution. When you receive your punishment, I shall come to watch you.’ It is because of these causes and conditions that they suffer this anguish.”

Traveling a little further, he came to another dwelling. The halls and pavilions were magnificently adorned with all manner of wonders. The place was filled with monks who were practicing walking meditation and seated meditation. When the time for the midday meal arrived, the wooden block was struck to assemble for food. Just as the meal was about to end, the delicacies suddenly transformed into pus and blood. The monks then struck each other with their bowls and vessels, breaking their heads and faces, blood flowing and staining their bodies. They cried out: “Why did we begrudge our food, only to suffer like this now?”

Sanghayaśas went forward and asked them the reason. They replied: “Elder, in our previous lives, during the time of Kāśyapa Buddha, we all dwelt together in one place. When visiting bhikṣus came, we all became angry and hid our food and drink, refusing to share with them. Because of these causes and conditions, we now suffer like this.”

In this manner, the venerable Sanghayaśas traveled throughout the great ocean, observing everywhere. He saw that there were altogether five hundred hells. He then gave rise to profound revulsion and deeply deplored the three realms of existence. He rebuked the five desires and was filled with great fear. He then reflected: “Karma created in this world is never destroyed. Like a shadow following a form, who can escape it? I should now seek the means to gain release.”

He contemplated with utmost sincerity and attained the arhat’s Path: the six supernormal powers without obstruction, and the three kinds of clear knowledge in perfect lucidity.

In a certain mountain forest there were five hundred sages diligently practicing austerities, hoping for the merit of rebirth in the Brahmā

heaven. Sanghayaśas went to them and spoke three gāthās praising the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha. All five hundred sages attained the marks of the Path.

[320c]

Thus did the venerable one broadly perform the Buddha's work. When his teaching activities were complete, he entered nirvāṇa. His relics were collected and a stūpa was built for offerings.

Kumārata

Before Sanghayaśas passed away, he entrusted the Dharma to Kumārata, telling him: "The Buddha entrusted the true Dharma to Mahākāśyapa, and thus in succession it has come down to me. I am about to enter nirvāṇa and now transmit it to you. You should, with your whole heart, diligently guard and protect it."

Kumārata replied: "I accept your teaching."

Thereupon he in turn proclaimed the deep treasury of the Dharma. His merit was profoundly deep and far-reaching. He had generated great, vast vows and practiced the bodhisattva path. His wisdom and eloquence were like the great ocean. From a young age he was famous, and the people of his country revered him.

Kumārata, rendered in Chinese, means "Youth." From a young age he bore a fine name. For what reason was he called "Fine Name"?

There was a wealthy elder who, on account of some affair, was going on a journey. He entrusted two jars of gold to a close friend: one jar was large and the other was small. He said to his friend: "I am about to travel abroad and leave these in your keeping. If my son desires them, you must give them to him."

Later, the elder's son went to the friend to claim the gold. The friend at that time returned to him only the smaller jar. The son became angry and refused to accept it. They then took the matter together to a magistrate's court. The son fully stated the circumstances and sought a ruling. The assembled magistrates were unable to settle the case.

At that time Kumārata was still a child, playing by the roadside. When he heard the sound of the dispute, he immediately said: "The son has already obtained his gold; why labor over this bitter contention? His father's original words were 'according to the son's desire.' Since he now desires the larger one, by right it belongs to him."

The magistrates then adopted his reasoning. Thereupon his fame spread far and wide, and he came to be called “the Youth of Fine Name.”

He left the household life to study the Way, and his talent and wisdom surpassed the world. When he arrived in a certain kingdom, the people were exceedingly stubborn and obstinate. Though they heard the Dharma teaching, they would not accept it on faith.

Kumārata said to them: “You may now assemble ten thousand cavalry with iron-clad horses and have riders mount them and pass before me in succession.”

They followed his instruction and prepared them accordingly. After Kumārata observed them in a single glance, he was able to distinguish completely every rider’s name, every horse’s color, and every detail of their clothing and appearance. He proclaimed all of this without a single error. The people of that kingdom then at last believed and submitted.

He composed various sūtras and treatises and traveled throughout the world to teach. When all that he needed to accomplish was done, he relinquished his life. [321a]

Jayata

When Kumārata was about to die, he told a bhikṣu named Jayata: “Elder, you should know this: just as a person crossing the ocean must rely on a boat or raft, so too must sentient beings who wish to leave the three realms cultivate wholesome dharmas before they can escape. Therefore I now wish to entrust the Dharma to you. You should study and practice it well, for the benefit of humans and devas.”

Jayata said: “Excellent! I accept your teaching.”

He then expounded the profound Dharma and broadly transformed the world.

Jayata possessed great merit. He was vigorous and courageous, diligently practicing austerities. He upheld the precepts with perfect discipline, without the slightest lapse. The World-Honored One had prophesied him as the last great Vinaya master.

Once within the assembly there was a bhikṣu whose elder brother’s wife came to the monastery bringing food for him. His fires of lust blazed fiercely, and they engaged in sexual intercourse. After committing this grave violation of the precepts, he immediately felt

remorse and was overcome with shame: “I am profoundly foolish to have committed such evil karma. I am surely no longer a śramaṇa or disciple of the Buddha.” He placed all his robes and bowl upon a three-pronged staff and wandered from place to place, crying out in a loud voice: “I am a sinner! I should no longer wear the dyed robes of the Buddha-Dharma. Since my offense is so grave, I will surely fall into hell. Where can I find rescue and protection?”

Jayata said to the bhikṣu: “If you can follow my words, I shall cause your sins to be swiftly eliminated.”

The bhikṣu joyfully replied: “I accept your teaching.”

Jayata then, through his supernormal powers, conjured a fire pit with fierce, raging flames, and commanded this bhikṣu to throw himself into it. At that time the bhikṣu, in order to extinguish his sins, leaped with his entire body into the great fire pit. At that moment, the fierce flames transformed into a clear, cool stream that reached only to his knees, causing him no harm whatsoever.

Jayata then told the bhikṣu: “Through your wholesome mind and sincere repentance, all your sins are now completely destroyed.” He then taught him the Dharma, and the bhikṣu attained the arhat’s Path.

Because of this, the world acclaimed Jayata as “the Pure Upholder of the Vinaya.”

On another occasion, he was traveling with his disciples to the city of Taxila. When they arrived at the city, Jayata’s expression became sorrowful and his brow furrowed. His disciples, puzzled and concerned, asked their teacher the reason.

He answered: “Wait for now. I will explain later.”

[321b]

They traveled a little further and on the road saw a crow. At that moment the venerable one broke into a gentle smile. The disciples again addressed their teacher: “We humbly beg your compassion; please explain the causes and conditions.”

Jayata then told the assembly: “When I first reached the city, at the gate below I saw a hungry ghost’s child, starving, emaciated, and exhausted. He addressed me, saying: ‘After my mother gave birth to me, she entered the city to seek food. Since we parted, five hundred years have passed. I am famished and destitute, and my life will not last much

longer. If, Venerable One, you should see my mother when you enter the city, please describe to her in full my suffering and hardship.’

“When I entered the city, I immediately found his mother and described to her in full her son’s hunger and deprivation. The ghost mother then addressed me: ‘Since I entered this city, five hundred years have passed, and I have never been able to obtain even a single person’s spittle. Why is this? Having just given birth, I am weak and feeble. Even if I manage to obtain a little spittle, it is snatched away by other ghosts and spirits. Only today did I happen upon a person’s spittle, with no other ghosts nearby, and I managed to obtain it. I wish to go outside the city to share this food with my child, but at the gate there are many powerful ghosts and spirits. Fearing they would seize it from me, I dare not go out. I humbly beg the Venerable One to have mercy and compassion; please take me out of the city so I may see my child.’

“At that time I took this ghost mother out of the city and had her share the food with her child. I then asked her: ‘How long has it been since you were born?’

“The ghost replied: ‘I have seen this city destroyed and rebuilt seven times. When the kingdom was prosperous and flourishing, with a thriving population, I have also seen it devastated and annihilated, with nothing remaining.’

“When I heard her words, I deeply lamented that the sufferings of birth and death are so long and distant, without limit or end. It was for this reason that my expression became sorrowful and my brow furrowed.”

“As for the crow, listen well and I shall explain. In the distant past, ninety-one kalpas ago, when the Buddha Vipasyin was in the world teaching, I was at that time the son of a wealthy elder. I was weary of the five desires and constantly wished to leave the household life. If I had become a śramaṇa at that time, I would certainly have severed all fetters and attained the arhat’s Path. But my parents would not grant my wish and insisted on arranging a marriage for me in order to obstruct my resolve.

“I did not disobey their command and so took a wife. After the marriage, I again wished to leave the household life. My parents said:

‘We arranged this marriage precisely so that you would produce an heir. If you have one son, we will release you.’

“I accepted their instruction and completed the marriage. A son was born. When the boy reached the age of six, my parents instructed the child: ‘If your father goes out intending to become a śramaṇa, you must embrace his feet and say to him: Father, if you abandon me, who will care for me and keep me alive? Kill me first, and then you may go.’

“The child did as his parents taught him, weeping and clinging to me with the deepest grief and longing. At that time, my heart was stained with love and attachment, and I said to the child: ‘For your sake I shall remain and will not leave the household life.’

“Because of that child, I failed to attain realization. For ninety-one kalpas I have wandered through birth and death, circling through the five paths of existence, and never once have I seen him. Now, with my eye of the Way, I observe that crow and see that it is the very son I fathered in that previous life. I am moved with pity for his foolish ignorance and his long dwelling in the cycle of birth and death. It is for this reason that I smiled.”

Thus did the venerable one skillfully teach the essential Dharma. With the power of his eloquence he traveled and taught throughout the world. When all that he needed to accomplish was done, he entered parinirvāṇa.

Vasubandhu

When the venerable Jayata was about to pass away, he told a bhikṣu named Vasubandhu: “Listen well now. In the past, the Teacher of gods and humans, through immeasurable kalpas of diligent practice and austerity, sought the supreme and wondrous Dharma. Now it has been brought to fulfillment for the benefit and peace of sentient beings. I received this entrustment and have guarded it with my whole heart. Now I wish to entrust it to you; you should deeply keep it in mind.”

[321c] Vasubandhu replied: “I accept your teaching.”

From that time on he propagated the sūtra treasury. Through the power of his great learning, wisdom, and eloquence, he adorned himself with such merits. He skillfully comprehended the meaning of all the sūtras, distinguishing and expounding them, and broadly transforming

sentient beings. When all that he needed to accomplish was done, he relinquished his life.

Manorhita

He next entrusted the Dharma to a bhikṣu named Manorhita, commanding him to disseminate the unsurpassed, supreme Dharma.

Manorhita's wisdom was transcendent. He was of few desires and content with little, diligently practicing austerities. His words were essential and wondrous, pleasing to the hearts of all. He was thoroughly versed in the meaning of the Tripiṭaka and brought great benefit in South India.

At that time there was a venerable one called Yaśas, whose eloquent wisdom was keen and perspicacious, profoundly deep and broadly learned. His merit was equal to that of Manorhita, and he too could comprehend the meaning of the Tripiṭaka. His fame spread everywhere, and all people revered him.

Once, Manorhita traveled to North India. The venerable Yaśas said to him: "In the two Indian kingdoms south of the Ganges, the people harbor many wrong views, yet they are clever, eloquent, and sharp-witted. Since you, Elder, are well versed in phonetics and grammar, you may travel in those lands to teach and transform them. I shall remain here to benefit sentient beings."

Manorhita then followed his counsel and went to those two kingdoms. He widely proclaimed the treatise of Vīra on no-self and vanquished all the wrong views of heterodox paths. When his work was complete, he relinquished his body and passed away.

Haklenayaśas and Siṃha Bhikṣu

After that, in succession, the venerable Haklenayaśas appeared in the world. He received the entrusted Dharma and broadly proclaimed and disseminated it. His merit was deep and far-reaching, and his talent was brilliant and profoundly learned. He transformed the deluded of the world and guided them onto the true path. When all that he needed to accomplish was done, he afterward relinquished his body.

There was also a bhikṣu named Siṃha, who in the kingdom of Kaśmīr performed great works for the Buddha's cause. At that time the king of that country was named Mihirakula. His wrong views blazed fiercely, and his heart was devoid of reverence and faith. In the kingdom of Kaśmīr he destroyed stūpas and monasteries and slaughtered the monks. With a sharp sword he beheaded Siṃha. From his neck flowed no blood, only milk.

The lineage of those who received and transmitted the Dharma was thereby severed.

Epilogue

This Dharma is a great bright lamp, able to illuminate the darkness of ignorance in the world. Therefore all the sages and holy ones described above together bore it upon the crown of their heads, received, upheld, and guarded it, entrusting it to one another in succession, constantly turning the wheel of the Dharma, and bringing great benefit to all sentient beings. They blocked the paths of evil and opened the road to the human and heavenly realms.

When at last the final age arrived, this Dharma declined and perished. The sages and holy ones vanished into obscurity, and none could uphold it. The world fell into darkness, and the great light was forever lost. Beings committed evil deeds and practiced the ten unwholesome actions. At the end of their lives, most fell into the three evil destinies and the eight difficulties.

[322a]

Therefore the wise should observe and consider that the unsurpassed, supreme Dharma possesses great merit, subtle, profound, and inconceivable. Just as a merchant wishing to cross the great ocean must board a ship to reach the other shore, so too all sentient beings who wish to escape the great ocean of birth and death in the three realms must rely on the ship of the Dharma to attain liberation.

The Dharma is cooling and removes the fever of afflictions. The Dharma is a wondrous medicine that cures the disease of the fetters. It is the true good spiritual friend of sentient beings, bringing great benefit and relieving all suffering and distress.

Why is this? The nature of all sentient beings has no fixed character. According to what they become accustomed to through habitual

association, they give rise to wholesome or unwholesome karma. If there are those who associate with the wrong views of non-Buddhist paths and receive their instruction, they will wander endlessly in saṃsāra without limit. Such teachers cannot be called good spiritual friends.

If there are those who can give rise to a mind of faith and reverence, draw near to sages and holy ones, and listen to and receive the wondrous Dharma, then through the merit and causes of hearing this Dharma, they will emerge from the mire of desire and receive the most excellent joy. Therefore such a person is called a good spiritual friend. One should diligently draw near to them and make offerings, for they are certain to free one from the suffering of the three evil destinies.

In ancient times, the king of the kingdom of Pāṭaliputra had a white elephant of great strength and bravery, capable of defeating enemies. Whenever there were criminals, the elephant was made to trample them to death. Later, the elephant's stable was destroyed by fire, and the elephant was moved to another location near a monastery. There it heard a bhikṣu reciting the Dharmapada:

“By doing good one is born in heaven; by doing evil one falls into the abyss.”

The elephant's mind became gentle, and it gave rise to thoughts of loving-kindness and compassion. Thereafter, when criminals were brought before it, it would not kill them at all, but merely sniffed them with its trunk, licked them, and walked away.

When the king saw this, he was greatly alarmed. He summoned his wise ministers to discuss the matter. One minister addressed the king: “The elephant's enclosure is near the monastery. It must have heard the wondrous Dharma, and that is why it has changed. You should now move it and tie it near the slaughterhouse. When it witnesses the killing, its ferocious mind will return.”

The king followed this plan and had the elephant tethered at the slaughterhouse. When the elephant saw the slaughtering, the flaying of hides, and the cutting of flesh, its vicious mind grew fierce, and its cruelty increased all the more.

From this one should know that the nature of sentient beings is not fixed. Why? Even an animal, upon hearing the Dharma, gives rise to compassion; yet upon witnessing slaughter, it becomes cruel. How much

more so for human beings, who are likewise influenced by their associations and give rise to wholesome or unwholesome karma.

Therefore the wise should understand that wrong views and evil teachings cause great harm. Cast them aside and distance yourself from them. Diligently apply skillful means, draw near to the holy Dharma, receive and uphold it, disseminate it, and regard it with the reverence due a great teacher. Through these subtle and wondrous merits and causes, one will forever transcend the suffering of the three evil destinies, cross the ocean of birth and death, and receive the joy of nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, this Dharma is the complete cause and condition for attaining the benefit of the Way. Therefore it is also called a true good spiritual friend.

In the past, Ānanda addressed the Buddha, saying: “World-Honored One, a good spiritual friend constitutes half the cause and condition for attaining the benefit of the Way.”

[322b]

The Buddha replied: “It is not so. A good spiritual friend constitutes the complete cause and condition for attaining the Way. Ānanda, you should know that in this Jambudvīpa, apart from Mahākāśyapa, Śāriputra, and the others, if the remaining sentient beings had not encountered me, they would have continued to wander endlessly, with no opportunity for liberation. Therefore I say that a good spiritual friend brings the greatest benefit.”

For these reasons, one should know that the Buddha-Dharma is the most honored and the most wondrous, unsurpassed, accomplished through immeasurable merit.

Therefore, when the World-Honored One first attained true enlightenment, seated upright beneath the King of Trees in contemplation, he reflected: “If in all the world there were no parents, teachers, or elders, and one were alone, solitary, and exposed, with nothing whatsoever to rely upon, upon whom should I depend and take my stand?”

He then reflected further: “All Buddhas of the past, the future, and the present have each taken the supreme Dharma as their teacher and guide. I too should, like the Buddhas of the three times, take the profound and wondrous supreme Dharma as my teacher.”

For this reason, the Buddha always revered this wondrous Dharma with the utmost sincerity, paying homage and diligently guarding and protecting it.

One should know that this Dharma is exceedingly rare. Therefore the wise should receive and uphold it.

Furthermore, in ancient times there was a Brahmin who possessed a great many human skulls. He went to the city of Pāṭaliputra and went about hawking them everywhere. After a long time, not a single person would buy them. He became extremely angry and cried out in a loud voice: “If the people of this city do not buy skulls from me, I shall spread an evil reputation about you, saying: ‘All of you people are foolish and dull-witted;’”

At that time the upāsakas of the city, hearing these words and fearing his slander, brought money and goods to purchase the skulls. They used a copper probe to pierce through the ear of each skull. For those that could be pierced all the way through, they paid a high price. For those that were only halfway pierced through, they paid less. For those that could not be pierced through at all, they paid nothing.

The Brahmin asked the upāsakas: “These skulls of mine are all the same. Why do you pay such different prices?”

The upāsakas replied: “The skulls that can be pierced all the way through belonged to people who, during their lifetimes, listened to and received the wondrous Dharma. Their wisdom was lofty and excellent. We value them this highly and therefore pay a great price. Those that are only halfway pierced through belonged to people who heard the wondrous Dharma but did not fully distinguish and understand it. For this reason we pay you less. Those that cannot be pierced through at all belonged to people who in their past lives never listened to the Dharma at all. That is why we pay nothing for them.”

The upāsakas then took these skulls outside the city and built a stūpa to make offerings to them. When they died, they were all reborn in heaven.

From these causes and conditions one should know that the wondrous Dharma possesses great merit and is able to elevate people. Why? These upāsakas, merely by building a stūpa from the skulls of those who had listened to the Dharma, were reborn in heaven. How much more so for

those who, with their whole heart, listen to and receive this Dharma, make offerings and pay reverence, and serve those who uphold the sūtras! The merit of such a person is exceedingly difficult to exhaust. In the future they will certainly attain the unsurpassed Way.

Therefore, all those who wish to obtain the unsurpassed peace, security, and joy, and who wish to transform sentient beings and bring them great benefit, should receive and uphold this supreme Dharma.

Glossary

Abhidharma (阿毘曇; Skt. *abhidharma*): The systematic philosophical and psychological analysis of the Buddha's teachings. One of the three divisions of the Buddhist canon (Tripiṭaka), compiled at the First Council by Mahākāśyapa. *See also* Tripiṭaka; Vinaya.

Ajātaśatru (阿闍世; Skt. *Ajātaśatru*): King of Magadha and son of Bimbisāra. A devoted supporter of the Buddha and of Mahākāśyapa after the Buddha's parinirvāṇa. His deep faith in the Three Treasures is likened to a great ocean. *See also* Rājagṛha; Mahākāśyapa.

Ānanda (阿難; Skt. *Ānanda*): The Buddha's cousin and personal attendant for the last twenty-five years of his life. Second patriarch of the Indian lineage. Known for his prodigious memory, he recited all the sūtras at the First Council after the Buddha's parinirvāṇa. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; First Council.

Aniruddha (阿那律; Skt. *Aniruddha*): One of the Buddha's principal disciples, foremost in divine vision. At the First Council, he confirmed which arhats were present and which were absent. *See also* First Council.

arhat (阿羅漢; Skt. *arhat*): "Worthy one." One who has attained the highest stage of the Hīnayāna path, completely freed from the cycle of birth and death. The twenty-three patriarchs all attained arhatship. *See also* nirvāṇa; four fruits.

Āryadeva (迦那提婆; Skt. *Āryadeva*): Fourteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. Born into a South Indian Brahmin family, he was also known as Kāṇadeva ("one-eyed Deva") because he offered his eye to the deity Maheśvara. A brilliant debater who composed the *Śataśāstra* (Hundred Verses Treatise), he was assassinated by a resentful student of a defeated non-Buddhist teacher. *See also* Nāgārjuna; Rāhulata.

Aśoka (阿恕伽; Skt. *Aśoka*): The great Mauryan emperor who ruled from Pāṭaliputra approximately one hundred years after the Buddha's

parinirvāṇa. He distributed the Buddha's relics and built eighty-four thousand stūpas. A devoted patron of the saṅgha, he was guided by Upagupta. *See also* Upagupta; Pāṭaliputra; stūpa.

Aśvaghōṣa (馬鳴; Skt. *Aśvaghōṣa*): Eleventh patriarch of the Indian lineage. A brilliant poet and philosopher from Pāṭaliputra who initially challenged the Dharma but was converted by Pārśva. He composed the musical work *Rāṣṭrapāla* to teach the doctrine of emptiness and no-self, and served as spiritual advisor to King Kanīṣka. *See also* Pārśva; Kanīṣka; Pāṭaliputra.

Bakkula (薄拘羅; Skt. *Bakkula*): An arhat who lived to one hundred sixty years without ever falling ill, due to past-life merit from offering medicine. As a child he miraculously survived being placed in an oven, a cauldron, thrown into a river, and swallowed by a fish. He was of few desires and never taught even a single verse. *See also* Aśoka.

Bhagavat (婆伽婆; Skt. *Bhagavat*): “Blessed One” or “World-Honored One.” An epithet of the Buddha Śākyamuni. *See also* World-Honored One.

Bimbisāra (瓶沙王; Skt. *Bimbisāra*): King of Magadha and father of Ajātaśatru. A supporter of the Buddha during his lifetime who possessed great wealth, including a thousand golden plows. *See also* Ajātaśatru; Magadha.

bodhi tree (菩提樹; Skt. *bodhivṛkṣa*): The tree under which the Buddha attained supreme, perfect enlightenment. Aśoka irrigated the tree with fragrant water and established a great assembly there. *See also* enlightenment.

bodhisattva (菩薩; Skt. *bodhisattva*): A being who aspires to attain Buddhahood for the benefit of all sentient beings. In this text, Nāgārjuna and Āryadeva are referred to as bodhisattvas who practiced the bodhisattva path. *See also* Mahāyāna.

Brahmā (梵天/梵王; Skt. *Brahmā*): The deity presiding over the Brahma heaven. Brahmā advised Māra to seek Upagupta's forgiveness and instructed a heavenly being to take rebirth as Mahākāśyapa. *See also* Māra; Mahākāśyapa.

- Buddha** (佛; Skt. *Buddha*): “Awakened One.” The historical Buddha Śākyamuni, who attained supreme, perfect enlightenment under the bodhi tree and established the Dharma that was transmitted through the twenty-three patriarchs.
- Buddhamitra** (佛陀蜜多; Skt. *Buddhamitra*): Eighth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He converted a powerful king from wrong views, defeated non-Buddhist teachers in debate through his wisdom, and transmitted the Dharma to Pārśva. *See also* Buddhanandin; Pārśva.
- Buddhanandin** (佛陀難提; Skt. *Buddhanandin*): Seventh patriarch of the Indian lineage. He received the Dharma treasury from Micchaka and transmitted it to Buddhamitra. *See also* Micchaka; Buddhamitra.
- Caraka** (遮勒; Skt. *Caraka*): A renowned physician known for his medical skill and compassion. He advised King Kaṇṣka on health matters and eventually renounced worldly life to become a monk. *See also* Kaṇṣka.
- cremation** (闍毘/耶旬; Skt. *jhāpita*): The ritual burning of the body after death. The text describes the cremation of the Buddha and of numerous patriarchs, typically accompanied by the collection of relics and construction of stūpas. *See also* relics; stūpa.
- Deer Park** (鹿野苑; Skt. *Mṛgadāva*): The park at Vārāṇasī where the Buddha first turned the wheel of the Dharma, teaching the Four Noble Truths to the five monks. *See also* Four Noble Truths; Vārāṇasī.
- Dharma eye** (法眼; Skt. *dharmacakṣus*): The eye of the Dharma; the true teaching of the Buddha that enables beings to see reality clearly. The patriarchs transmit the “Dharma eye” from one to the next. *See also* Dharma treasury.
- Dharma treasury** (法藏; Skt. *dharmakośa*): The collected teachings of the Buddha, entrusted from master to disciple in an unbroken lineage. The title of the text refers to this transmission. *See also* Dharma eye.
- Dharmamitra** (達摩蜜多; Skt. *Dharmamitra*): A meditation master of great renown in Kaśmīr. Despite his fame, he humbly served the saṅgha by tending the kitchen fire, remembering the sufferings of his

past lives as a dog. He was consulted by King Kaniṣka. *See also* Kaśmīr; Kaniṣka.

Dhṛtaka (提多迦; Skt. *Dhṛtaka*): Fifth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He received the Dharma treasury from Upagupta. At his ordination, he progressed through all four stages of the path during the three announcements of the ordination ceremony. *See also* Upagupta; Micchaka.

Dīpaṃkara Buddha (定光如來; Skt. *Dīpaṃkara*): A past Buddha in whose time Ānanda, as a novice, served his teacher with great diligence, and a layman who provided food was reborn as Ānanda in a later life.

eight liberations (八解脫; Skt. *aṣṭa vimokṣa*): Eight stages of meditative liberation through which practitioners progressively free themselves from attachment to form and the formless realms.

eighteen transformations (十八變; Skt. *aṣṭādaśa vikurvāṇāni*): A set of miraculous powers displayed by arhats, including rising into the air, emitting fire and water from the body, and manifesting various forms. Multiple patriarchs perform these transformations before entering parinirvāṇa.

eighty minor marks (八十種好; Skt. *aśīty anuvyañjanāni*): Eighty secondary physical characteristics of a Buddha, supplementing the thirty-two major marks. *See also* thirty-two marks.

emptiness (空; Skt. *sūnyatā*): The Mahāyāna teaching that all phenomena lack inherent, independent existence. A central doctrine in Nāgārjuna's *Madhyamaka-śāstra* and a theme in Aśvaghoṣa's compositions. *See also* Nāgārjuna; no-self.

enlightenment (菩提/正覺; Skt. *bodhi*): Supreme, perfect awakening attained by the Buddha under the bodhi tree, and the goal of Buddhist practice. *See also* bodhi tree.

First Council (集法藏; Skt. *prathamasaṅgīti*): The assembly convened at the Pippala Cave in Rājagṛha shortly after the Buddha's parinirvāṇa, where five hundred arhats compiled the Buddha's teachings. Ānanda recited the sūtras, Upāli recited the Vinaya, and

Mahākāśyapa compiled the Abhidharma. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; Ānanda; Upāli; Rājagṛha.

five aggregates (五陰; Skt. *pañcaskandha*): The five components of psychophysical existence: form, feeling, perception, mental formations, and consciousness. All conditioned phenomena, including personal identity, arise from their combination. *See also* no-self.

four fruits (四果; Skt. *catvāri phalāni*): The four stages of the path to arhatship: stream-enterer (*srota-āpanna*), once-returner (*sakṛdāgāmin*), non-returner (*anāgāmin*), and arhat. *See also* arhat; stream-enterer.

Four Noble Truths (四聖諦; Skt. *catvāri āryasatyāni*): The foundational teaching of the Buddha: the truth of suffering, the truth of the origin of suffering, the truth of the cessation of suffering, and the truth of the path leading to cessation. The first teaching given at Deer Park to the five monks. *See also* Deer Park.

Gandhāra (乾陀越國; Skt. *Gandhāra*): An ancient kingdom in northwestern India (modern Pakistan/Afghanistan). One of Upagupta's disciples was sent there and attained arhatship. *See also* Upagupta.

Gavāṃpati (憍梵波提; Skt. *Gavāṃpati*): An arhat who resided in the Śrīṣa Palace. When informed of the Buddha's parinirvāṇa and the convening of the First Council, he chose to enter nirvāṇa rather than return. *See also* First Council.

Gṛdhrakūṭa (耆闍崛山; Skt. *Gṛdhrakūṭa*): Vulture Peak, a mountain near Rājagṛha where the Buddha frequently taught and where Mahākāśyapa practiced meditation. *See also* Rājagṛha; Mahākāśyapa.

Haklenayaśas (鶴勒那夜奢; Skt. *Haklenayaśas*): Twenty-second patriarch of the Indian lineage. He appeared in the world after Manorhita, received the entrusted Dharma, and broadly disseminated it before passing the transmission to Siṃha. The Chinese text writes his name in two parts (鶴勒那 and 夜奢), which some scholars have read as two separate figures. *See also* Manorhita; Siṃha.

Hīnayāna (小乘; Skt. *Hīnayāna*): “Lesser Vehicle.” A term used by Mahāyāna Buddhists to refer to schools that emphasize individual liberation and the arhat ideal, as distinct from the bodhisattva path. *See also* Mahāyāna; arhat.

impermanence (無常; Skt. *anitya*): One of the three marks of existence. The text repeatedly emphasizes that all conditioned phenomena, including wealth, beauty, royal power, and even the bodies of saints, are subject to decay and dissolution.

Indra (帝釋/釋提桓因; Skt. *Śakra Devānām Indra*): Lord of the Trāyastriṃśa Heaven, who paid respects to Mahākāśyapa before his parinirvāṇa and offered flowers and incense at the passings of great saints. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; Trāyastriṃśa.

Jambudvīpa (閻浮提; Skt. *Jambudvīpa*): The southern continent in Buddhist cosmology, identified with the human world. *See also* four continents.

Jāyata (闍夜多; Skt. *Jāyata*): Nineteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He was recorded by the Buddha as the last great Vinaya master. He excelled in administering the precepts and converting those who had committed grave offenses. *See also* Vasubandhu; Manorhita.

Kaṇiṣka (闍昵吒; Skt. *Kaṇiṣka*): King of the Kuṣāṇa empire. He received Aśvaghōṣa, the Buddha’s begging bowl, and a compassionate rooster as tribute worth nine hundred million gold coins. He was a patron of Buddhism and was spiritually guided by Aśvaghōṣa. *See also* Aśvaghōṣa.

karma (業; Skt. *karma*): Volitional action and its consequences. The text illustrates the workings of karma through numerous stories of past-life causes producing present-life effects, such as Kuṇāla’s blinding and Bakkula’s invulnerability.

Kaśmīr (闍賓; Skt. *Kaśmīra*): A region in northwestern India where the Buddha predicted the Dharma would flourish. Madhyāntika was prophesied to spread the Dharma there, and several patriarchs practiced in this region. *See also* Madhyāntika.

Kāśyapa Buddha (迦葉佛; Skt. *Kāśyapa Buddha*): A past Buddha, the sixth of the seven Buddhas of antiquity. Stories set during his dispensation appear as past-life narratives in the text.

Kauṇḍinya (憍陳如; Skt. *Kauṇḍinya*): One of the five monks to whom the Buddha first preached at Deer Park. He sought to become the Buddha's attendant but was declined due to his advanced age. *See also* Deer Park.

Krakucchanda Buddha (迦羅鳩孫佛; Skt. *Krakucchanda*): A past Buddha, the fourth of the seven Buddhas of antiquity. A king destroyed a jeweled stūpa of this Buddha, which a youth later restored, earning merit that led to rebirth in a noble family.

Kukkuṭapāda (雞足山; Skt. *Kukkuṭapāda*): “Rooster’s Foot Mountain.” The mountain where Mahākāśyapa entered meditative absorption to await the coming of Maitreya. The mountain opened for Ajātaśatru and Ānanda, then closed again. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; Maitreya; Ajātaśatru.

Kukkuṭārāma (雞頭末寺; Skt. *Kukkuṭārāma*): “Rooster Peak Monastery.” A prominent monastery associated with King Aśoka, where the elder Yaśas presided and where Aśoka made his final offerings. *See also* Aśoka; Yaśas.

Kumāralāta (鳩摩羅馱; Skt. *Kumāralāta*): Eighteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. His name means “beautiful name” (or “youth”), given because of his childhood display of wisdom in adjudicating a legal dispute. He composed treatises and traveled widely to teach. *See also* Jāyata.

Kuṇāla (拘那羅/駒那羅; Skt. *Kuṇāla*): Son of King Aśoka, named after a bird with beautiful eyes. His stepmother Tiṣyarakṣā had his eyes gouged out in revenge for his refusal of her advances. Through contemplation of the impermanence of the eyes, he attained the fruit of stream-entry. *See also* Aśoka; Tiṣyarakṣā.

Kuśinagara (拘尸那城; Skt. *Kuśinagara*): The city where the Buddha entered parinirvāṇa between twin śāla trees. *See also* parinirvāṇa.

- Lumbinī** (林微尼園; Skt. *Lumbinī*): The garden where the Buddha was born. Upagupta led King Aśoka to visit this and other sacred sites. *See also* Aśoka; Upagupta.
- Madhyāntika** (摩田提; Skt. *Madhyāntika*): A disciple to whom Ānanda entrusted the Dharma eye, prophesied by the Buddha to spread the teachings in Kaśmīr. *See also* Ānanda; Kaśmīr.
- Magadha** (摩竭國; Skt. *Magadha*): An ancient Indian kingdom in northeastern India, with its capital at Rājagṛha. The homeland of the Brahmin Nyagrodha, Mahākāśyapa's father. *See also* Rājagṛha.
- Mahākāśyapa** (摩訶迦葉; Skt. *Mahākāśyapa*): First patriarch of the Indian lineage. Born with a golden body due to past-life merit, he renounced worldly life with his wife and became the Buddha's foremost disciple in ascetic practice. He convened the First Council and entered meditative absorption at Kukkuṭapāda Mountain to await Maitreya. *See also* First Council; Kukkuṭapāda; Ānanda.
- Mahāyāna** (摩訶衍/大乘; Skt. *Mahāyāna*): “Great Vehicle.” The tradition of Buddhism emphasizing the bodhisattva path and universal liberation. Nāgārjuna received extensive Mahāyāna scriptures from the Nāga King's palace. *See also* bodhisattva; Nāgārjuna.
- Maheśvara** (大自在天; Skt. *Maheśvara*): “Great Lord.” A Hindu deity (Śiva) worshipped in a temple where Āryadeva removed the golden eye from the six-zhang statue to demonstrate that true divinity transcends material form. *See also* Āryadeva.
- Maitreya** (彌勒; Skt. *Maitreya*): The future Buddha, currently a bodhisattva in Tuṣita Heaven. Mahākāśyapa preserves his body at Kukkuṭapāda to display it to Maitreya's assembly, inspiring them to practice. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; Kukkuṭapāda.
- Manorhita** (摩奴羅; Skt. *Manorhita*): Twenty-first patriarch of the Indian lineage. He excelled in understanding the three divisions of the canon and spread the Dharma in southern India. He shared responsibilities with the elder Yaśas for teaching in different regions. *See also* Yaśas (patriarch); Haklena.

Māra (魔王波旬; Skt. *Māra Pāpīyas*): The Evil One, lord of the Desire Realm. He attempted to prevent the Buddha's enlightenment and later disrupted Upagupta's teaching assemblies, but was subdued by Upagupta through skillful means. *See also* Upagupta.

Māṭharī (摩倬羅; Skt. *Māṭharī*): A wise minister of King Kaniṣka who secretly organized military campaigns that brought three of the four seas under the king's dominion. *See also* Kaniṣka.

Mathurā (摩突羅; Skt. *Mathurā*): A city in northern India where the Buddha prophesied that Śāṇavāsa would build a monastery and Upagupta would teach. Several patriarchs were active there. *See also* Śāṇavāsa; Upagupta.

Māyā (摩耶; Skt. *Māyā*): Queen Māyā, the mother of Prince Siddhārtha (the future Buddha Śākyamuni). She is mentioned in the narrative paintings shown to King Ajātaśatru. *See also* Śuddhodana.

Micchaka (彌遮迦; Skt. *Micchaka*): Sixth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He received the Dharma treasury from Dhītika and transmitted it to Buddhanandin. *See also* Dhṛtaka; Buddhanandin.

Mihirakula (彌羅掘; Skt. *Mihirakula*): A king of Kaśmīr of wrong views who destroyed monasteries, killed monks, and beheaded the final patriarch, Siṃha. His persecution marked the end of the patriarchal lineage. *See also* Siṃha; Kaśmīr.

Nāga King (大龍/龍王; Skt. *Nāgarāja*): Supernatural serpent beings who guard treasures. In this text, the Nāga King brought Nāgārjuna to an undersea palace containing vast collections of Mahāyāna scriptures. Also, the Nāga King gave Śāṇavāsa's past-life incarnation a wish-fulfilling jewel. *See also* Nāgārjuna.

Nāgārjuna (龍樹; Skt. *Nāgārjuna*): Thirteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. Born in southern India to a Brahmin family, he was a prodigy who mastered the four Vedas as an infant. After youthful misadventures, he became a monk and received Mahāyāna scriptures from the Nāga King's palace under the ocean. He composed the *Madhyamaka-śāstra* and other seminal works, converted a southern Indian king, and defeated many non-Buddhist teachers in debate. *See also* Āryadeva; Mahāyāna.

nirvāṇa (涅槃; Skt. *nirvāṇa*): The cessation of suffering and liberation from the cycle of birth and death. Each patriarch enters nirvāṇa at the conclusion of his teaching career, after transmitting the Dharma to a successor. *See also* parinirvāṇa.

no-self (無我; Skt. *anātman*): The Buddhist teaching that there is no permanent, unchanging self or soul. One of the three marks of existence and a central theme in the debates and teachings of the patriarchs. *See also* five aggregates; emptiness.

Nyagrodha (尼俱律陀; Skt. *Nyagrodha*): A wealthy Brahmin of Magadha, father of Mahākāśyapa. His wealth surpassed even that of King Bimbisāra. *See also* Mahākāśyapa; Magadha.

parinirvāṇa (般涅槃; Skt. *parinirvāṇa*): The final passing of the Buddha or of an arhat, marking the complete and irreversible cessation of the cycle of birth and death. The text describes the parinirvāṇa of the Buddha at Kuśinagara and of each of the twenty-three patriarchs. *See also* nirvāṇa; Kuśinagara.

Pārśva (脇比丘; Skt. *Pārśva*): Ninth patriarch of the Indian lineage, known as “Rib Monk” because he never lay on his side to sleep. He spent sixty years in his mother’s womb and was born with white hair. He practiced extreme asceticism and transmitted the Dharma to Puṇyayaśas. *See also* Buddhmitra; Puṇyayaśas.

Pāṭaliputra (華氏城; Skt. *Pāṭaliputra*): The capital city of the Mauryan empire, where Aśoka ruled. Also the city where Aśvaghōṣa taught and composed the *Rāṣṭrapāla*. *See also* Aśoka; Aśvaghōṣa.

Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja (寶頭盧; Skt. *Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja*): An arhat commanded by the Buddha to remain in the world until the coming of Maitreya. He appeared at Aśoka’s great assembly, with white eyebrows and a dignified bearing, and testified to having seen the Buddha. *See also* Aśoka.

Pippala Cave (寶鉢羅窟; Skt. *Pippalaguha*): The cave near Rājagṛha where the First Council was held and where Mahākāśyapa practiced. *See also* First Council; Rājagṛha.

Puṇyayaśas (富那奢; Skt. *Puṇyayaśas*): Tenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He received the Dharma from Pārśva and transmitted it to Aśvaghōṣa, whom he converted through a demonstration of supernormal powers. *See also* Pārśva; Aśvaghōṣa.

Rādhagupta (羅提毬; Skt. *Rādhagupta*): A minister of King Aśoka, identified as the child who in a past life rejoiced when Aśoka (as the boy Jaya) offered earth to the Buddha. He counseled the dying Aśoka with teachings on impermanence. *See also* Aśoka.

Rāhulata (羅睺羅; Skt. *Rāhulata*): Fifteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage, not to be confused with the historical Rāhula (the Buddha's son). He received the Dharma from Āryadeva and was renowned for his ability to memorize teachings after hearing them only three times. *See also* Āryadeva; Saṅghanandi.

Rājagṛha (王舍城; Skt. *Rājagṛha*): The capital of Magadha, where the First Council was held at the Pippala Cave. Mahākāśyapa and Ānanda both dwelt and taught there. *See also* Magadha; First Council; Pippala Cave.

Rāṣṭrapāla (賴吒咄羅; Skt. *Rāṣṭrapāla*): A musical composition by Aśvaghōṣa that conveyed the Buddhist teachings of suffering, emptiness, and no-self through elegant melody. Five hundred princes who heard it renounced worldly life. *See also* Aśvaghōṣa.

relics (舍利; Skt. *śarīra*): The physical remains of the Buddha or of an arhat after cremation. The distribution and enshrinement of relics in stūpas is a central devotional act in the text. Aśoka distributed the Buddha's relics and built eighty-four thousand stūpas. *See also* stūpa; Aśoka; cremation.

Śākyamuni (釋迦如來; Skt. *Śākyamuni*): The historical Buddha, born as Prince Siddhārtha of the Śākya clan. The text narrates his life from birth through enlightenment and parinirvāṇa, and the subsequent transmission of his Dharma through twenty-three patriarchs. *See also* Buddha; World-Honored One.

Śāṇavāsa (商那和修; Skt. *Śāṇavāsa*): Third patriarch of the Indian lineage. Born wearing a garment of śāṇa (hemp cloth) that grew with his body and remained with him throughout his life. He built a

monastery at Mathurā on Mount Urumūṇḍa as the Buddha had prophesied, and transmitted the Dharma to Upagupta. *See also* Ānanda; Upagupta; Mathurā.

saṅgha (僧/眾僧; Skt. *saṅgha*): The community of Buddhist monks and nuns. One of the Three Treasures. The text describes the saṅgha's role in preserving and transmitting the Dharma. *See also* Three Treasures.

Saṅghanandi (僧伽難提; Skt. *Saṅghanandi*): Sixteenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He practiced the bodhisattva path with firm vows, surpassing the realms of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. After his passing, his body could not be moved even by great elephants until it was cremated in place, while the tree above remained unharmed. *See also* Rāhulata; Saṅghayaśas.

Saṅghayaśas (僧伽耶舍; Skt. *Saṅghayaśas*): Seventeenth patriarch of the Indian lineage. Before attaining arhatship, he traveled by the ocean and witnessed the sufferings of hungry ghosts and hell beings, which inspired him to intensify his practice. *See also* Saṅghanandi; Kumāralāta.

Siṃha (師子; Skt. *Siṃha*): Twenty-third and final patriarch of the Indian lineage. He was martyred by King Mihirakula (Mirakula) in Kaśmīr. When beheaded, no blood but only milk flowed from his neck, marking the end of the patriarchal transmission. *See also* Mihirakula; Kaśmīr.

six supernormal powers (六通; Skt. *ṣaḍ abhijñā*): Six transcendent abilities attained by arhats: the divine eye, divine ear, knowledge of others' minds, recollection of past lives, supernormal locomotion, and the extinction of defilements.

skillful means (方便; Skt. *upāya*): The adaptive methods used by Buddhas and accomplished teachers to guide sentient beings according to their capacities. Upagupta is especially celebrated for his ingenious use of skillful means in converting disciples. *See also* Upagupta.

śramaṇa (沙門; Skt. *śramaṇa*): A renunciant or ascetic. The term is used broadly for Buddhist monks and sometimes for non-Buddhist wanderers as well.

stream-enterer (須陀洹; Skt. *srota-āpanna*): One who has entered the stream leading to nirvāṇa by eliminating the first three fetters. The first of the four fruits. *See also* four fruits; arhat.

stūpa (塔/寶塔; Skt. *stūpa*): A reliquary mound or tower enshrining the relics of the Buddha or of a saint. Aśoka is said to have built eighty-four thousand stūpas. Construction of stūpas and offerings at them are frequently described as acts of great merit. *See also* relics; Aśoka.

Śuddhodana (白淨; Skt. *Śuddhodana*): King Śuddhodana, the father of Prince Siddhārtha. He is referred to as “White Pure” (白淨) in the Chinese text. *See also* Māyā.

Śūdra (宿駄吒; Skt. *unknown*): Aśoka’s younger brother, originally of wrong views, who was converted by skillful means and ordained as a monk. He attained arhatship but was later killed by a member of the Qiang people due to past-life karma. *See also* Aśoka.

sūtra (修多羅/經; Skt. *sūtra*): A discourse of the Buddha. At the First Council, Ānanda was appointed to recite the sūtras from memory, beginning with “Thus have I heard.” *See also* Ānanda; First Council; Tripiṭaka.

Tathāgata (如來; Skt. *Tathāgata*): “Thus Come One.” An epithet of the Buddha, emphasizing his arrival at and departure from the truth. Used frequently throughout the text as a title of respect for the Buddha. *See also* Buddha; World-Honored One.

Taxila (得叉尸羅; Skt. *Takṣaśilā*): An ancient city in northwestern India (modern Pakistan). Kuṇāla governed there when his eyes were gouged out on orders of Queen Tiṣyarakṣā. *See also* Kuṇāla; Tiṣyarakṣā.

thirty-two marks (三十二相; Skt. *dvātriṃśan mahāpuruṣalakṣaṇāni*): The thirty-two physical characteristics of a great being (*mahāpuruṣa*),

particularly of a Buddha. Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja described the Buddha as adorned with these marks. *See also* eighty minor marks.

three poisons (三毒; Skt. *triviṣa*): Greed, hatred, and delusion, the three root afflictions that keep beings bound to the cycle of birth and death.

Three Treasures (三寶; Skt. *triratna*): The Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Taking refuge in the Three Treasures is the foundational act of becoming a Buddhist. The text describes Aśoka and others as having attained unshakable faith in the Three Treasures. *See also* Buddha; Dharma treasury; saṅgha.

Tiṣyarakṣā (帝失羅叉; Skt. *Tiṣyarakṣā*): The chief queen of King Aśoka, who attempted to seduce prince Kuṇāla and, when rejected, had his eyes gouged out in revenge. She was ultimately executed by Aśoka. *See also* Kuṇāla; Aśoka.

Trāyastriṃśa (忉利天; Skt. *Trāyastriṃśa*): The Heaven of the Thirty-Three, presided over by Indra. Mahākāśyapa visited this heaven to pay respects to the Buddha's hair relic before entering parinirvāṇa. *See also* Indra.

Tripiṭaka (三藏; Skt. *Tripiṭaka*): “Three Baskets.” The Buddhist canon consisting of sūtras, Vinaya, and Abhidharma. The First Council organized the Buddha's teachings into these three collections. *See also* Abhidharma; Vinaya; sūtra.

turning the wheel of the Dharma (轉法輪; Skt. *dharmacakrapravartana*): A metaphor for the Buddha's teaching activity. The first turning occurred at Deer Park, and the wheel continues to turn through the lineage of patriarchs. *See also* Deer Park; Four Noble Truths.

Tuṣita (兜率天; Skt. *Tuṣita*): The heavenly realm where Maitreya currently resides, awaiting the time to descend and become the next Buddha. *See also* Maitreya.

Upagupta (憂波鞠多; Skt. *Upagupta*): Fourth patriarch of the Indian lineage. Acclaimed as “the Buddha without marks” for his prowess in meditation and converting beings, though he lacked the thirty-two physical marks of a Buddha. He was the Buddha's prophesied

teacher who would arise one hundred years after the parinirvāṇa, foremost in meditation, and he served as the spiritual guide of King Aśoka. Famous for subduing Māra with three corpses. *See also* Śāṇavāsa; Aśoka; Māra; Mathurā.

Upāli (優波離; Skt. *Upāli*): One of the Buddha's principal disciples, foremost in Vinaya. At the First Council, he was charged with compiling the Vinaya Piṭaka. *See also* First Council; Vinaya.

Urumūṇḍa (優留茶山; Skt. *Urumūṇḍa*): A mountain near Mathurā where the Buddha prophesied Śāṇavāsa would build a monastery. Śāṇavāsa subdued two nāga princes there before constructing the monastery. *See also* Śāṇavāsa; Mathurā.

Vaiśālī (毘舍離; Skt. *Vaiśālī*): An ancient city north of the Ganges. One quarter of Ānanda's relics was given to the people of Vaiśālī. *See also* Ānanda.

Vārāṇasī (波羅柁; Skt. *Vārāṇasī*): The city near which Deer Park is located, where the Buddha first taught the Dharma. *See also* Deer Park; Four Noble Truths.

Vasubandhu (婆修槃陀; Skt. *Vasubandhu*): Twentieth patriarch of the Indian lineage. He received the Dharma from Jāyata and was skilled in explaining the meaning of the sūtras. He transmitted the Dharma to Manorhita. Not to be confused with the later Vasubandhu of the Yogācāra school. *See also* Jāyata; Manorhita.

Vinaya (毘尼/毘尼藏; Skt. *Vinaya*): The monastic disciplinary code, one of the three divisions of the Buddhist canon. Upāli was charged with compiling it at the First Council. *See also* Upāli; Tripiṭaka.

Vipaśyin (毘婆尸佛; Skt. *Vipaśyin*): A past Buddha, the first of the seven Buddhas of antiquity. In the time of Vipaśyin, Mahākāśyapa and his wife made a vow together after repairing the golden image on a stūpa, resulting in ninety-one kalpas of golden bodies and heavenly rebirth. *See also* Mahākāśyapa.

Vīra (比羅; Skt. *Vīra*): The disciple to whom Aśvaghoṣa transmitted the Dharma before his passing. He later composed the *Nirātman-śāstra*

(Treatise on No-Self) in one hundred verses and transmitted the Dharma to Nāgārjuna. *See also* Aśvaghōṣa; Nāgārjuna.

wish-fulfilling jewel (如意珠; Skt. *cintāmaṇi*): A legendary jewel that grants all wishes. In a past life, Śāṇavāsa journeyed to the Nāga King's palace under the sea and obtained such a jewel, which he used to rain treasures upon Jambudvīpa. *See also* Śāṇavāsa; Nāga King.

World-Honored One (世尊; Skt. *Bhagavat*): The most common honorific for the Buddha Śākyamuni in Chinese Buddhist texts. *See also* Buddha; Tathāgata.

Yaśas (耶舍; Skt. *Yaśas*): The elder who presided at the Kukkuṭārāma monastery during Aśoka's time. He informed Aśoka about Upagupta and about the Buddha's prophecy regarding the distribution of relics. *See also* Aśoka; Kukkuṭārāma; Upagupta.

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